

DUSU polls: ABVP, NSUI, Left alliance in fray; 1,000 EVMs deployed

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

With polling for the Delhi University Students' Union (DUSU) elections scheduled for Friday, major student organisations, including the ABVP, NSUI and the AISA-SFI alliance, are gearing up for one of the most closely watched contests in student politics.

Voting will be held on Friday, with polling for day classes from 8.30 am to 1 pm and evening classes from 3 pm to 7.30 pm. Counting of votes is scheduled for September 19 at the Multipurpose Hall, University Sports Stadium, North Campus.

A total of 1,000 EVMs (Electronic Voting Machines) have been deployed, out of which 960 will be in use on Friday with 40 in reserve, according to university officials.

Chief Election Officer Raj Kishore Sharma said, "A total of 12 control rooms will be functional on Friday. In case

any of the EVMs glitch, experts will be available to readily fix them."

Sharma added that once the polls are concluded, the EVMs will be securely transported by police to the multipurpose hall, where they will be opened at the time of counting of votes on Saturday.

The contest for the four central panel posts, namely president, vice president, secretary and joint secretary, is expected to see an intense battle between the RSS-affiliated Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad (ABVP), Congress-backed National Students' Union of India (NSUI) and the Left alliance of the All India Students' Association (AISA) and Students' Federation of India (SFI).

The university has restricted vehicular movement on key stretches, including Chhatra Marg, Probyn Road and University Road, ahead of the election process, while student organisations are

taking their campaigns to classrooms, college campuses and social media.

According to an advisory issued by the university, traffic restrictions will be in place on Friday and Saturday, till the declaration of results.

In the 2025 election, the ABVP won three of the four central panel posts, including the president's position, while the NSUI secured the vice-president's post.

ABVP's Aryan Maan had won the president's post with 28,841 votes, while NSUI's Rahul Jhansla secured the vice-president's post with 29,339 votes. ABVP candidates Kunal Chaudhary and Deepika Jha became secretary and joint secretary, respectively, after defeating their opponents.

This year, ABVP has fielded Yash Dabas for president, Ishu Maurya for vice-president, Riya Chhawadi for secretary and Lakshya Raj Singh for joint secretary.

Dabas, who hails from Kanjhawala in Delhi, is pursu-



Students representing various groups campaign for their candidates ahead of the 'Delhi University Students' Union' ('DUSU') elections in New Delhi on Wednesday

PTI

ing studies in the Department of Buddhist Studies and is an international-level tennis player. He has participated in ITF competitions in Spain, Australia and Serbia, according to ABVP.

Maurya, a law student at

Campus Law Centre, has been associated with ABVP since 2021, while Chhawadi is a fourth-year BA Programme student at Sri Aurobindo College and an inter-college basketball player. Singh, also pursuing law at Campus Law

Centre, has represented India in handball at the Asian Games and World Championship, the organisation said.

The NSUI has nominated Vijay Shankar Meena for president, Vir Chatrath for vice-president, Namrata Chaudhary

DUSU campaign ends in violence, defacement charges and 4-0 boast

ABHINAV KUMAR JHA
■ New Delhi

Campus walls that once told the whole story of a DUSU election, thick with paste and printed faces, this year fell largely silent, even as the fight over who broke the rules, and who bled for it, grew louder than ever.

As campaigning for the Delhi University Students' Union polls closed ahead of Friday's vote, the contest wound down amid allegations of poster defacement, code violations, outside political interference, and a night of violence that has left both sides trading blame just hours before the ballot opens.

The Delhi High Court's involvement surfaced again this week when a bench hearing a plea challenging the participation of ABVP and NSUI-affiliated candidates flagged a separate concern, a social media post by a candidate belonging to the Aam Aadmi Party's student wing that allegedly displayed not just the party's name but its election symbol. The bench said such activity needed to be checked by university authorities and the Chief Election Officer, and made clear it expected full compliance with the Code of Conduct, the Lyngdoh



Committee recommendations, the law against defacement of public property, and the court's own earlier orders. Any failure to enforce these norms, the bench said, could not be avoided.

That judicial scrutiny extended into a strongly worded set of observations on Wednesday, this time touching on violence and the role of outsiders in the campaign, a development ABVP moved quickly to welcome. At a press conference on the eve of polling, ABVP National General Secretary Dr Virendra Singh

Solanki said the organisation welcomed the High Court's remarks and demanded the immediate arrest of those responsible for attacking ABVP workers in incidents on September 16.

"Violence of any kind is unacceptable. The university and police administration must ensure that the election process is conducted peacefully and in accordance with the prescribed rules," Solanki said.

Solanki used the same briefing to allege that NSUI's campaign had leaned on political figures from outside the university, naming

Indian Youth Congress National President Uday Bhanu Chib and Congress National Spokesperson Ragini Nayak as having campaigned for NSUI inside classrooms. He said Congress's broader political machinery, including the IYC and Seva Dal, had been visibly active during the campaign, alongside individuals linked to the Aam Aadmi Party. "NSUI has lost its ground on campus and is now attempting to conduct electoral activities with the support of outsiders," he said, contrasting this with ABVP's claim of a year-round

campus presence rather than an election-season one.

ABVP's panel, fielding Yash Dabas for President, Ishu Maurya for Vice President, Riya Chhawadi for Secretary and Lakshya Raj Singh for Joint Secretary on ballot number 7-3-3-3, declared itself confident of a clean sweep. "We have complete faith in the support of students, and on September 18, ABVP will win all four seats and deliver a 4-0 result," Solanki said.

That confidence sits alongside a campaign season that regulators have struggled to keep orderly. Weeks before campaigning began, DU Proctor Manoj Kumar Singh had convened student representatives to issue a pointed advisory banning defacement of public property and prohibiting printed billboards or banners anywhere near the polls, permitting only hand-made posters on designated "Wall of Democracy" stretches. The rules followed a familiar, largely unsuccessful pattern. In 2024, a 24-hour ultimatum to remove printed posters was followed by a spot check finding campus walls still plastered and roads littered with pamphlets, with a traffic constable noting over 50 daily challans even as MCD workers tore down by

day what students put back up by night. That year's defacement eventually forced the Delhi High Court to halt vote counting until posters, hoardings and graffiti were cleared and public property restored.

Anticipating a repeat, DU had tightened the rules further last year, mandating a Rs 1 lakh bond from candidates, restricting physical campaigning to two designated walls, and banning rallies, loudspeakers and vehicle campaigns outright, while candidates whose names were misused in unauthorised defacement were required to report it to police within 24 hours or face fines, suspension or expulsion.

That squeeze has visibly reshaped this year's campaign trail, pushing candidates further into reels, short videos and campus influencers to build visibility ahead of Thursday's vote. But as ABVP's press conference and the High Court's fresh observations on outsiders and violence made clear on the campaign's final day, the medium may have changed, the posters may finally be fewer, but the underlying contest over rules, territory and who truly belongs on campus remains as combustible as ever heading into polling day.

NSUI holds march demanding hostels



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The National Students' Union of India (NSUI) on Thursday held a march to demand adequate, affordable hostel facilities for Delhi University students, an end to paper leaks and accountability in the Satya Niketan building collapse case.

The 'Taali-Thali March', organised on Prime Minister Narendra Modi's birthday, began at the NSUI headquarters at 5 Raisina Road and was led by the organisation's national president Vinod Jakhar.

The NSUI claimed nearly 100 police personnel were deployed outside its office and that barricades and restrictions prevented protesters from proceeding towards Jantar Mantar.

Addressing the protesters, Jakhar extended birthday greetings to Modi but said the Government must address issues affecting students.

"Delhi University students deserve hostels. Paper leaks must be stopped nationwide, and students deserve a safe and transparent education system," he said.

The NSUI said thousands of students continue to face high rents and inadequate hostel facilities due to a shortage of accommodation on and around the university campus.

It also questioned the Delhi government's recent announcement to construct hostels for 10,000 students and demanded that Chief Minister Rekha Gupta release a clear and transparent standard operating procedure (SOP) for the project.

Supreme Court clears removal of over 13,100 invasive trees in Central Ridge for native plantation

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In a significant order, the Supreme Court on Thursday gave its go ahead to a move of the Delhi government's forest department to clear over 13,100 invasive trees (such as *vilayati kikar*, *babool*, and eucalyptus) in the Central Ridge and replace them with native saplings.

A bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana agreed with the contention of the forest department that trees like invasive species like "Vilayati Keekar" (*Prosopis juliflora*), Babool tree (*Vachellia nilotica*) and

Eucalyptus need to be uprooted to make way for the trees like Neem, Banyan, Peepal, Jamun and Amaltas tree (*Cassia fistula*).

The bench, however, said the forest department will carry out this exercise under the approved Delhi Eco-restoration Plan 2026-30 prepared by Forest Research Institute (FRI), Dehradun and would be overseen by Delhi Ridge Management Board. It said that the department will submit an interim compliance report and the director of FRI will constitute a team of experts to examine the implementation of the plan.

The top court stayed the contempt proceedings initiated

before the Delhi High Court. During the hearing, Additional Solicitor General Aishwarya Bhati, appearing for the forest department, said that it is a big area and around 13,000 invasive trees need to be uprooted so that new trees can be planted in the area.

Lt Col (Retd) Sarvadaman Singh Oberoi, managing trustee of the Aravalli Bachao Citizens Movement, filed a contempt petition before the high court alleging violation of court orders on construction, clearing and excavation activities at the Central Ridge. Oberoi was represented by senior advocate Shoeb Alam.

The forest department challenged the Delhi High Court



order of August 20, by which it had directed to ensure that no construction activity, clearing, excavation or removal of trees or shrubs is carried out in the Central Ridge area. On Thursday, Alam said he has no

issue with the plantation of new trees but the manner in which the forest department is uprooting the old trees, it is damaging the top soil, which is rich in minerals. CJI Kant told Alam that these

Eucalyptus and Vilayati Keekar tree species are such that they not only lower the underground water level but also destroy the soil, which would result in no other plant growing near them.

He said that unless these trees are uprooted from the very roots, they would again come back. "In 1970s as the paper industry grew, farmers in India without knowing their harmful effect started planting Eucalyptus and other trees. Nowadays, nobody plants these trees. Now farmers have found a substitute in the 'Popla' tree, which is eco-friendly and can be used in timber as well as in paper industry," the CJI said.

He further said that only some forest officials who adopt unscientific methods plant these trees like on the roadside, which has now become a cause of road accidents. Alam agreed with the experience of the CJI in the agriculture field but said that he has no problem with planting of alternative species and was worried only with the methodology adopted to uproot the existing trees.

Bhati refuted the charge and said that everything was done according to the approved plan. She submitted that according to the annual plan for 2026-27, a total of 22,188 invasive trees over 191 hectares have to be

removed and, in their place, 7,29,000-odd trees and shrubs are to be planted.

Bhati submitted that as of now, 9,000-odd invasive trees have been removed and in their place, 5,31,000 shrubs and trees, comprising around 2,23,000 trees and 3,07,000 shrubs, have been planted over approximately 120 hectares.

"About 13,161 invasive trees are left to be removed over approximately 70 hectares, and indigenous trees are to be planted. The difficulty is that the monsoon season will end in September. If we do the plantation after the month of September, it will not yield the required results," she submitted.

House help held for ₹3 crore burglary in Timarpur

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi



A house servant was arrested for allegedly burgling a residence in north Delhi's Timarpur area to fund a proposed move to Nepal and open a restaurant-café. Apart from the servant, his father-in-law and a 17-year-old boy were also apprehended in connection with the robbery.

The accused were identified as Anil Kamat (22), the house servant from Bihar's Supaul, Dev Chandra Sah (49), a vegetable vendor and Kamat's father-in-law, and the juvenile is a resident of Jharkhand's Giridih area. He also worked as a house servant, police said.

Police further said they recovered 117 gold and diamond jewellery items

worth around ₹3 crore, ₹4.34 lakh cash and the bags used to carry the stolen valuables. The burglary was reported on September 6 from the first-floor of the house at Mall Road.

The complainant, Anshul Gupta, told police that his elder brother Anuj Gupta and his family had gone abroad on September 2. The family later learnt that the house

had been burgled, following which a case was registered at Timarpur police station.

Police said two domestic servants hired by the family the previous month were found missing after the incident and their mobile phones were switched off.

During an investigation, more than 300 CCTV cameras in Delhi, Bihar and Jharkhand were examined.

The suspects were tracked through CCTV footage from Mall Road to ISBT, New Delhi Railway Station and then towards Mukarba Chowk. Technical surveillance and cyber intelligence subsequently helped police establish their links to Bihar and Jharkhand.

A team was sent to Darbhanga, where CCTV footage showed Kamat and the juvenile at the railway station on September 8. The juvenile was later traced to his relatives' residence in Giridih and apprehended on September 10, police said.

Kamat was also traced to the area near Simrahi in Supaul district, where his in-laws lived. A police team raided the premises but did not find him there. His father-in-law, Sah, was present and was questioned.

Govt plans AI-based traffic audit of road network in South zone

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government plans to conduct an artificial intelligence (AI)-based traffic and safety audit of more than 420 km of road network in South Delhi to reduce congestion and road accidents.

Under the traffic study, which will use AI-based traffic analysis and other modern technologies, the Public Works Department (PWD) will study traffic congestion hotspots, critical bottlenecks, and accident-prone areas.

"The traffic study will prepare a short-term implementation plan comprising traffic management measures, operational improvements, and other low-cost engineering interventions with a priority implementation schedule and indicative cost estimates,"



an official said. The PWD plans to take up the study on 270 roads, including the Outer Ring Road, Ring Road, Mehrauli-Badarpur Road, Lala Lajpat Rai Marg, Hansraj Gupta Marg, Sri Aurobindo Marg, and Maharaja Agrasen Marg.

For the study, the PWD plans to hire a consultant at an estimated cost of Rs 3.5 crore, who will also provide a detailed project report on

the steps required.

"Based on the existing traffic congestion, critical bottlenecks and delayed corridors, a policy for new flyovers, underpasses, elevated corridors and other road interventions that might be required will be prepared," the project plan stated.

According to the plan, infrastructure feasibility studies will also be undertaken,

aimed at developing an integrated and sustainable mobility framework that will assess the performance and future demand of public transport corridors and recommend strategies to improve public transport efficiency, reliability, and ridership.

The study has been planned to address increasing local and regional travel, which has put pressure on the road infrastructure, leading to a rise in congestion, vehicle emissions, and travel durations.

"The traffic study will function as a decision-support system for integrated urban transport planning, enabling evidence-based interventions aimed at improving mobility, road safety, operational efficiency, accessibility and environmental sustainability," the officials added.

DTC strike strands Delhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■
New Delhi

Contract drivers and conductors of Delhi Transport Corporation buses strike continued on Thursday, pulling buses off the roads and parking them idle at depots, leaving passengers across the capital struggling to find alternative transport.

The workers said the strike will continue until their demands are met. With DTC buses off the roads, commuters turned to autos, taxis and Gramin Seva vehicles, only to find fares had shot up sharply as demand outstripped supply.

Contract drivers and conductors are protesting to demand a salary hike, medical facilities and accident insurance, none of which they currently receive.

Speaking about their griev-



DTC electric buses are parked at a depot during the ongoing corporation drivers' strike better working conditions, in New Delhi, Thursday

ances, drivers said they earn only around Rs 22,000 a month, with no medical coverage or life insurance provided. "We should get medical and life insurance benefits along with a salary hike. We will continue the strike until our demands are met," several drivers said. Contract driver Vipul Singh said the workers

were demanding a wage increase, saying they currently receive ₹862 per day, an amount he said was simply not enough to survive on. Another driver, Vinod, said he earns ₹22,000 a month, which he said makes it impossible to manage household expenses, while permanent DTC employees earn ₹80,000

a month for comparable work. He said their demand was for daily wages to be raised to ₹1,500.

The strike's ripple effect has hit commuters hard. Passengers said routes that normally cost around Rs 20 were being quoted at ₹100 or more by alternative transport operators. On some routes, fares ranging from ₹50 to ₹300 were being demanded, with commuters travelling to areas like Palam reportedly being asked to pay ₹250 to 300 for journeys that would typically cost a fraction of that.

The disruption has not been limited to office commuters alone. People travelling to hospitals for medical appointments have also been affected, with some saying the sharp rise in auto fares had forced them to rely on cycles instead, out of sheer necessity, to reach their destinations.

Four arrested in Capital rape-murder

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■
New Delhi

A 17-year-old girl was allegedly raped and stabbed to death before her body was dumped in an open field in Delhi, with police arresting four people, including three juveniles, in connection with the crime. According to police, the girl had gone with the accused in a tempo and was allegedly sexually assaulted and killed after they drank together inside the vehicle.

Police said the girl's decomposed body was found near Jaipal Rana's field on Kushak Road on September 13. It had deteriorated to such an extent that its gender could not be immediately ascertained.

YFE hails HC stay on 91% MBBS reservation in UP as unconstitutional

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■
Lucknow/New Delhi

The Youth for Equality Foundation (YFE) has welcomed the landmark interim order passed by the Lucknow Bench of the Allahabad High Court, which has stayed the ongoing NEET-UG 2026 counselling for four premier government medical colleges in the State.

The division bench, comprising Justice Alok Mathur and Justice Amitabh Kumar Rai, intervened after the Uttar Pradesh government introduced a notification mandating an unprecedented 91% reservation for MBBS admissions at the government medical colleges in Kannauj, Saharanpur, Ambedkar Nagar, and Jalaun. This con-



troversial notification directly breached a formal legal undertaking that the UP government had submitted to the High Court last year, wherein the state promised to strictly adhere to the Reservation Act, 2006. The Court came down heavily on the State Government for violating its own commitment.

The 91% reservation structure drastically shrank the available seats, severely compromising the futures of highly meritorious General Category (GC) and Other

Backward Classes (OBC) medical aspirants. Recognising this severe injustice, Youth for Equality (YFE), alongside the Reservation Hatao Andolan (RHA), stepped forward to spearhead the legal battle, providing comprehensive financial, moral, and legal aid to the aggrieved students. During today's high-stakes hearing, the petitioner-students were robustly represented by Senior Advocate Amrendra Nath Tripathi, ably assisted by Advocate Harsh Vardhan Kediya. Their compelling arguments exposed the unconstitutional nature of the state's sudden policy shift, successfully securing the stay on counselling for the four affected colleges pending further orders.

Delhi hits back at US sanctions threat

It also gives the US President powers to impose substantial tariffs on countries that continue to rely on Russian oil and gas, with India and China among the major economies potentially affected. The House vote followed an 86-11 approval of the measure in the Senate last month. While the legislation received support from lawmakers across party lines, opposition in the House was particularly focused on the extent of tariff powers that would be available to the President.

Democratic lawmakers have argued that granting additional tariff authority to Trump could have wider economic consequences. Congressman Richard Neal was quoted during the House debate as saying that the objection was to giving the President greater authority over tariffs. Supporters of the legislation, meanwhile, have argued that stronger economic pressure is necessary to reduce Russia's ability to finance its war effort in Ukraine.

Russia has criticised a new US sanctions package, warning that additional measures against Moscow could complicate efforts to reach a peace settlement in Ukraine.

Kremlin spokesman Dmitry Peskov said Russia was monitoring the legislation and described the additional US sanctions as "unfriendly actions." "We are, of course, monitoring the progress of this document. It falls under the category of unfriendly actions, and of course the imposition of any additional sanctions by the US would certainly complicate efforts to find a peace settlement in Ukraine," Peskov told reporters.

The sanctions package targets Russia's energy and defence industries, Russian officials and financial institutions, as well as vessels forming part of what Washington describes as the country's "shadow fleet" of tankers used to maintain energy shipments despite existing Western restrictions. The legislation aims to increase economic pressure on Moscow over its war in Ukraine, which has entered its fifth year. US-mediated efforts to end the war have been stalled for months. President Trump sent two envoys to Moscow and Kyiv earlier this month as part of efforts to restart the peace process.

PM invites tech giants to build chips in India

He framed the push within a broader narrative of economic momentum, citing 7.8 per cent quarterly GDP growth, a recent sovereign rating upgrade by a Japanese credit rating agency, and the New Delhi Declaration adopted at the BRICS summit India hosted this month. "India's economy is growing, and on the other hand, the world's trust in India is also increasing," he said.

The PM said the development of a semiconductor ecosystem required capabilities spanning chip design, equipment, materials, testing and packaging. He urged industry leaders to deepen domestic research and development and encouraged Indian researchers working overseas to contribute to advanced technology development in the country.

"Young talents who are researching in India should come forward; the youth who are researching abroad should also join the development of advanced technologies in India," Modi said. He called on semiconductor companies to expand research partnerships with Indian institutions and universities, saying greater industry-led R&D would benefit both companies and the country's technology workforce.

Modi said the government was advancing the second phase of its semiconductor programme and had introduced regulatory changes intended to facilitate collaboration among global companies, startups and design firms. The government approved the second phase of the Semicon India programme in July with an outlay of Rs 1.275 lakh crore.

The PM also called for a deeper domestic supply chain, including more fabless semiconductor companies, locally developed intellectual property and greater use of silicon photonics for artificial-intelligence infrastructure.

He urged companies producing semiconductor equipment, chemicals, gases and materials to expand in India, saying the country had an opportunity to build an ecosystem spanning the semiconductor value chain.

India slams Pakistan at UN over safe havens...

Senior al-Qaeda operative Walid bin Attash, who helped select and prepare several hijackers, was captured separately. Mustafa Ahmed al-Hawsawi, a key financial and logistical facilitator of the 9/11 operation, was captured under similar circumstances, he said.

"In each case, these were not fugitives hiding

in caves or badlands, they were men who had long evaded detection. Draining this swamp that provided an enabling environment for such monsters of humankind to prosper is important," Parvathaneni said, in a thinly-veiled reference to Pakistan. He said that "the same permissive environment that sheltered the architects of 9/11 has, in the years since, continued to provide space, support, and impunity to affiliates of al-Qaeda such as Lashkar-e-Taiba and Jaish-e-Mohammed and their like, acquiring different identities to escape this Council's sanctions framework and whose leadership and terror training infrastructure have been shielded from consequence. "The international community must join hands to address the continuity of such sanctuary to ensure that more such individuals are not thrust upon any country or its citizens and no one loses family and loved ones," he said.

Last week, as the world marked 25 years of the September 11 terror attacks perpetrated by al-Qaeda, UN Security Council members, including Pakistan, visited the 9/11 memorial in Lower Manhattan. While bin Laden was captured and killed in the Pakistani town of Abbottabad in 2011, Mohammed was captured in March 2003 in Rawalpindi and is currently detained at Guantanamo Bay.

Binalshibh and bin Attash were captured in Karachi within a span of months, while al-Hawsawi was captured in Pakistan in March 2003. "Last week, we honoured the memory of those taken mercilessly away by the scourge of terrorism 25 years ago in this very city. Earlier this month, the Council members visited the site of this horrible tragedy. May the memory of these victims always remain a motivation to not only fight against all such individuals who are the worst of humanity, but also those who aid, abet, finance and support their crimes," Parvathaneni said. US Ambassador to the UN Mike Waltz had taken his fellow Security Council Ambassadors to the 9/11 memorial.

"We reinforced our shared commitment to peace, security, and a world free from terror," Waltz had said. Pakistan currently sits in the Security Council as a non-permanent member, and its envoy Asim Iftikhar Ahmad was among the UN ambassadors who visited the 9/11 memorial site. On the 25th anniversary of the 9/11 attacks, the UN Security Council also adopted a Presidential Statement which reaffirmed the Council's "unequivocal condemnation" of the 9/11 terrorist attacks. The PRST adopted under the French Presidency was the Council's first presidential statement on counter-terrorism in five years. India also reiterated its deep concern at the humanitarian plight of the Afghan returnees.

The Secretary General's Report on Afghanistan mentions that in 2025, 2.9 million Afghans were returned, and until August 22, 2026, another 1.15 million Afghans were returned, most of which were involuntary.

"A forcible return of this nature that is neither safe nor dignified, of over three million individuals, in any other part of the world would have elicited a political outcry in this Council, urgent provision of large-scale humanitarian support and efforts to ensure better re-integration and assimilation. That there is no such reaction is a sad reflection on the times," Parvathaneni said. India reaffirmed that returns must be voluntary, safe and dignified, and reintegration should receive sustained international support. To this end, India is cooperating with the UN agencies and the Afghan authorities to make provisions for housing, food and other essential items to ease the immense pain and hardship the returnees are suffering.

India said it also strongly condemns the "trade and transit terror inflicted" on Afghanistan in violation of UN declarations on Landlocked Developing Countries (LLDCs), WTO norms, provisions of the UN Charter and international law, and the tenets of basic human compassion. (PTI)

Tata board backs Chandrasekaran

Tata Trusts rejected the outcome outright.

In a statement, the Trusts said Chandrasekaran's August 12 decision "has been duly accepted and has attained finality", noting they had already asked Tata Sons to set up a selection committee for a successor under the company's Articles of Association.

It argued the reappointment vote "was a legal nullity", saying the Articles require both Trust-nominated directors to back any chairmanship resolution - and since Noel Tata voted against it, "it was rendered legally void and without any basis". The Trusts said Noel Tata had also submitted a legal opinion from former Chief Justice of India DY Chandrachud supporting their position, which "was not taken note of by the Board".

In a detailed statement to the board, Noel Tata went further, arguing the question was premature because his own status as a director was

unresolved after a general meeting "was not able to proceed for want of quorum".

A vote taken under that cloud, he warned, "would be open to serious legal challenge by any shareholder who chose to bring it".

He also urged the board not to conflate the reappointment fight with the separate, pending question of Tata Sons' listing status with the RBI.

"It would not serve this company for a regulatory development to determine the outcome of a succession process," he said, adding that "the page has turned" on Chandrasekaran's original decision to step down.

According to a statement issued by Tata Sons, the reappointment saga traces back to July 28, 2025, when Tata Trusts passed a unanimous resolution expressing "appreciation" for Chandrasekaran's stewardship of the group since 2017 and resolving that he "be re-appointed as Executive Chairman for a further term of five years" once his current tenure expired.

Tata Sons' board agreed in principle the following September, and set out to secure formal approval in February 2026.

That approval never came cleanly. "In February 2026, in the absence of unanimity, the resolution was deferred for decision," the company said. The matter resurfaced at board meetings in May and June without resolution.

Then, on August 12, Chandrasekaran informed the board that he would not put himself forward for reappointment when his term expires on February 20, 2027.

Three weeks later, on September 3, the board's Nomination and Remuneration Committee met to consider the fallout. It "unanimously resolved to request him to reconsider his decision and to recommend him for re-appointment at the next Board meeting", Tata Sons said. That meeting came on Thursday.

"Chandra acceded to the Board's request to reconsider his decision," the company said, and the board "thereafter resolved by a majority vote to re-appoint him as Executive Chairman for a further term of five years".

Four directors voted in favour; Noel Tata, chairman of Tata Trusts, voted against.

Tata Trusts moved immediately to repudiate the outcome. In a statement headlined declaring the resolution "illegal", the Trusts said Chandrasekaran's August 12 decision not to seek reappointment "has been duly accepted and has attained finality" and that they had already directed Tata Sons "to initiate the process for setting up a Selection Committee for appointing a successor". The Trusts disclosed that Noel Tata had submitted a legal opinion from Justice DY Chandrachud, the former Chief Justice of India, backing their position.

The Trusts said they "remain committed to ensuring an orderly and timely leadership transition" and confirmed a fuller statement by Noel Tata to the board was annexed to their release.

In that annexed statement, delivered directly to directors, Noel Tata laid out his objections point by point. He stressed that Chandrasekaran's August 12 letter "was freely taken and clearly expressed", was not requested by the board, and was "not the outcome of any process of review" - yet was made public "without prior deliberation with the shareholders," including Tata Trusts, which holds "approximately 66 per cent of its equity". Once made public, he argued, the decision "has consequences which this Board cannot afterwards undo", noting that "the Group's employees, its lenders, its counterparties and the market have all proceeded upon it. So, has the majority shareholder. The page has turned". He argued a reappointment vote asked the board "to set aside three things at once: the Chairman's own stated decision, the acceptance of that decision by the majority shareholder, and the further process which that shareholder has asked this company to set in motion".

Noel Tata also raised a procedural objection: his own standing as a director, he said, was "presently uncertain" after a general meeting "was not able to proceed for want of quorum", meaning any vote on the chairmanship "rests upon a foundation which has not yet been laid".

He warned that a decision taken under that uncertainty "would be open to serious legal challenge by any shareholder who chose to bring it" — a risk, he said, the company could ill afford "at a moment when it has matters of far greater consequence pending before its regulator".

He urged directors not to let the reappointment question bleed into the separate, unresolved dispute over Tata Sons' listing obligations to the RBI. "It would not serve this company for a regulatory development to determine the outcome of a succession process, and it would not serve this company for a succession process to shape its regulatory posture," he said, adding that each matter "is entitled to be decided upon its own merits". He closed by asking that his statement "be recorded in full in the minutes of this meeting". With Tata Sons treating

Chandrasekaran as reappointed and Tata Trusts treating the vote as a nullity - and a selection-committee process already under the Trusts' direction - the dispute appears headed toward further confrontation.

The next showdown may happen at the company's AGM, which has to ratify the appointment. Neither side's statement indicated any immediate legal filing had been made as of Wednesday. The shift in Tata Sons board's position followed the RBI's rejection last week of Tata Sons' application to surrender its registration as a non-banking financial company - a decision that revives the prospect of a stock listing the company had spent more than a year trying to avoid, including by repaying more than Rs 21,000 crore in debt.

Board members reasoned that continuity of leadership would reassure prospective investors ahead of any listing process, according to sources. Potential investors typically seek assurance on management continuity once a company embarks on an initial public offering.

The listing push followed the Reserve Bank of India's rejection on September 11 of Tata Sons' application to surrender its registration as a core investment company, an exemption that would have let the company avoid a stock-market debut. The RBI classified Tata Sons as an "upper layer" non-banking financial company in 2022, a designation that requires listing within three years; that deadline lapsed in September 2025 while the deregistration request was under review. Tata Sons had repaid its outstanding debt in an earlier bid to qualify for the exemption.

The listing decision exposed a rift even within the Trusts. The Sir Dorabji Tata Trust sought to bind nominee director Venu Srinivasan to vote against the listing, but Srinivasan refused, citing his independent duty as a director sitting on the board as a joint nominee, according to people familiar with the matter.

Any legal challenge to the RBI's rejection can only be pursued by Tata Sons itself, not by the Trusts directly, according to sources.

Chandrasekaran has led Tata Sons since February 2017, when he succeeded Ratan Tata as interim chairman after the board's ouster of Cyrus Mistry. He was unanimously reappointed for a second five-year term in 2022.

Tata Trusts backed a third term for him as early as 2025, but the proposal stalled in February 2026 after Noel Tata raised concerns over losses at businesses like Air India and Tata Digital and set out conditions, including keeping Tata Sons unlisted, for supporting the renewal.

Thursday's vote appears to resolve the succession question that had been running in parallel: the Sir Dorabji Tata Trust had initiated a formal process to identify Chandrasekaran's replacement, with Tata Steel chief executive TV Narendran, Tata Sons group chief financial officer Saurabh Agrawal and National Stock Exchange chief executive Ashish Chauhan as contenders. That process is now expected to be paused or discontinued.

The Shapoorji Pallonji Group, which holds about 18 per cent of Tata Sons and has pushed for a listing to unlock value from its stake and support its own debt repayment.

An eventual Tata Sons listing could rank among the largest IPOs in Indian history. Even a 1 per cent stake sale has been valued at an estimated Rs 15,000-20,000 crore, implying an overall valuation near Rs 20 lakh crore - roughly USD 230 billion - for the conglomerate, which holds controlling stakes in more than a dozen listed companies across steel, automobiles, software services, hospitality and aviation.

IRS officer caught in CBI net for graft

The money was reportedly intended to influence the outcome of a tax appeal. The Income Tax Department arrested Lavidiya and four others while he was Commissioner of Income Tax (Appeals) for Units 7 and 8 in Hyderabad. At the same time, searches at 18 locations in Mumbai, Hyderabad, Khammam, Visakhapatnam, and New Delhi led to the seizure of about Rs 69 lakh in cash, along with trap money, documents, and digital records.

The May 2025 searches started the current case over disproportionate assets. At Srivastava's home in Delhi, investigators found Rs 54 lakh in cash and notes listing various properties. They also collected documents about assets in Lavidiya's name and her family members' names. The earlier bribery complaint had already mentioned alleged benami holdings, including a Mumbai flat worth about Rs 2.5 crore, reportedly received in exchange for favours and registered under someone else's name.

The CBI looked at the period from 1 April 2022 to 10 May 2025. During this time, the couple's known income was ₹1,95,74,358, but their assets and spending totalled ₹3,07,52,247. The differ-

ence of ₹1,11,77,889 was called disproportionate assets, making up 57.10 per cent of their declared income. By the end of this period, the family's assets were valued at ₹4,31,60,820. After considering legitimate income and expenses, the agency found that over ₹1.11 crore could not be explained. Lavidiya has been charged under Section 13(2) and Section 13(1)(b) of the Prevention of Corruption Act, 1988. These sections address criminal misconduct by public servants whose assets exceed their known sources of income. Srivastava has also been charged under Section 12 of the same law for allegedly helping to acquire the wealth. Inspector Naveen Kumar is now leading the investigation. The accusations claim that officials used their authority over tax appeals to get cash, property, and unaccounted assets, keeping money and records at family homes. Lavidiya is the son of Ramulu Naik, a former BRS legislator from Wyr in Khammam district. Both officers left their jobs at the end of the inspection period.

The CBI is investigating where each asset came from, the wife's involvement in acquiring or hiding them, and whether the unexplained money meets the legal standard for conviction. This case adds another layer to the original bribery scheme, focusing on wealth and keeping two senior officers from different central services under ongoing anti-corruption scrutiny.

Satish Salian sues Thackeray for ₹500 crore

The police at first regarded the case as one of accidental death. Satish later claimed that his daughter had been gang-raped and killed and that the first investigation had been inadequate. These allegations are currently under investigation. The CBI's FIR, based on Salian's statement, lists several people.

Among them are Aaditya Thackeray, the former CM Uddhav Thackeray, actors Dino Morea, Sooraj Pancholi and Rhea Chakraborty, as well as former police officers and others. Thackeray has denied ever knowing or meeting her. In a statement issued this week, he claimed that he had no knowledge of her and that the efforts made over the past six years to associate him with her death were part of a false campaign motivated by political considerations and personal ill will. He added that no evidence showed any connection between him and the incident and asked the CBI to proceed without interference or exposure to character attacks.

1,498 treasured mementoes gifted...

The entire statue is richly detailed, showcasing intricate designs that enhance its spiritual significance and aesthetic appeal, according to the e-auction website.

Also on offer is a model replica of HMS Victory. This model faithfully captures Lord Nelson's famous vessel, featuring detailed multi-tier gun decks painted in its iconic yellow and black stripe configuration. The ship is mounted securely on brass supports over a polished wooden plinth, complete with an official metal nameplate, and is accented with miniature Indian flags for premium presentation. It has a base price of ₹2.25 lakh, the website says.

Besides, sports memorabilia containing a pair of running spike shoes, gifted to PM Modi by a Paralympic silver medalist, and a meticulously handcrafted commemorative artwork (base price ₹1.20 lakh) showcasing an architectural depiction of the modern convention centre in Daman, using zardozi embroidery, also figure in the auction.

A detailed top view scale model that replicates INS Nilgiri, the lead ship of the Indian Navy advanced stealth guided missile frigates, with a base price of ₹66,000; a BAPS Swaminarayan Akshardham North America temple miniature 3D model, capturing the stunning architecture of the famous Robbinsville, New Jersey temple, complete with intricate stone-like carvings, multiple majestic spires, and a small decorative flag at the top, with a base price of ₹4,500, have also gone under the hammer. A magnificent, masterfully crafted commemorative 3D architectural model depicting the Lok Sabha chamber inside the new Parliament House of India is also part of the current e-auction, with a starting bid of ₹45,000. "This exceptional artefact features detailed relief work, showcasing the triangular architecture, the iconic green parliamentary seating layout, the state emblem of India atop the roof, and dedicated cutouts celebrating the historic women reservation bill (Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam)," it adds.

Shekhawat said the collection represents the country's artistic and spiritual traditions, traditional craftsmanship, cultural practices and sporting achievements.

ECI bars TMC factions from using party name, symbol in bypolls

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Election Commission has directed rival factions of the All India Trinamool Congress (AITC) not to use the party name and “Flowers and Grass symbol” during the West Bengal bypolls, and asked them to submit their preferred names and symbols by Friday morning.

In its interim order issued on Thursday night, the Commission, after hearing leaders of the two factions led by Mamata Banerjee and Arup Roy, said the matter requires substantive determination by the poll body under provisions of the Election Symbols (Reservation and Allotment) Order 1968.

“On due consideration of the totality of information available on record... the commission is of the opinion that there are two rival groups in the All India Trinamool Congress, one led by Ms. Mamata Banerjee and the other led by Shri Arup Roy,” the interim order said.



“Each group is now claiming to be the party, and therefore the matter requires a substantive determination by the Commission under Para 15 of the Election Symbols (Reservation & Allotment) Order 1968,” it said.

Accordingly, the commission said, to place both the rival groups on an even keel and to protect their rights and interests and going by the past precedent, the Commission gave its interim order to cover the purpose of the current by-elections and to continue till the final determination of the dispute in the matter.

“Neither of the two groups led by Shri Arup Roy

(Petitioner) and the other led by Ms. Mamata Banerjee (Respondent) shall be permitted to use the name of the party ‘All India Trinamool Congress’

“Neither of the two groups shall also be permitted to use the symbol ‘Flowers and Grass’, reserved for ‘All India Trinamool Congress’,” the Commission said.

The poll body said both the groups shall be known by such names as they may choose for their respective groups, and if they so desire, linkage with their parent party ‘All India Trinamool Congress’ and both the groups shall also be allotted

such different symbols as they may choose from the list of free symbols notified by the ECI for the purposes of the current by-elections.

“Accordingly, both the groups are hereby directed to furnish, latest by 11:00 am on 18.09.2026: The names of their groups by which they may be recognised by the commission and, to this end, give three options in order of preference, any one of which may be approved by the commission and the symbols which may be allotted to the candidates set up, if any, by the respective groups.

“They may indicate the names of three free symbols, in the order of their preference, any one of which may be allotted to their candidates by the commission,” the ECI said.

Both the factions had presented their cases for claim on party name and symbol ahead of the October 6 bypolls in the Nandigram and Rejinagar Assembly constituencies of West Bengal.

Congress jabs Union Govt as US passes Russia sanctions bill

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Congress on Thursday took a swipe at the Modi Government after the US House of Representatives passed a bill that would authorise President Donald Trump to impose steep tariffs on Russia's trading partners in oil and gas, saying appeasement has never paid and will never pay.

The Opposition party also demanded that the Government clarify its stance on the issue at the earliest, and ensure India's energy security is not sacrificed.

The Lindsey O Graham Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act of 2026, passed by the US Senate last month, was approved by the House in a 262-159 vote on Wednesday and will now go to Trump to be signed into law.

The bill seeks to impose sanctions not only on Russia's leadership and energy sector, but also on the “shadow fleet” of vessels that enable Moscow to evade sanctions on oil deliveries. It also seeks to authorise Trump to impose stiff tariffs on China, India and other



Congress leader Jairam Ramesh

countries to reduce their dependence on Russian oil and gas, as well as additional sanctions on Iran.

Reacting to the passage of the bill, Congress general secretary in charge of communications, Jairam Ramesh, said on X, “Appeasement has never paid and will never pay.”

Congress general secretary, in-charge organisation, KC Venugopal, also targeted the Government.

“Will the PM find the guts to stand up to the US' latest Senate resolution? Will India's foreign policy and energy sovereignty be controlled from Washington?

The PM was boasting that the BRICS Joint Declaration was a symbol of the world trusting India, but soon after, we are seeing such aggressive bullying from a strategic partner,” he said on X.

“Just this week, we saw the Centre bow to US pressure and impose MDR on UPI transactions, and now we are facing renewed pressure on oil purchases. Given the Compromised PM's track record, we are likely to see the Centre toe the US' line and surrender to Washington,” Venugopal said.

“We demand that the Modi Government clarify its

Reporter TV MD held for keeping 67 litres of liquor in Kerala

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kochi

The Managing Director of a private Malayalam news channel was arrested by Excise officials from Kochi in the wee hours of Thursday after liquor above the permissible limit was recovered during a police search at his ancestral house in Wayanad, Excise officials said. The Excise department registered a case against Anto Augustine based on the police report after they recovered liquor above the permissible limit during the search, they said, adding that 67 litres of liquor was found at his home in Wayanad.

The Special Investigation Team (SIT) on Wednesday searched the office and residences of Augustine and his two brothers in Kochi and Wayanad as part of a probe into alleged irregularities in a failed football event featuring Argentina's star player Lionel Messi sponsored by Reporter Broadcasting Company. The Excise case was registered under various non-bailable sections of the



Anto Augustine during arrest

Abkari Act for possessing liquor in excess of the permissible quantity, officials said. He was arrested and later shifted to Wayanad, Excise officials said.

Meanwhile, Home Minister Ramesh Chennithala said the SIT had not done anything wrong as the searches were conducted after obtaining warrants.

“Home Minister won't interfere in any police investigation. Let the investigation go on. The law will take its course,” he said. He denied opposition allegations that there was an emergency-like situation in Kerala and said several media persons had been booked during the previous Pinarayi

Vijayan Government. “If anyone did anything illegal, there will be action from the part of the police,” he said.

Anto Augustine and his brothers were involved in so many controversies before entering into the media business. They acquired Reporter TV five years ago. Earlier, they were arrested for illegal tree felling in a forest in Wayanad. They were also involved in cheating people by launching a fake mobile phone company - Mango Phone. Anto was involved in several criminal cases before entering the media business and was declared a history sheeter by the local police station.

Two JeM terrorists killed in J&K encounter

MOHIT KANDHARI
■ Jammu

A joint team of security forces led by an elite group of Para Commandos have neutralised two heavily armed Pakistani terrorists affiliated with the proscribed Jaish-e-Mohammad (JeM) outfit, without causing any collateral damage, in the general area of Brattal, Udhampur on Thursday.

During ongoing searches in the thickly forested area, the security forces also detained a suspected overground worker (OGW). They escorted him for further interrogation to establish any links and whether he was sheltering the foreign terrorists and providing logistics to sustain them inside their hideout.

It was the second major encounter in Udhampur district this year. On February 4, a dreaded commander of Pakistan-based Jaish-e-Mohammed (JeM), Rubani alias Abu Mavia, along with his associate, was neutralised inside a natural cave during a 20-hour-long operation in the Basantgarh area of Udhampur. The JeM commander was active in the area for several years before



he was gunned down.

The anti-terrorist operation was going on in the area, and on Wednesday evening the security forces recorded a suspected movement of terrorists. “Around 9.00 pm, at least 4-5 rounds from a rocket launcher were fired by the special forces, targeting the safe hideout of JeM terrorists in the Brattal /Khubban area under the jurisdiction of Majalta police station in Udhampur district”. On Thursday, the Army confirmed the killing of two terrorists in the operation.

“In a joint intelligence-based operation during the

intervening night of September 16-17, confirmed inputs indicated the presence of terrorists in the general area of Brattal, Udhampur.

“Despite hostile weather, difficult terrain and poor visibility, troops of White Knight Corps, Police and CRPF launched a targeted counter-terrorism operation, resulting in the neutralisation of two terrorists.

“The operation is still in progress, with search and surveillance continuing in the area. Security forces remain deployed to track and neutralise any remaining threat,”

the Jammu-based White Knight Corps said in a post on X. The slain terrorists have been identified as Saddam and Mustafa by Jammu and Kashmir Police.

An AK Assault Rifle (with 4 mags), one M4 Carbine (with 3 mags), a Glock Pistol (with 2 mags) and 4 grenades have been recovered from their person, police said in a post on X.

Security forces have been maintaining a hawk's eye in the region to prevent Pakistan-based JeM terrorists from carving out safe hideouts in the upper reaches of Udhampur.

West Bengal to observe PM birthday as Annapurna Diwas

SAUGAR SENGUPTA
■ Kolkata

West Bengal Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari on Thursday greeted Prime Minister Narendra Modi on his 76th birthday, announcing the day would be celebrated every year as Annapurna Diwas, marking the distribution of a monthly allowance of ₹3000 to women that was once guaranteed by the Prime Minister before the Bengal elections. More than 1.6 crore women have been receiving the monthly allowance, Government sources said.

Referring to the Prime Ministerial announcement that a list of 50 lakh beneficiaries of the PM housing scheme was being prepared, Adhikari said all the allottees in that respect would be women. In what could



West Bengal CM Suwendu Adhikari was presented a memento by State MoS Malati Rava Roy during the Annapurna Diwas event, to commemorate Prime Minister Narendra Modi's 76th birthday in Kolkata on Thursday

further cement BJP's stranglehold on Bengal, Adhikari, during a programme, said, “the Prime Minister has announced that a list of beneficiaries is being prepared who will get new houses under the PM Awas Yojana... These 50 lakh allotments will be made in favour of

women who will own them,” adding “this day will be celebrated as Annapurna Diwas in Bengal every year ... We all wish our *Yashaswi* (celebrated) Prime Minister a long and prosperous life.”

The new Government had come not only to distribute allowances to women, he

said, “we have come promising an all-round reform where no woman will be at the receiving end of any kind of discrimination or torture... No one will be spared if found guilty of torturing women... That is our priority,” announcing that the State had set up a commission chaired by retired Justice Samapti Chattopadhyay to provide justice to oppressed women. “We will not tolerate even a single case of cruelty or torture on women... That is our commitment,” he said.

The Chief Minister was addressing a 60 thousand strong crowd at Central Park in Salt Lake, with many more thousands joining virtually from 500 locations across the State. Bengal was celebrating the Prime Minister's birthday with illumination of lamps throughout the State.



Grand opening of art exhibition “Celebrating Leadership, Vision & Service through Art” dedicated to PM Modi's life and service held at Dr Ambedkar International Centre (DAIC) in New Delhi

PIONEER PHOTO

ED raids former Haryana minister Gopal Kanda in Gurugram over real estate fraud

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ Gurugram

On Thursday, the Enforcement Directorate (ED) searched the home, farmhouse, and office of Gopal Goyal Kanda, a former Haryana minister, in Gurugram. Officials said the searches are part of an investigation into money laundering linked to an alleged real estate fraud involving Vatika Limited. The ED's office in Gurugram carried out the searches pursuant to Section 17 of the Prevention of Money Laundering Act, 2002.

Officials said the operation began early and involved

both state police and security personnel. The teams examined financial records, documents related to transfers between companies, and papers related to the projects under investigation. The case concerns four commercial projects carried out by Vatika Limited.

The agency said it had raised about Rs 248.46 crore from 661 investors, promising timely handover of the properties, guaranteed returns, lease rentals, and sale deeds. However, an official noted that possession had not yet been handed over and that the promised sale deeds are still incomplete. Officials also

added that the searches at Kanda's properties were intended to trace the movement of funds.

The agency stated that it suspects the money taken from the real estate company was forwarded to companies associated with the former minister. This follows searches by the same agency on August 25 at seven homes and businesses linked to Vatika Limited and its promoter-directors in the Delhi-NCR area.

The ED has taken action against Vatika Limited and its promoter-directors, Anil Bhalla, Gautam Bhalla, and Gaurav Bhalla, along with



Representative image

others. This step follows the Economic Offences Wing of the Delhi Police filing FIRs alleging fraud and failure to deliver the residential plots in question, along with other similar offences. In August, the agency obtained documents, digital devices, audited financial statements, and accounting records. It also seized or placed under freeze assets amounting to approximately Rs 33 crore, comprising three luxury cars, jewellery, bank accounts and securities.

The ED said it had identified a pattern in transactions related to the Vatika India Next and Vatika India

Next-2 projects. The agency said it received about Rs 260.30 crore from complainants between 2010 and 2012 but supplied only plots worth about Rs 120 crore. In some cases, the plots promised were not delivered by the agreed deadlines. Officials said the searches carried out on Thursday were linked to the commercial projects under investigation and the suspected transfer of funds to companies associated with Kanda.

Kanda previously held the position of MLA for Sirsa and is currently the president of the Haryana Lokhit Party. He previously served

stance on this at the earliest, and ensure India's energy security is not sacrificed,” he added.

The Ministry of External Affairs said it will take all necessary steps to protect its economic interests and ensure energy security after the US House of Representatives cleared the bill.

The MEA said the Indian side is monitoring further developments in the matter following the passage of the Act in the US Congress.

Besides 203 Republicans, 58 Democrats and one Independent voted in favour of the legislation. Seven Republicans and 152 Democrats opposed it.

Democratic opposition largely centred around the tariff authorities provided to Trump.

The bill is named after Senator Lindsey Graham, the South Carolina Republican who died in July after spending more than a year building support for it.

“China and India, you better buy your oil and gas somewhere else,” Democratic Senator Richard Blumenthal told reporters after the passage of the bill.

World's highest flower fields opened in Leh

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jammu

Lieutenant Governor, Ladakh, Vinai Kumar Saxena, on Thursday inaugurated the world's highest-altitude twin flower fields in Leh to mark the 76th birth anniversary of Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

Besides being the highest in the world, the two flower fields at Choglamsar and Stakna in Leh, at an altitude of 10,600 feet, are also the highest and the largest flower fields in the country.

With over 25 lakh high-value flowers – including 24 lakh Lilium and 1 lakh



Gladiolus, the flower fields spread over 40 acres. This is the first experiment of this size and nature at high-altitude in Leh, and its successful execution has further paved the way for replicating this model in other parts of Ladakh.

The development of the twin flower fields marks a significant milestone in promoting agricultural diversification, farmers' empowerment and creating new livelihood opportunities through commercial floriculture in Ladakh.

Interestingly, the flower field at Choglamsar has been developed in a record time of just two months. Plantation at Choglamsar began on July 16, and the first bloom started in the first week of September. On the other hand, plantation of nearly 14 lakh Liliums at Stakna flower field began in August, and the first bloom is expected around the end of October.

States Focus



TN LEADERS PAY TRIBUTES TO PERIYAR ON BIRTH ANNIVERSARY

Political leaders across party lines in Tamil Nadu on Thursday paid tributes to social reformer and Dravidar Kazhagam founder EV Ramasamy, revered as 'Thanthai Periyar', on his 148th birth anniversary.

September 17 is observed as Social Justice Day in the State, reaffirming its commitment to the principles of equality, self-respect and rationalism championed by Periyar. Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay led the State in paying homage to the social reformer, saying Periyar had spent his entire life fighting to eradicate social divisions and protect people's rights.

In a post on the microblogging platform X, Vijay said Periyar had sown "progressive thoughts anchored in self-respect, social justice and rationalism" in the minds of the people. He highlighted the reformer's lifelong struggle against discrimination based on caste and religion and his efforts to secure the fundamental rights of the people. (PTI)



MANIPUR CM HOLDS SECURITY MEET TO REVIEW LAW & ORDER

Manipur Chief Minister Y. Khemchand Singh on Thursday held a meeting with senior security officials, and discussed measures to maintain law and order in the northeastern State.

The meeting comes days after six people, including four women, were gunned down in separate incidents in Tamenglong and Noney districts. "During the security coordination meeting held at the CM Secretariat, officials discussed the stringent steps that should be taken to maintain law and order in the State, and discussed in length the new vulnerable areas and how to deploy security personnel there," an official release said.

It also said that with the construction season approaching, authorities of the National Highways and Infrastructure Development Corporation Ltd (NHIDCL) are gearing up to intensify work in the next six months. (PTI)

Leaders wish PM on his birthday

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Leaders across the political spectrum greeted Prime Minister Narendra Modi on his 76th birthday on Thursday. Union ministers and senior BJP leaders also congratulated him on 25 years in public life and highlighted Modi's contribution to development, welfare and governance.

Born on September 17, 1950, in Vadnagar, Gujarat, Modi turned 76 on Thursday. He completes 25 uninterrupted years in public office on October 7, having first taken the oath as Gujarat chief minister in 2001 before becoming prime minister in 2014.

While President Droupadi Murmu hailed his record on governance, Home Minister Amit Shah invoked Modi's journey from an ordinary BJP volunteer to the nation's highest political office.

Vice President CP Radhakrishnan credited Modi with presiding over India's emergence as one of the world's fastest-growing major economies, while Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu said his journey from



Union Home Minister Amit Shah, Gujarat Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel and others during a visit to the Jagannath Temple on the occasion of Prime Minister Narendra Modi's birthday in Ahmedabad on Thursday. PTI

Gujarat chief minister to prime minister had given "a new momentum to India's growth story".

Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla said India was forging a new identity on the global stage under Modi's leadership and making progress in development, self-reliance, innovation, digital technology, infrastructure and public welfare.

Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge and Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi also wished Modi a long and healthy life.

Home Minister Shah described Modi as a symbol of tireless hard work, sacrifice and foresight, saying his

life is an "epic tale of penance, sacrifice, and unwavering resolve".

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh said India is marching forward with full confidence towards the goal of 'Viksit Bharat' under Modi's leadership, with progress in infrastructure, digital connectivity, welfare, innovation and entrepreneurship.

BJP president Nitin Nabin described Modi as a symbol of national service and dedication and a leader of 140 crore countrymen, saying India is scaling new heights of development and self-reliance under his guidance.

Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal

described Modi as a "karma yogi" who has dedicated every moment of his life to national service and public welfare.

Union minister Kiren Rijiju expressed hope that Modi continues to lead the country towards the goal of Viksit Bharat 2047.

Union minister CR Patil said Modi's commitment to public service, good governance and development, while placing national interests above all else, has infused new momentum and a broader vision into India's progress. BJP chief spokesperson and MP Anil Baluni said Modi has dedicated his entire life to public service, national service and the welfare of every individual.

BJP MP Sambit Patra said Modi's journey from an ordinary family to the position of prime minister is an inspiring story of struggle, hard work, discipline, and dedication to national service. BJP Rajya Sabha MP Tarun Chugh paid obeisance at the Golden Temple in Amritsar, praying for Prime Minister Narendra Modi's long life. JD(U) chief and former Bihar chief minister Nitish Kumar also extended his greetings, wishing Modi a healthy and long life.

Nitin Nabin slams Opposition over BRICS

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Indore

BJP president Nitin Nabin on Thursday launched the Madhya Pradesh Government's scheme for free registration of rural properties to mark Prime Minister Narendra Modi's birthday, and criticised the Opposition for 'ignoring' India's rising global stature as seen at the recent BRICS Summit.

Speaking after launching the 'Swamitva Adhikar Abhilekh Nispadan evam Panjiyan Yojana 2026', Nabin said the scheme would enable rural people to register their properties and live with a sense of dignity and self-respect.



BJP president Nitin Nabin

Officials said around 50 lakh private properties in rural areas would be registered free of cost under the scheme, the first of its

kind in the country.

Highlighting Modi's contribution to the country's development, Nabin said, "While carrying forward

India's heritage, Prime Minister Modi has connected 140 crore people with development."

India's influence is being felt across the world under Modi's leadership, he said.

The Opposition was only indulging in politics, the BJP chief said, alleging that Opposition parties were talking about the menu rather than India's stature as seen at the recently concluded 18th BRICS Summit in New Delhi.

"Those who walk shoulder to shoulder with the people seeking to divide the country are today talking about uniting the nation," Nabin said. The function was attended by Chief Minister Mohan Yadav, among others.

ED raids 4 States in money-laundering probe linked to Ranchi RSS office attack

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) on Thursday searched locations in Delhi, Bihar, Jharkhand, and Karnataka as part of a money-laundering investigation linked to a petrol-bomb attack on the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh office in Ranchi. This action was taken under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act and followed an NIA case that began with a special investigation by the Jharkhand Police.

The attack happened early on 17 June at the RSS regional office in Ranchi's Nivaranpur area, which is under the Chutia police station. Two makeshift petrol bombs, reportedly made in bottles, were thrown at the building around 12:30 am. One landed on the roof and caused a small fire that went out on

its own, while the other fell near the entrance. No one was hurt, and the damage was minor.

RSS members said the attack was planned. Police found glass fragments and called in a forensic team. Jharkhand Police arrested three men, Saif Ansari, Aman Ansari, and Sayam Sujan, within hours. Police caught two trying to escape by train, and later found the third in Ranchi. One of the accused tried to escape from custody, grabbed a weapon, and was shot in the leg.

Investigators said the suspects used a hired cab, checked out the area in advance, and sent video of the incident to their handlers. Technical evidence and CCTV footage helped with the arrests. The National Investigation Agency (NIA) later took over the case and filed an FIR, which now forms the basis of the Enforcement



Directorate's PMLA investigation. Agencies are focusing on alleged links between the accused and the Pakistan-based Shahzad Bhatti Network.

Officials said at least one of the arrested men had spent time in Dubai, where he reportedly met a handler

known as "Rana Sahib," an associate of Shahzad Bhatti. They allegedly communicated through encrypted messaging apps. Early police reports also suggested links to an ISI-backed group called Tehreek-e-Taliban Hindustan.

The Ministry of Home

Affairs issued a gazette notification under Section 35(1)(a) of the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act, adding the Shahzad Bhatti Network to the First Schedule of banned terrorist organisations. The Centre stated that the group's objective is to recruit gullible youth and local criminals to smuggle arms, explosives and narcotics across the border and to carry out terrorist activities that threaten India's democratic system, communal harmony and internal security.

The notification further alleged that the network radicalises young people through allurements, motivates them for anti-national acts and mobilises resources in collusion with other banned outfits. Shahzad Bhatti, a Pakistani gangster described as operating from the UAE, is identified as the key figure. Security agencies had already conducted a large

multi-state operation against the network around Independence Day, resulting in hundreds of detentions and more than 80 FIRs across 14 States.

The ED is now the second central agency, after the NIA, investigating the group's activities. They are focusing on the financial trail that may have supported the Ranchi attack and related operations. These searches show the Government's policy of investigating both the operational and financial sides of alleged cross-border terror groups.

Investigators are still looking into whether money was sent to local people and how the network used social media and overseas trips to recruit and radicalise others. More information from the raids and ongoing NIA and ED investigations is expected as both agencies work together on the case.

Rahul attacks MP Government over death of tribal children



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Thursday launched a blistering attack on the BJP Government in Madhya Pradesh over the death of more than 30 tribal children due to various diseases in Balaghat district, claiming that the state Government is India's most corrupt and most incompetent Government - that is the truth," Gandhi said.

Later, in a post on his WhatsApp channel, Gandhi claimed that Madhya Pradesh is the RSS-BJP's laboratory, where an experiment to increase illiteracy and unemployment is underway.

"I am coming to Indore - to expose this experiment, explain this game of stealing the future, and unveil the truth. We will not allow anyone to play with students' lives under any circumstances. We are determined to secure the right to education and employment," Gandhi said, referring to his Chhatron Ki Goonj programme on Saturday.

The Congress on Wednesday had demanded the resignation of Deputy Chief Minister and Health Minister Rajendra Shukla over the death of tribal children in Balaghat.

Last week, the Madhya Pradesh High Court had sought a response from the state Government over the deaths while hearing a PIL.

The petition alleged inadequate treatment and claimed that around 400 children were being treated at a hospital with a capacity of 50 beds.

Lack of disease control, nutrition and clean water, along with a crumbling health system, is claiming the lives of children, he alleged.

Adulterated medicines and poisonous illegal liquor are devastating hundreds of families, Gandhi added.

"I am heading to Indore and I am continuously gathering feedback from students, youth and common people across the state. The horrific incidents coming to light are

Top Maoist leader held in West Bengal

SAUGAR SENGUPTA
■ Kolkata

In a major breakthrough, the Special Task Force of the West Bengal Police has arrested senior Maoist leader Asim Mondal alias Akash. The central committee member and State secretary of the Communist Party carried a reward of ₹2.20 crore out of which Jharkhand Police had declared a bounty of ₹1 crore, and the remaining amount was declared by Odisha Police.

Akash was arrested in East Midnapore district after his location was tracked down. Incidentally, East Midnapore is the home district of Bengal Chief Minister Suvenudh Adhikari. He had been operating for more than 15 years, and his name came to the fore during the closing years of the Buddhadeb Bhattacharjee Government in Bengal. He was



Maoist leader Asim Mondal

an acquaintance of slain Maoist leader Kishenji alias Koteswar Rao, who operated from the Jangalmahal area of Bengal. After Kishenji's death, Akash took control of the organisation, and since then he has been underground.

Akash's arrest comes close on the heels of a surrender of a number of Maoist leaders in the State, sources said, adding that he was being interrogated regarding the operational, organisational and strategic preparedness of the Red extremist group.

Ex-BJP MLA, dismissed cop booked for gangraping woman at gunpoint

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Thane

A former BJP MLA and a dismissed constable have been booked for allegedly gangraping a 22-year-old woman after holding her captive at gunpoint, a Thane police official said on Thursday. He identified the accused as Narendra Pawar, former BJP MLA from Kalyan West constituency, and Shailesh Patil, a dismissed police constable.

Citing the woman's complaint, the official said she was held at gunpoint at a farmhouse in Baggaon in Bhiwandi, where she was forced to consume alcohol and then sexually assaulted.

"The woman is married and is facing marital disputes. Pawar allegedly invited her to his office under



Ex-BJP MLA Narendra Pawar

the pretext of mediation. On September 13, Pawar and Patil brought her to the Baggaon farmhouse, allegedly threatened her with a firearm, coerced her to drink alcohol, and sexually assaulted her," the official said.

After Pawar left the premises, Patil allegedly sexually assaulted her again, following which an associate of the accused dropped the survivor off at her residence, the official said. The woman first approached Congress

corporator Kanchan Kulkarni via her Instagram contact number on September 16, disclosed the ordeal and shared supporting evidence, including video footage and WhatsApp chat records. "The victim reached out to me on social media. Hearing her account was horrifying, and after reviewing the video and chat evidence she provided, we immediately took her to Padgha police station," said Kulkarni.

Following intervention by Director General of Police Sadanand Date, Padgha police station senior inspector Pankaj Giri verified the details and registered an FIR against Pawar and Patil under Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita for gangrape, brandishing weapons and other offences, the official said.

Anti-drug warning made part of film certification guidelines

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Films depicting consumption, use or trafficking of narcotic drugs will have to carry an anti-drug warning, with the Centre making the requirement part of the guidelines governing certification of films for public exhibition.

Under the revised guidelines, scenes depicting or involving the consumption, use or trafficking of narcotic drugs or psychotropic substances will have to carry the warning: "Illicit Narcotics Destroy Health and Guarantees Imprisonment. Say No to Drugs."

The Ministry of Information and Broadcasting notified the amended guidelines on September 16 under the Cinematograph Act.

The move marks a change from the earlier certification guidelines, which required the Central Board of Film Certification (CBFC) to ensure that scenes tending to "encourage, justify or glorify drug addiction" were not shown, but did not prescribe such a specific on-screen warning.



Representative image

Last month, the ministry asked OTT platforms to prominently display the same warning during scenes depicting consumption or use of narcotic drugs.

A similar advisory was issued to private satellite television channels.

The film certification guidelines lay down the principles the CBFC must follow when examining films for

public exhibition under the Cinematograph Act.

The guidelines were last amended in May 2025, when the Government incorporated the three age-based parental guidance categories — U/A 7+, U/A 13+ and U/A 16+ — into them. The categories, introduced following amendments to the Cinematograph Act in 2023, advise parental guidance

for children below seven, 13 and 16 years, respectively.

Among other things, they require the board to ensure that anti-social activities such as violence are not glorified or justified, criminal methods likely to incite offences are not depicted and scenes encouraging, justifying or glorifying drug addiction are not shown.

The guidelines also address depictions of violence, cruelty, sexual content and matters that could affect public order, the security of the State or India's relations with foreign countries.

On Wednesday, the Centre reconstituted the CBFC, bringing actors Preity Zinta, Pankaj Tripathi, Suniel Shetty, Pallavi Joshi and Prosenjit Chatterjee, filmmaker Priyadarshan and Grammy-winning musician Ricky Kej, among others, onto its new 18-member board.

The CBFC is headed by chairperson Shashi Shekhar Vempati. The reconstituted board has been given a three-year term or will continue until further orders, whichever is earlier.

Stem cell therapy advisory issued

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Union Health Ministry has advised States and Union territories to ensure that stem cell therapy is offered as standard clinical care only for approved disease conditions, while its use for autism remains restricted to duly approved clinical trials.

The advisory, issued on September 16 to states and UTs that have adopted the Clinical Establishments (Registration and Regulation) Act, 2010 regarding the regulation of stem cell therapy, follows a Supreme Court judgment delivered on January 30 in Yash Charitable Trust and Ors v Union of India and Ors.

The advisory reiterates the existing framework governing stem cell research and therapy and seeks to ensure that stem cell therapy is per-



mitted as standard care in routine clinical practice only for disease conditions/indications included in the list approved by the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare.

For Autism Spectrum Disorder (ASD), the advisory stipulates that the therapeutic use of any type of stem cell in autism is to remain restricted to duly approved clinical trials, in accordance with the National Guidelines for Stem Cell Research, 2017, issued jointly by Indian Council of Medical Research (ICMR) and

the Department of Biotechnology (DBT) and other applicable Government instructions issued by the Government of India from time to time.

The ministry has requested States and Union territories to disseminate the Supreme Court's directions to all state and district regulatory authorities and Government and private clinical establishments involved in stem cell research, treatment, promotion or administration, for strict compli-

ance with the applicable framework. The advisory also draws attention to the consequences of non-compliance with the framework governing stem cell therapy.

The Supreme Court, in its judgment dated 30 January, held that non-compliance with the statutory mandate must attract consequences, including professional misconduct under Regulation 7.22 of ICM Regulations, 2002.

The ministry has accordingly requested the concerned state and district regulatory authorities and clinical establishments to ensure strict compliance with the applicable framework governing stem cell research and therapy.

Reinforcing the regulatory position, the National Medical Commission, in its advisory 5 September, reiterated that stem cell therapy may be offered as clinical care only for the approved indications.

Congress gets a late boost in Rajasthan civic polls

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jaipur

The Congress on Thursday won six of the nine wards where repolling was held across four urban local bodies of Rajasthan, while the BJP secured three, with the results for all 10,244 wards that went to polls now declared.

Repolling was held on Wednesday at 10 polling booths after technical problems in EVMs had prevented completion of counting in the affected wards earlier.

The Congress swept all four pending wards in Jaipur Municipal Corporation and also won one ward each in Kota Municipal Corporation and Suket municipality.

The BJP won two of the three pending wards in Kota Municipal Corporation and the lone pending ward in Jodhpur Municipal Corporation.



With the nine results, the BJP's final tally stands at 4,182 wards, while Congress has won 3,619 and Independents 2,273.

RLP won 63 wards, AAP 42, CPI(M) 38, BSP 19 and Bharat Adivasi Party eight.

Rajasthan has a total of 10,245 wards across 309 urban local bodies, but polling was held in 10,244. No election was held in Ward 2 of Tonk Municipal Council after all four candidates in the fray withdrew their nominations. A bypoll will be

held in the ward later.

The BJP surged ahead of the Congress in the urban local body elections, while Independents registered a strong presence across several civic bodies.

Meanwhile, the process for electing mayors and chairpersons is underway in 305 urban local bodies. Elections for mayors and chairpersons will be held on September 21, followed by elections for deputy mayors, deputy chairpersons and municipal vice-

presidents on September 22.

The State Election Commission on Thursday issued a separate schedule for Jaipur, Jodhpur and Kota municipal corporations and Suket municipality, where the process had been held back due to the repoll.

The public notice for election of mayors and chairpersons in these four bodies will be issued on September 18, nominations can be filed till September 19 and polling will be held from 10 am to 2 pm on September 25, followed by counting immediately thereafter.

Elections for deputy mayors, deputy chairpersons and vice-presidents in the four bodies will be held on September 26.

In the previous municipal election cycle held between November 2019 and February 2021, Rajasthan had 196 urban local bodies comprising 7,500 wards.

Punjab farmers protest on rail tracks, demand talks

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ferozepur

Farmers squatted on rail tracks at four places on Thursday to pressure the Punjab Government to hold talks with them and resolve their 12 demands, including a loan waiver and procurement of basmati, maize, moong, mustard, and potatoes at minimum support prices. The Kisan Mazdoor Morcha (KMM), which is leading the protest, said farmers sat on rail tracks in Mallanwala, Amritsar, Gurdaspur and Moga.

The KMM said they started the protest after issuing the state Government an ultimatum on Wednesday to meet their demands by 12 noon on September 17. The



organisation said if the state did not accept their demands, they planned to squat on the railway tracks. Among the demands, farmers want withdrawal of cases registered against farmers and workers who participated in previous agitations. On August 31, the farmers protested outside the offices of Deputy Commissioners across

Punjab and submitted a memorandum to the state Government listing its demands. Also, they staged 'dharnas' outside the residences and offices of several Cabinet ministers in the state. In Ferozepur, KMM leader Inderjit Singh Bath said that despite peaceful demonstrations, the Government failed to take effective steps on issues concerning farmers

and workers. Farmers' 12-point charter includes a complete loan waiver for farmers and farm workers, along with adequate compensation and Government jobs for families of farmers and workers who died by suicide.

They demanded an effective policy to tackle floods, groundwater depletion, and air and water pollution, as well as the distribution of river waters according to the riparian principle.

The protesters sought resolutions in the Punjab Assembly opposing the Seed Act, 2025; the Cooperative Act, 2026; the VB-G RAM G Act; and the Electricity Amendment Bill, 2025. They demanded an immediate halt to installing prepaid electricity metres in Punjab.

EPFO wage revision too little, too late: AITUC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ NEW DELHI

Terming the Union Cabinet's decision to hike the Employees' Provident Fund Organisation (EPFO) wage ceiling from ₹15,000 to ₹25,000 as "too little and too late", the All India Trade Union Congress (AITUC) has demanded that the limit be further raised to ₹30,000 to ensure broader social security coverage. In a statement issued here, AITUC General Secretary Amarjeet Kaur stated that the revision — coming after a 12-year gap since September 2014 — is a belated response to persistent demands from trade unions and employee representatives. AITUC noted



AITUC General Secretary Amarjeet Kaur

that the frozen limit of ₹15,000 had long become completely out of sync with rising wages, inflation, and the cost of living, thereby depriving millions of workers earning just above the earlier threshold of

mandatory social security. While advocating for a ₹30,000 ceiling, the trade union expressed serious concern over the potential impact on workers' monthly take-home pay. AITUC insisted that an

employer's statutory EPFO contribution must be paid over and above an employee's Cost to Company (CTC) structure, rather than being adjusted or deducted from their agreed wages.

To avoid similar delays in the future, the union urged the Central Government to establish a regular, automatic mechanism for the periodic revision of the wage ceiling instead of waiting for over a decade.

Furthermore, AITUC cautioned that expanding EPFO coverage should not remain a mere numerical exercise, calling for strict enforcement of statutory contributions to ensure meaningful pension, insurance, and provident fund benefits for the workforce.

Odisha BJP Govt failed to curtail price rise: BJD

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bhubaneswar

The Opposition BJD in Odisha on Thursday accused the BJP Government in the State of failing to control the rising prices of essential commodities that caused hardship to people.

Addressing a press conference, BJD spokesperson Mihir Ray pointed out that a report in August said the country's inflation rate stood at 4.82 per cent while the ratio was 5.52 per cent in Odisha.

"Among all the States in the country, Odisha's inflation rate was the fifth highest. Andhra Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh, Tamil Nadu and Telangana had higher inflation rates than Odisha," Ray claimed.

The BJD spokesperson said rural areas of Odisha have recorded a higher inflation rate at 5.90 per cent as compared to 4.47 per cent in urban localities. Due to the higher inflation rate, the prices of essential commodities,



ties, such as sugar, onions and edible oil, have increased substantially in the state, causing immense hardship to consumers, he claimed.

"The State Government is showing no urgency in taking effective measures to bring the rising inflation rate in Odisha under control," the BJD spokesperson said.

During the 2024-25 financial year, the national inflation rate stood at 4.6 per cent, while that of Odisha was 6 per cent, Ray claimed.

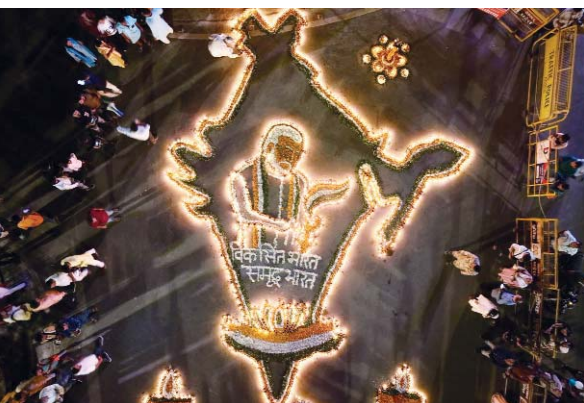
"Odisha's inflation rate has consistently been higher than the national inflation rate, while rural inflation has regularly remained higher than that of urban," he noted.

Lamp of blessings lit in prayers for PM Modi's long life

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ayodhya

On the occasion of Prime Minister Narendra Modi's birthday, a special programme was organised on Thursday by the Municipal Corporation at Lata Chowk on the banks of the Saryu. Under the leadership of Mayor Mahant Girishpati Tripathi, the "Aashirwad Ka Deep" (Lamp of Blessings) was lit to pray for Prime Minister Narendra Damodar Modi's long life and good health. Citizens, Batuk Brahmins and BJP workers took part in the programme.

On the occasion, Mayor Mahant Girishpati Tripathi said that Prime Minister Narendra Modi has shown through his leadership that India is rapidly moving towards becoming a global power. Under his leadership, a new story of development and progress is being written in every village. He said that the lamp lit by the people of Ayodhya on the



Prime Minister's birthday is a symbol of prayers for his long life and the nation's continuous development.

Attractive floral alpina designs were created at Lata Chowk for the lamp-lighting. Diyas were arranged to form a map of India, with a picture of Prime Minister Narendra Modi placed at the centre as the main attraction. Designs of Bharat Mata and other motifs were also decorated with flowers. A chain of lamps was arranged along

the edges, making the entire site look striking. As soon as the lamp was lit, the atmosphere at Lata Chowk turned devotional and festive.

The programme was attended by Municipal Commissioner Jayant Kumar, Additional Municipal Commissioner Bharat Bhargava, Chief Tax Assessment Officer Gajendra Kumar Singh, social worker Rajlakshmi Tripathi, social worker Bhaskar Shukla, and BJP workers.

Jarange calls off fast, gives 3 month's ultimatum to Govt

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Beed

Maratha quota activist Manoj Jarange on Thursday called off his 20-day-old fast, and warned the Maharashtra Government that he would take the protest to Mumbai if his demands over Maratha reservation were not considered in three months.

Jarange made the announcement after talks with a Government delegation which included ministers Radhakrishna Vikhe Patil, Dada Bhuse, MLC Prasad Lad and MLA Suresh Dhas and senior officials, at Patoda in Beed district.

The development came days after Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis said the Government won't tolerate any intimidating tactics and questioned the timing of the agitation during the ongoing Ganesh festival.

Fadnavis on Thursday welcomed Jarange's decision to end his fast, saying the



Government has already accepted 12 of his 13 demands and will fulfil each of them. During their meeting with Jarange in Patoda in Beed district, where the activist had halted on the way to Mumbai, the delegation members informed him about the steps initiated by the state Government for the Maratha quota.

Vikhe Patil suggested that Jarange should depute three representatives to monitor the progress of official work for considering his demands. "It will take around three to four months to act on the Kolhapur and Satara gazette

after a written comment is received from the advocate general," the minister said, and urged Jarange to call off his hunger strike.

Jarange said he is firm on his demand for "official recognition" of historical administrative records like the Hyderabad Gazette, Satara Gazette, and Aundh Gazette so Marathas can prove Kunbi lineage and claim OBC reservation benefits.

"The Government should give in writing that not a single 'Kunbi' record will be ignored. The chief minister should sign that paper," Manoj Jarange said.

State Govt to unveil master plan of future City at Invest Telangana Global Summit: CM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Hyderabad

Telangana Chief Minister A Revanth Reddy on Thursday said that the State Government would unveil the master plan of the Bharat Future City at the 'Invest Telangana Global Summit-2026' to be organised in December this year.

Speaking at the 'Praja Palana Dinotsavam' celebration organised here by the State Government to mark the anniversary of the merger of erstwhile princely state of Hyderabad under Nizam rule with the Indian Union, he said the 'Future City' (coming up on city outskirts) would feature specialised zones such as the Young India Skills University, a Life Sciences Hub, an EV Park, an AI City, a Health City, and an Education City.

He said TCS has come forward to build the country's largest AI data



centre in Future City with an investment of ₹70,000 crore. Amazon has already commenced the construction of a data centre with an investment of ₹one lakh crore. Recalling the merger of the Nizam's Hyderabad State with the Indian Union, he said the country's first Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru and his deputy Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel "enforced" military action known as 'Operation Polo' after recognising the aspirations and respecting the movements of the people of Hyderabad.



On the occasion of PM Narendra Modi's birthday, Surat youth Siddharth Doshi organised a special puja and darshan at the sacred Kedarnath Dham. He offered prayers for the Prime Minister's long life, good health and continued strength to serve the nation, as well as for India's peace, prosperity and welfare. For several years, Doshi has marked this day with special worship at major Jyotirlinga temples, including Kashi Vishwanath, Somnath and Ujjain Mahakaleshwar. This year he chose Kedarnath. He said India is advancing towards a developed nation under Modi's leadership, and that youth must uphold national service and pride. His aim is to inspire patriotism and the resolve of Viksit Bharat. Nation First. Service Supreme. Viksit Bharat is our resolve.

PHOTO PIONEER

MADHYA PRADESH URBAN DEVELOPMENT COMPANY LIMITED
(Department of Urban Development and Housing, Government of Madhya Pradesh)
Amarkantak Bhavan, Indra Complex, M.P. Nagar, Zone 1, Bhopal -462011
Phone : 91+755-2763060, 61, 62, Fax : 91+755-2763868
Email : mpustpbpl@gmail.com (CIN No. U75110MP2015SGC034139)
No. MPUDC/UDHD/2026/9542 Dated :16.09.2026

INVITATION FOR BIDS
Madhya Pradesh Urban Development Company Limited (MPUDC) invites online bids on www.mptenders.gov.in/nicgep/app MPUDC-MDB tenders from eligible bidders for the following sub-projects :-

S. No.	Description	Probable Amount (In Cr.)	Bid Start Date	Bid Closing Date
1.	RFP (Request for Proposal) for Procurement of Fire Tender (Nos. 127)	127.00	17.09.2026	15.10.2026
2.	RFP (Request for Proposal) for Procurement of Mini Water Tender with Mist Technology (Nos. 111)	33.30	17.09.2026	15.10.2026

2. Interested bidders may visit the website www.mptenders.gov.in/nicgep/app MPUDC-MDB tenders for further information and details. Invitation for Bids (IFB) for above packages can be viewed on website of MPUDC www.mpudc.co.in and on UDHD website www.mpurban.gov.in.

3. Any clarifications/further information or addenda to the Bidding Document shall be uploaded only on the above website and shall not be published separately in the newspapers.

M.P. Madhyam/128114/2026

CHIEF ENGINEER



Editor's
TAKE

Modi at 76: From longevity to legacy

As the BJP begins a month-long celebration of Modi's 25 years in power, the milestone invites a larger reckoning: what has his tenure changed, and at what cost?

Narendra Modi turned 76 on September 17th, and the BJP has converted the date into a month-long liturgy. The Seva Sankalp Abhiyan, launched on the birthday and running to October 17, pairs blood donation camps and cleanliness drives with bike yatras linking Vadnagar, his birthplace, to Varanasi, his constituency. The arithmetic behind the campaign is real: on October 7, he completes 25 years as a head of government - Gandhinagar from 2001, New Delhi since 2014. An unbroken quarter-century in executive office is rare in any democracy. Rarer still is the scale on which one man has rewritten the terms of a nation's politics. The ledger has substantial entries. Bank accounts, cooking gas, toilets, piped water and houses reached households that had waited three generations for the state to notice them. Digital public infrastructure – Aadhaar, UPI, direct benefit transfer – turned welfare from patronage into plumbing, and is now studied from Lagos to Lima.

Highways, ports and airports were built at a pace the licence-permit republic could not imagine. Article 370, the Ram temple, Chandrayaan-3, the G20 presidency and Operation Sindoor supplied the emotional grammar of a self-assured India. The economy grew 7.8 per cent in April-June, the fastest of any major economy, through a tariff war that was supposed to break it. In May, the BJP took West Bengal and a third term in Assam.

However, there have been gaps as well. Growth has not translated into work: unemployment among graduates under 25 runs near 40 per cent, and a quarter of India's youth are neither studying, training nor employed. Parliament legislates with less debate than it did in 1952. Investigative agencies move with a partisanship the opposition calls persecution, and the Election Commission's roll revisions have drawn charges the ECI has failed to convincingly answer. Federalism has shrunk to an argument over transfers.

Polarisation has been an instrument rather than an accident, and minorities have been at the receiving end. Demonetisation remains the costliest experiment no one has been held accountable for. Then came June. A satirical outfit calling itself the Cockroach Janta Party turned an exam-leak scandal into the largest youth mobilisation in decades, and a government famous for never conceding, conceded – a minister resigned, demands were met, a task force was announced. It was the first genuine retreat since the farm laws. It exposed the single constituency that remains defiant: young Indians who have known no other prime minister and cannot find a job.

But then such challenges are part of the deal. What occupies him now? Viksit Bharat 2047 is the stated horizon. The nearer list is harder – closing the American trade agreement without surrendering agriculture; the 2027 census and the delimitation that follows, which risks setting a growing North against an already resentful South; and the succession he refuses to discuss, the seventy-five rule he once applied to Advani having quietly lapsed for himself. Longevity is not legacy. The question at 76 is whether the coming years are spent consolidating what he built, or making it survivable without him.

The NE borders need eyes in the sky

The Northeast's borders cannot always be secured with fences. Shifting rivers, porous terrain and difficult frontiers demand something more agile: space-based surveillance that can turn satellite data into timely, actionable and legally usable intelligence. Assam's experience shows why the next frontier of border security is not more fencing, but faster information



BHASKAR
JYOTI
MAHANTA

In a riverine char (sandbar) of the Dhubri sector, perhaps 400 families might live in one season, but by the next season, it could be completely obliterated. The Brahmaputra creates and destroys land at its own will. When the char disappears, the families move away, and with them, the border too changes. This is the actual functional reality of approximately 61 kilometres of Assam's border with Bangladesh, where electronic surveillance has to be adopted instead of fencing, because there is no hard soil there to erect a fence. You cannot put a fence in water. You can only monitor it.

I was reminded of this while chairing a recent discussion organised by SIA-India in Guwahati on 'Space Technology for National Security and Border Protection'. This panel included a former Army Commander of the Eastern Theatre, a senior telecom administrator and scientist, a national security expert, and representatives of two new Indian satellite-manufacturing enterprises – institutions that did not exist a decade ago.

Assam has approximately 263 kilometres of border with Bangladesh, a large portion of which is riverine. To our east, we have a 1,643-kilometre border with Myanmar, where governmental authority has largely collapsed, and the resulting drug economy fuels insurgency. To our north, we have a neighbouring country that refuses to recognise Arunachal Pradesh as Indian and has established 628 border villages near the Line of Actual Control (LAC), the majority of which are located opposite Arunachal. And this country plans to construct a dam on a river upon which 70 million Indian people depend.

Three borders, three distinct problems. Our difficulty is not a lack of military strength. Our primary problem is 'latency' – that is, the time gap between an event occurring on the ground and the right person becoming aware of it. This is where aerospace or space technology becomes necessary.

What would remain if space-based communications, navigation and imaging technologies were disrupted for 72 hours in the Eastern Theatre? If the adversary is using state-of-the-art satellite systems and we revert to older methods in an eventuality, the enemy won't even need to defeat us; rather, we ourselves would be handing them the initiative.

Satellite-derived information today is neither intelligence nor evidence for a police officer. In the sense an operational officer understands it, it is not intelligence, because intelligence must arrive in a timely manner and have someone



ASSAM HAS APPROXIMATELY 263 KILOMETRES OF BORDER WITH BANGLADESH, A LARGE PORTION OF WHICH IS RIVERINE. TO OUR EAST, WE HAVE A 1,643-KILOMETRE BORDER WITH MYANMAR, WHERE GOVERNMENTAL AUTHORITY HAS LARGELY COLLAPSED, AND THE RESULTING DRUG ECONOMY FUELS INSURGENCY

The writer is a former DGP of Assam

operational domain. The Indian Space Policy of 2023 and IN-SPaCe opened this sector to private-sector capabilities, and 52 satellite surveillance programmes are currently underway. A decade ago, none of this was clear. But for reaching the 'last mile', the robust management of institutional rules and procedures is essential. Two mishaps this year make this clear:

In January, due to a launch failure, a DRDO Earth observation system was lost.

Two months after entering orbit, a historic Indian private satellite (the world's first to combine radar and optical sensors) was destroyed due to a geomagnetic storm.

Self-reliance is not just the ability to build a satellite once; it is the ability to rapidly replace new satellites, coupled with indigenous launch speed, domestic hardware and procurement processes completed in 90 days instead of 90 weeks.

What should this region do?

The Northeastern states should issue a standing order by allocating budgets for all-weather radar coverage of rivers and flood-prone areas from Indian satellites. For this necessary platform for geo-stationary satellites/constellations must be put in place. Demand builds an industrial base, and at the state level, 'self-reliance' begins with a purchase order for satellite products.

Leverage Existing Infrastructure: Instead of building a new centre from scratch, work upon the existing mechanism. The North Eastern Space Applications Centre (NESAC), based in Umiam, is already serving these eight states; provide it with a border-and-disaster wing operated jointly by the state police, border security forces and disaster management teams.

Build a Geospatial Cadre: Develop our own analysts and commentators through a geospatial cadre trained in our own institutions, because sovereignty depends equally on people as it does on hardware. Enforce Sovereign Contracts: Incorporate sovereignty conditions into contracts; there should be no 'shutter control', no geographical restrictions, or any such conditions that give a foreign supplier the authority to dictate what and when we see.

The satellite surveillance system that exposes illegal infiltration or crossing can also reveal the condition of river embankments and the likelihood of breaches. The same imagery that serves border agencies in January can assist District Commissioners (DCs) in August. In a state where floods render more people homeless every year than any enemy attack could, this is not a minor facility to be mentioned in passing. The necessity of satellites in the Northeast should not only be proven in a 'war room'; it should also be considered an integral part of wartime preparations to be undertaken during the monsoon season.

Daiv Vani

WISDOM FOR A MEANINGFUL LIFE

The Boy Who Won by Staying Home

Once, Ganesha and his brother Kartikeya were challenged to a race around the world, with the prize going to whoever completed the circuit first. Kartikeya immediately set off on his peacock, eager to cover every continent and ocean.

Ganesha, instead, simply walked around his parents, Shiva and Parvati, seated together, and declared himself finished, explaining that they represented the entire universe to him, making a literal journey around the world unnecessary. His parents, moved by the depth of his understanding, declared him the winner.

We often equate achievement with distance covered, hours logged, or effort visibly displayed, mistaking motion for meaning. Ganesha's wisdom lay in recognizing that some truths do not require circling the globe to be understood, only clarity about what truly matters.

We chase external milestones, promotions, recognition, achievements, believing they will bring us closer to fulfilment, while overlooking the people and truths already within our reach.

Today, pause and ask whether what you're chasing is truly necessary, or whether what matters most is already present, closer than you think.

—DAIV

When community ends at the gate



SANJAY
CHANDRA

2ND OPINION

We recently attended a few Ganesh Chaturthi celebrations at the homes of friends in our condominium complex. Tower lobbies were buzzing with people in their best ethnic wear, carrying offerings for Lord Ganesh. At one home, our host had invited a flautist friend, who rendered a few bhajans on his flute. These intimate gatherings also allowed guests to mingle. Such gatherings at home are, of course, nothing new. What made me think was something else. The larger community celebration itself appears to be changing. Increasingly, in our urban centres, it seems to be moving from the wider neighbourhood into gated residential complexes. I remember that the only large community celebration during my childhood was the Ram Leela, held on whichever was the biggest available ground in the neighbourhood. Much later, I witnessed the Durga Puja

pandals in the east, Ganesh Chaturthi celebrations in the west and Dussehra festivities in the south. Beyond their religious and cultural significance, they performed another function. Minor acquaintances, or even strangers, bumped into each other. Conversations began. Some developed into lifelong relationships. There were no gates defining who belonged to that community.

Urban living has changed since then. High-rise condominium complexes have created neighbourhoods of their own, comprising hundreds or thousands of families. Almost everything we need is available within the boundaries. Groceries and meals arrive at our doors. There are shops, clubs, gyms and play areas. We want entertainment within the complex and, increasingly, even religious places and festivities within walking distance of our homes.

Convenience is undoubtedly a part of this change. Security is another. After a tiring day, few of us want to travel across the city for something that can be found downstairs. But I sometimes wonder whether, without consciously intending it, we are also shrinking the boundaries of what we consider our community. The neighbourhood once extended beyond the people we knew. A festival took us into public spaces where we encountered people from different backgrounds and circumstances. Today, the gates of a condominium can quietly determine whom we meet, whom our children play with and, increasingly, whom we celebrate with.

Digital technology may be reinforcing this tendency in another way. Residential groups allow us to communicate

instantly and have made community management far easier. But they have also given everyone the ability to critique virtually every decision immediately. Resident welfare associations can consequently find themselves trying to accommodate every demand and appease every section, forgetting that this is rarely possible. The discussion then becomes increasingly about what should or should not happen inside our gates.

None of this means that condominium communities are undesirable. They provide companionship, security and a sense of familiarity that is valuable in increasingly impersonal cities. Nor is there anything wrong with celebrating festivals within them. The issue is whether these communities are becoming substitutes for the wider neighbourhood rather than a part of it. Perhaps the change is subtle enough for us not to notice. The neighbourhood becomes the condominium, the condominium becomes the tower, and gradually our social world begins to end at the gate.

I enjoyed those intimate Ganesh Chaturthi evenings immensely. Yet they left me with a question quite unrelated to the celebrations themselves. Are the gates around our homes also slowly becoming gates around our idea of community? And if everything we need – social, cultural, recreational and even religious – must increasingly come within those gates, are we developing an exclusivity without even recognising it?

The writer is a founder of Kala - Krazy About Literature And Arts, and is an author, speaker, coach, arbitrator and strategy consultant

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Bamboo can build a greener future

As we approach World Bamboo Day on September 18, it is time to recognise a remarkable plant that holds immense cultural and ecological value. Known variously as 'green gold' and 'poor man's timber', bamboo is an environmental powerhouse, with over 1,500 species capable of thriving across diverse climates.

Globally, bamboo is deeply woven into human traditions, symbolising uprightness in China, friendship in India, prosperity in Japan, and standing proudly as the national plant of St Lucia.

Economically, China leads global production, closely followed by India. Beyond traditional uses such as construction, paper and furniture, bamboo serves as food, medicine, musical instruments, martial arts equipment and even a medium for seawater desalination. More importantly, it is a vital ally in combating climate change. Bamboo absorbs carbon dioxide, improves soil health and prevents erosion.

To fully harness these benefits, institutions such as India's Forest Research Centre for Bamboo & Rattan (FRCBR), established in Aizawl, Mizoram, in 2004, are leading crucial research into sustainable cultivation. Promoting bamboo is not just an ecological choice; it is an economic necessity for a truly greener tomorrow.

M PRADYU | KANNUR

Celebrating service through action

Prime Minister Narendra Modi's birthday on September 17 has been accompanied by several programmes centred on public service and social welfare. Across the country, activities related to cleanliness, health, voluntary service and community participation are being organised. Such initiatives provide an opportunity to draw attention to issues that directly affect everyday life.

The observance also coincides with the nationwide Swachhata Hi Seva campaign, which seeks to encourage citizens to participate in cleanliness drives and improve public spaces. Special attention to sanitation workers is another important aspect of the programme. Clean surroundings require regular public participation and cannot be achieved through government efforts alone.

Service-oriented activities such as blood-donation drives and community programmes can encourage citizens, particularly young people, to contribute to society. Participation by students, voluntary organisations and local communities can also strengthen awareness of civic duties and social responsibility.

Their impact should extend beyond the celebrations. Sustained attention to cleanliness, public health and community service can give greater meaning to public service.

RUKMA SHARMA | JALANDHAR

Youth campaign takes aim at UP

"Uttar Pradesh, once known for its culture, struggle and unity, has today become identified with hatred and bulldozers," AISA president Neha Bora said in a speech in Lucknow on Wednesday, September 16, launching a fresh attack on the Yogi Adityanath government as her 'Gen Z Rising' campaign drew a large gathering of young people. Bora's remarks came at a programme at Gandhi Bhawan, where the sizeable gathering raised slogans in her support. Her campaign, which began at Allahabad University last month, has travelled through several districts and is now seeking to build wider youth mobilisation across the state.

Bora has emerged as one of the more visible young voices directly challenging the state government through the campaign. The campaign is also attempting to move beyond campus politics by taking up wider issues concerning young people, including education, employment and governance.

Its progress through different districts is aimed at creating a network that can sustain the mobilisation beyond individual programmes. The campaign's focus on youth participation reflects an effort to bring education, employment and governance into broader public discussion.

BHAGWAN THADANI | MUMBAI

PICTALK



Priests perform 'abhishek' during the Maha Kumbabhishekam ceremony, of the renowned Sri Meenakshi Sundareswarar Temple, in Madurai

PHOTO: PTI

Delhi’s unsafe buildings: Disaster is round the corner

Delhi’s recurring building collapses expose gaps in enforcement, emergency access and disaster preparedness. The article argues for identifying high-risk structures, strengthening safety regulations, using technology for monitoring, and training local communities so that disasters can be prevented rather than managed afterwards



SATENDRA SINGH

A building has collapsed in Satya Niketan, there have been casualties, and rescue operations are on in full swing. But soon enough, as always happens in such situations, debris will be cleared and media attention will shift to something else. However, what needs to be asked is: "Does the risk apply only to the collapsing building, or does it also involve all the other buildings which still stand strong?"

In case another building were to collapse, or in case another fire or earthquake were to occur in this area, would Delhi’s emergency services machinery be able to respond in time to save those caught inside? This is precisely what went through my mind when I visited Satya Niketan after the last incident. What I saw was very disturbing indeed: densely populated buildings, narrow pathways which appear to be obstructed, and no open ground where fire engines, ambulances or any other emergency vehicle can rush to the spot. The tragedy, thus, may not just be one of a collapsed building but much more than that.

Building collapses, fires and other disasters of the kind have been happening too frequently in our national capital. From our analysis of several such disasters in the past that took place in the Delhi/NCR region, we know that the same story keeps repeating itself — the lack of authorisation in construction, alterations in the structure, extra floors, poor-quality materials, overcrowding, lack of fire safety measures and, most importantly, the failure of enforcement. While each such incident brings about shock, statements from politicians, investigations and promises, the truth is that the risk does not stay confined to the particular structure.

The issue is not that there are not enough rules in Delhi. There are the Unified Building Bye-Laws, the Fire Safety Regulations, the Planning Provisions and the Disaster Management Act. There are municipal corporations, development authorities, fire services and other organisations charged with responsibility for the respective urban security issues. However, the frequent emergencies demonstrate a critical lack of correlation between the written laws and their enforcement. It may happen that a construction begins without appropriate permission, a building is given extra floors, a residence is turned into a business place, or structural modifications are done without the necessary technical assessment. Sometimes, complaints have been filed and notices have been sent, but there is no effective reaction. The outcome is a dangerous situation in which the private gain from hazardous construction is achieved by a few individuals, while the threat itself is faced by residents, students, neighbours, firefighters and the whole community.

The problem is much more acute in crowded areas. A building may look sturdy under ordinary circumstances, but could become highly susceptible under the effect of fire, rain, an earthquake or any such sudden impact. Narrow alleys or crowded roads could exacerbate the situation. An emergency vehicle such as a fire engine, an ambulance or heavy machinery would not be able to access the building in time. If there are no available exits, or stairways are insufficient or crowded, then even a minor incident could cause a catastrophe. The crucial minutes at the beginning are those that could be lost because of a lack of proper planning and preparation.

This is precisely why Delhi needs to shift gears from the reactive mode to the preventive mode. Emergency operations are required but should not be the primary means to address the problem of unsafe buildings. It is impossible to fix an unsafe building by conducting a better rescue operation once people get stuck inside. What needs to be done is to pinpoint the potential risk areas prior to any accident. High-risk buildings and clusters of high-risk populations need to be identified and tested for structural soundness and fire safety standards. Defective buildings will need to be either fixed, strengthened, modified or even demolished. These assessments should not degenerate into just another paperwork exercise. There has to be accountability and timeliness attached to



SATYA NIKETAN IS NOT MERELY AN EXAMPLE OF YET ANOTHER COLLAPSE; IT IS ALSO A REMINDER OF THE TYPE OF URBAN GROWTH WE ARE SEEING IN DELHI. THE CITY CANNOT AFFORD TO ACCEPT HAZARDOUS BUILDINGS AS A PART AND PARCEL OF URBAN GROWTH. ECONOMIC GROWTH AND SAFETY ARE TWO ENTIRELY DIFFERENT CONCERNS; IN TRUTH, THERE CAN NEVER BE ANY ECONOMIC DEVELOPMENT WITHOUT STRUCTURAL AND FIRE SAFETY MEASURES

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them. These processes can become more streamlined with the use of technology. Plans and permissions granted for construction must be digitised and easily verifiable. Any construction that violates the approved plan must attract an immediate inspection. Where negligence can be proven, liability must extend beyond the owner of the property to include the approving agencies, among others. Enforcement cannot be selective or based on the level of media interest after an accident.

But there is one more aspect that cannot be neglected - the community. In every disaster situation, local residents become the first responders. Before the arrival of fire services, policemen, ambulances or any rescue team, local residents may be involved in rescuing people, giving first aid, informing the services about the situation and finding out who could still be trapped. Their reaction in the initial minutes of a disaster can determine whether people will survive. But the preparations of communities to respond to disaster situations in most vulnerable localities remain mostly informal and disorganised.

Thus, Delhi needs to build the capacities of community-based organisations, local residents, volunteers, market associations and other local networks in disaster-prone areas. They do not need much equipment in the beginning. What they require is some basic training in evacuation, first aid, dealing with fires, emergency communications, identification of vulnerable people and coordination with services such as policemen, firemen and health professionals. They should practise emergency drills in schools, markets, residential colonies and other crowded places. Volunteers should be aware of the emergency numbers, access roads and safe assembly points in their area. This is a relatively inexpensive but effective measure.

The government should not only focus on individual buildings but also consider neighbourhood risks. In cases where new high-density developments and activities need to take place, the local authorities should consider some very basic questions: Can emergency vehicles reach the building? Are there any safe means of evacuation? Can firefighters go up the floors in case of an emergency? Are the buildings strong enough to withstand the stress? What will happen if more than one building is affected in the event of an earthquake or fire?

Satya Niketan is not merely an example of yet another collapse; it is also a reminder of the type of urban growth we are seeing in Delhi. The city cannot afford to accept hazardous buildings as a part and parcel of urban growth. Economic growth and safety are two entirely different concerns; in truth, there can never be any economic development without structural and fire safety measures.

Disaster readiness is not about how quickly we manage to rescue people from a collapsed building; it is about preventing a disaster before the collapse. Satya Niketan should not end up being another entry on Delhi’s list of tragic stories. It should be a lesson that results in change. The next building should not collapse before we find out its dangerous condition.

India’s energy transition: Managing redistribution



JAY GANESH PANDEY

GOPAL K SARANGI

India’s energy transition discourse is often portrayed as a singular shift away from a fossil-centric energy regime towards a low-carbon energy system. In reality, it is a far more complex transformation, dynamically unfolding across resources, technologies, industries, markets and regulations. Coal is being gradually replaced (and often supplemented) by solar and wind; internal combustion engines are giving way to electric mobility; centralised electricity systems are evolving towards distributed,

decentralised energy systems; industries are adopting cleaner and more efficient production processes; and governance is shifting from state-led planning towards competitive markets, private finance and carbon-based investment mechanisms.

Policy instruments for renewable energy have also undergone a profound transformation, from historical incentive structures such as accelerated depreciation (AD) and generation-based incentives (GBI) to feed-in tariffs and, more recently, market-determined reverse auctions. However, these transition pathways are disruptive in nature, often dismantling existing fossil-based supply-chain architectures and forging new supply-chain linkages. For instance, India’s existing energy regime is slowly and systematically becoming disconnected from fossil-heavy energy pathways, shifting towards low-carbon options such as moving from coal to renewables, from traditional cooking fuels to modern cooking options, and from diesel-based irrigation facilities to solar PV-based irrigation systems. At the same time, new linkages are being established in many distinct ways, such as through the electrification of transport systems using electric vehicles (EVs), sourcing critical minerals for batteries, and forging new resource linkages for green hydrogen systems.

Each of these transition pathways, while generating new opportunities for economic growth and climate action, also disrupts socio-economic structures and functions by redistributing costs, risks and benefits across workers, communities, firms and regions. These effects appear in the form of both first-order and second-order impacts, often conceptualised as implementation risks and consequential risks.

Effects of the transition

The first-order effects of India’s energy transition are relatively visible, direct and immediate. They arise directly from changes in resources, technologies, policies and markets. When coal production declines, miners, contract workers, transporters, coal-bearing districts and state governments dependent on mining royalties face immediate socio-economic losses. Around 13 million workers are tied to the coal value chain in India and are expected to bear the brunt eventually. In the same vein, such a shift in resources from fuels to metals could generate stranded assets. Estimates suggest that close to 10 per cent of new coal units in India will remain unused by 2030. Conversely, renewable energy developers, equipment manufacturers, financial institutions, technology providers and regions endowed with high solar and wind potential become the primary beneficiaries of new investment flows. The more consequential risks often emerge as second-order effects that unfold over time. The loss of coal-based livelihoods can weaken local economies, reduce public revenues and trigger migration, potentially disturbing existing local economic structures. Meanwhile, renewable investments may generate jobs in different regions and require entirely different skill sets, potentially widening regional inequalities. Battery energy storage systems require adequate supplies of scarce critical minerals, which are largely imported by India. This could aggravate supply-security risks for a country like India. The production of green hydrogen is contingent upon a continuous supply of green energy, adequate supplies of pure water and other associated resources, which are again either inadequate or scarce. Competing demands for such resources could generate negative spillover effects for India if not managed well.



Managing the redistribution

As the energy transition is fundamentally a redistribution of economic value, policy must focus beyond carbon accounting towards distributional governance. The redistribution is not limited to income; it encompasses employment, investment, public revenues, assets, economic opportunities and transition risks. These are likely to shift across sectors, regions and communities. A robust institutional framework is therefore required to assess not only the aggregate impacts of the transition, but also their magnitude, distribution and incidence. Given that coal still accounts for around 70 per cent of India’s electricity generation, it is also important to mainstream distributional impact assessments into energy policymaking, ensuring that the economic winners and losers of major energy reforms are identified before implementation. Coal also makes significant contributions to the government’s exchequer. In 2024-25, coal mining generated around ₹1.10 lakh crore in royalties, DMF, NMET, GST, coal cess and other payments. A transition benefit-sharing framework needs to be developed that channels a part of clean-energy dividends into coal-dependent regions through investments in economic diversification, skills, social protection and local infrastructure.

Equally important is investing in people rather than just projects by supporting reskilling, local enterprises and regional supply chains so that transition benefits remain embedded within affected communities.

History reminds us that no great economic transformation has ever been neutral. When factories replaced farms during the Industrial Revolution, prosperity grew, but so did inequalities. When India liberalised its economy in 1991, new industries flourished, cities expanded and millions found opportunities, while others struggled to adapt to a rapidly changing marketplace. India’s clean-energy transition is writing the next chapter of that story. It promises cleaner air, energy security and new economic opportunities. Its success will ultimately be measured not only in gigawatts installed or tonnes of carbon avoided, but also by whether the prosperity it creates is as widely shared as the climate benefits it delivers.

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BRICS Summit success reflects India’s rising global leadership



RAJESH KUMAR SINGH

The successful conclusion of the 18th BRICS Summit in New Delhi has once again demonstrated India’s growing influence in shaping the global conversation. More importantly, the summit reflected the vision, diplomatic maturity and decisive leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, under whose guidance India has increasingly emerged as a confident and constructive voice on the world stage.

Held under the theme “Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability”, the summit brought together leaders of the expanded BRICS grouping at a time when the world is facing geopolitical tensions, economic uncertainty, technological disruption and growing challenges to multilateral cooperation. The adoption of the New Delhi Declaration by consensus was one of the most significant outcomes of the summit and a strong endorsement of India’s leadership. The success becomes even more significant considering the diversity of the expanded BRICS grouping. Its members have different political systems, economic structures, strategic interests and regional priorities. Bringing such a diverse group together around a common agenda requires sustained dialogue, mutual respect and the ability

to build consensus. India demonstrated precisely these qualities during its chairship. Prime Minister Modi has consistently advocated a foreign policy based on dialogue, cooperation and strategic autonomy. This approach was clearly visible during the BRICS Summit. Rather than allowing differences among member countries to overshadow areas of common interest, India focused on practical cooperation in areas that directly affect the lives and livelihoods of people.

The scale of India’s BRICS chairship itself underlines the seriousness with which the country approached the responsibility. More than 400 meetings and engagements were held across 30 cities, involving ministers, parliamentarians, officials, experts, businesses and civil society representatives. The wide geographical spread of these engagements helped take BRICS beyond a leaders-only platform and brought different sections of society into the process.

A particularly important aspect of India’s leadership was its emphasis on the Global South. India has repeatedly argued that developing and emerging economies must have a stronger voice in institutions of global governance. The New Delhi Declaration reaffirmed the BRICS commitment to greater representation of emerging markets and developing countries in global decision-making structures. It also called for reforms in institutions such as the United Nations, the IMF, the World Bank and the WTO.

This is consistent with Prime Minister Modi’s



broader vision of India as a bridge between developed and developing nations. India’s own development experience gives it credibility when it speaks about digital inclusion, financial inclusion, technology, sustainable development and affordable solutions for developing societies.

Economic cooperation was a major pillar of the summit. Under India’s chairship, BRICS advanced work on the Economic Partnership Strategy 2030, resilient global value chains and greater economic cooperation. Discussions on cross-border payments and local currencies also continued.

India’s emphasis on innovation was equally significant. Technology and science are increasingly important to economic competitiveness and social development. The summit placed innovation, science and technology at the heart of BRICS cooperation, including emerging technologies and knowledge sharing.

The summit also focused on sustainable development, climate action, healthcare, urban development, women-led development and youth cooperation, highlighting BRICS as a platform for cooperation on issues directly affecting ordinary citizens. India’s chairship also highlighted the importance of people-to-people relations. Business, youth, women, academic, parliamentary and civil society forums formed an important part of the year-long engagement. Such initiatives can help BRICS evolve from an intergovernmental platform into a broader partnership among societies.

Prime Minister Modi’s leadership has been particularly important in maintaining India’s ability to engage simultaneously with countries that may have competing interests. India’s approach has been to keep channels of dialogue open, protect national interests and seek areas where cooperation is possible. This balanced diplomacy has enhanced India’s credibility as an independent and reliable partner.

The New Delhi Summit therefore represents more than the successful hosting of an international event. It is a reflection of India’s changing place in the world. The fact that BRICS leaders specifically commended India’s 2026 chairship and expressed gratitude to the Government and people of India for hosting the summit is an important recognition of the country’s stewardship.

The summit has also strengthened the idea that the Global South need not remain merely an observer in the making of the international

order. India has increasingly sought to ensure that developing nations have a meaningful voice in discussions on global finance, trade, technology, climate change, development and international security. For Prime Minister Modi, the successful BRICS Summit is another milestone in India’s continuing diplomatic journey. His emphasis on consensus, cooperation, innovation and inclusive development has helped India project itself as a country willing to shoulder greater responsibility in global affairs. The message from New Delhi is clear: India is no longer simply responding to changes in the international system; it is increasingly helping shape the conversation about its future.

The successful conclusion of the BRICS Summit, the unanimous adoption of the New Delhi Declaration, the extensive programme conducted during India’s chairship and the broad agenda covering economic growth, technology, sustainable development and Global South cooperation together make the summit a significant achievement. It is, above all, a testament to India’s growing diplomatic confidence and Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s leadership at a time when the world needs greater dialogue, cooperation and trust.

The New Delhi Summit has strengthened India’s position as a key voice of the Global South and as an important force in building a more balanced, inclusive and cooperative global order.

The writer is a political analyst



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Order Order

SC asks medical body to explain delay in stipend

The Supreme Court on Thursday directed the National Medical Commission to submit an affidavit and explain why the stipend to foreign medical graduates is not being given in some colleges.

A bench comprising Justices Aravind Kumar and Vipul M Pancholi also asked the Rajasthan Government to disperse the stipend to students within two weeks.

The top court warned that in case of non-compliance, the state secretary will be summoned to the court.

During the hearing, advocate Tanvi Dubey, appearing for the petitioners, submitted a chart stating that there are certain colleges which are not paying any stipend to the foreign medical graduates.

She further submitted that there is a circular of the National Medical Commission (NMC) itself which provides that there has to be parity between the Indian and foreign medical graduates.

However, despite that, there is no parity in most of the states when it comes to payment of stipend to the foreign and Indian medical graduates while they are doing the same kind of duties and putting in the same kind of hours.

The top court has now posted the matter for hearing after two weeks. The NMC had earlier informed the top court that seven out of 756 medical colleges have not been paying stipends to interns, junior residents or senior residents, and show-cause notices have been issued to them. (PTI)



Kiran Bedi moves Delhi HC in building collapse case

Retired IPS officer Kiran Bedi on Thursday approached the Delhi High Court seeking to be made a party in a matter concerning the collapse of a hostel building in Satya Niketan that left seven people dead.

Additional Solicitor General Chetan Sharma, appearing for the Centre, Delhi Government and the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD), however, opposed Bedi's application and sought time to file objections. "What reply will you file? She is a conscientious citizen of the country. She has administrative experience. The matter is in larger public interest," a bench of Chief Justice D K Upadhyaya and Justice Tejas Karia told the law officer.

The bench said that Bedi, who also served as the lieutenant governor of Puducherry, was seeking to intervene in the case only to assist the court and her "long experience" could always be utilised.

ASG Sharma submitted that while he held Bedi in "great esteem", her application seeking intervention demonstrated that she was "pre-judging" the matter in which the authorities were yet to file status reports.

Asking them not to view it adversarially, the court gave the authorities three days to file their replies to Bedi's plea and listed it for hearing along with the main matter on September 25. The building at Satya Niketan, which housed a boys' paying-guest accommodation near the Delhi University's South Campus, collapsed on September 6 while repair work was underway. Seven people died in the collapse, while several others were injured. On September 7, the high court ordered a high-level MCD inquiry into the building collapse and made it clear that the Government cannot evade responsibility. (PTI)



SC suggests 3-language policy from class 6

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New delhi

The Supreme Court on Thursday asked the CBSE to consider implementing its policy mandating the study of three languages, including two native Indian languages, for Class 6 students from the next academic session starting 2027.

The Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE), represented by Additional Solicitor General Aishwarya Bhati, told the bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and justices Joyimalya Bagchi and V Mohana that it would consider the suggestion. Justice Bagchi, at the outset, said that just to comfort the children, the CBSE should

consider deferring the implementation of the three-language policy from the next academic year.

If the students, who are in Class 6 at present, want to study three languages from this year, they can also be allowed, Justice Bagchi added.

The law officer said that the CBSE would consider the suggestion and come back with a fresh note on the issue.

The bench said its suggestions were without prejudice to the rights and contentions of the parties and the real issues may be decided later.

Earlier, the Centre and the CBSE told the bench that they were working on its suggestions on implementing the policy mandating the study of three languages, including



two native Indian languages, for Class 6 students.

On May 27, the top court agreed to examine a plea challenging the policy and issued notices to the Centre, the CBSE and the NCERT seeking their responses.

According to a circular issued by the CBSE, the study

of three languages, including at least two native Indian languages, has been made compulsory for Class 9 students beginning July 1.

"Every student in Class 9 would study three languages. Out of the three languages, at least two would be Bhartiya Bhashas. Examples of Bhartiya

Bhashas: Hindi, Sanskrit, Tamil, Telugu, Kannada, Malayalam, Marathi, Bengali, Punjabi, Gujarati, Odia, Assamese, etc. Examples of non-native languages: English, French, German, Arabic, Spanish, etc." the CBSE had said in its statement.

Two Indian languages have been made mandatory for Class 6, with some relaxations for Classes 7, 8 and 9 students, who were studying two non-native languages.

The move is part of the CBSE's alignment of its scheme of studies with the National Education Policy-2020 and the National Curriculum Framework for School Education-2023.

According to the circular issued on May 15, students

opting for a foreign language may do so only as the third language after studying two native Indian languages, or as an additional fourth language.

"With effect from July 1, 2026, for Class 9, the study of three languages (R1, R2, R3) shall be compulsory, with at least two languages being native Indian languages," the circular said.

The board said till the dedicated R3 textbooks are available, Class 9 students shall use Class 6 R3 textbooks (2026-27 edition) of the chosen language. The CBSE said that to keep the focus on learning and reduce any undue pressure on students, no board examination shall be conducted for R3 at the Class 10 level.

Former Keralam DGP sentenced to four years' RI in disproportionate assets case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kottayam (Keralam)

A court on Thursday sentenced former state DGP Tomin J Thachankary to four years of rigorous imprisonment in a case related to amassing wealth disproportionate to his known sources of income.

This is the first case in Keralam in which an officer of DGP rank has been sentenced for possessing assets disproportionate to his known sources of income, according to reports.

Kottayam Vigilance Court judge K V Rajanish found Thachankary guilty under the Prevention of Corruption Act.

The court also imposed a fine of ₹30.84 lakh on the former IPS officer. The court ordered Thachankary to be shifted to Poojapura Central Jail in Thiruvananthapuram where he can approach the Kerala High Court with an appeal against the verdict.

During the final hearing, Thachankary requested that the court consider his health condition while pronouncing the sentence. The prosecution, however, submitted that no leniency should be shown



considering the post he had held. As many as 96 prosecution witnesses and 271 documents were examined during the trial, while 23 defence witnesses were examined and 55 defence documents were marked.

The Vigilance and Anti-Corruption Bureau (VACB) Special Cell, Ernakulam, had registered the case against Thachankary for allegedly amassing wealth disproportionate to his known sources of income.

According to the prosecution, the VACB investigation found expenditure amounting to ₹64.70 lakh for which Thachankary could not account for corresponding sources of income.

The investigation team

found that he had allegedly acquired assets 135.80 per cent in excess of his known sources of income during the period between 2003 and 2007.

Vigilance Public Prosecutor K K Sreekanth appeared for the prosecution in the case.

"It is a serious crime that a high-ranking police officer, who is bound to protect the life and property of the public, illegally acquired wealth in this manner," Sreekanth said. He welcomed the verdict. "At this moment, this verdict is most favourable to the prosecution. Further actions will be decided in the coming days in consultation with the Vigilance Director," he said.

He said that all the contentions of the prosecution were accepted by the court.

"Today's ruling further proves that no matter how high-ranking an officer is, they are bound by the law under the Vigilance. Equal justice for everyone," he said.

Bobby Kuruvilla and Alexander Kuruvilla, the complainants in the disproportionate assets case against Thachankary said they were satisfied with the verdict.

Patna HC quashes anti-social tags against two, orders compensation

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New delhi

The Patna High Court has quashed the Bihar Government's branding of two persons as "anti-social elements" and restricting their movement, holding that the move had been taken without proper verification and directing the administration to pay a compensation of ₹1 lakh each to the men.

A division bench of Justices Rajeev Ranjan Prasad and Sunil Dutta Mishra, in an order dated September 11, also awarded ₹10,000 each for litigation costs.

The petitioners Shashi Kumar alias Fukan and Ajay Singh had challenged proceedings initiated against

them after the Nalanda superintendent of police recommended that they be noted as "anti-social elements" based on a report submitted by the Rajgir sub-divisional police officer (SDPO) during last year's assembly polls.

They contended that they had been falsely implicated in criminal cases and were already on bail. Cases under the Bihar Crime Control Act (BCCA) were registered, following which the Nalanda district magistrate issued show-cause notices to the petitioners on September 10, 2025 for appearing before competent authorities.

"It was further stated that the petitioners failed to submit any cogent material in



support of their defence before the DM, and accordingly, it was held that the free movement of the petitioners would cause problem to law and order in the locality," the court order said.

"We have noticed from the pattern of the order(s) passed by the DM, Nalanda that his orders are in the nature of cut-and-paste as similar kind of words and grounds have been men-

tioned in various orders which this court has/had occasion to go through. The DM passed similar kind of order in almost similar words which instantly gives us an impression that the orders have been passed with total non-application of judicious mind," the order added. It is evident that while issuing the show-cause notices or at the time of passing of the final orders, the DM has not gone through the definitions of the word "anti-social element", the court observed.

The DM had proceeded on "surmises and conjectures" that the petitioners might disturb law and order during the assembly elections, without material showing

that they had previously disturbed public order, it said.

The court also noted that the men had been ordered to mark their attendance at Silao police station, about 40 km away, thrice a week and had their movements restricted for three months.

It further observed that no verification report or other material had been produced to substantiate allegations recorded in the police diary.

The court said the SP, SDPO and SHO concerned had acted "in haste" without verifying the allegations and directed the state Government to recover the compensation and litigation costs from the erring officials after giving them an opportunity of hearing.

Graham Staines murder case: Rejected convict Dara Singh's remission plea, Odisha tells SC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New delhi

The Odisha Government on Thursday told the Supreme Court that it has rejected the remission plea of Ravindra Pal alias Dara Singh, who is serving a life sentence for the murder of Australian missionary Graham Stuart Staines and his two minor sons in 1999.

"You take whatever grounds you want to take to challenge it. Amend your petition and then argue," a bench of Justices Manoj Misra and Vijay Bishnoi told the counsel appearing for Singh.

The bench noted that a copy of the August 31 order rejecting the remission plea has been supplied to Singh's counsel.

"The counsel representing the petitioner (Singh) prays for and is allowed two weeks to file an appropriate amendment application," the bench said, while posting the matter after three weeks.

At the outset, the counsel



appearing for the Odisha Government told the bench that the state has rejected Singh's remission plea.

The top court had earlier pulled up the Odisha Government for not taking a decision on Singh's remission plea. Singh, 63, has been in jail for more than 25 years.

He approached the top court in 2024 seeking premature release on the ground that he had served over 24 years in jail and "repented" for his action taken in a fit of "youthful rage".

In his plea, Singh said he

believed in 'karmic' philosophy and prayed for an opportunity to reform his character and cure the effects of the bad 'karma' he accumulated through his actions.

A mob led by Singh attacked Staines and his two sons – 11-year-old Philip and eight-year-old Timothy – while they slept in their station wagon and set the vehicle on fire at Manoharpur village in Keonjhar district on the intervening night of January 22-23, 1999.

Singh, the main accused

in the triple murder, was convicted and sentenced to death by a CBI court in 2003.

The Orissa High Court commuted his death sentence to life imprisonment in 2005, which the Supreme Court upheld in 2011.

Staines and his wife, Gladys Staines, worked with the Mayurbhanj Evangelical Missionary that cared for leprosy patients.

Gladys Staines, who was awarded the Padma Shri in 2005, had said she had forgiven the killers of her husband and sons, and held no bitterness against them.

The Odisha Government took the decision to reject Singh's remission plea at a special meeting of the State Sentences Review Board (SSRB) on August 31, officials had said.

The meeting resolved that "in view of certain facts and circumstances, the Board is not inclined to recommend his premature release at this stage".

Change your mindset: SC asks Tamil Nadu to comply with direction to identify land for Navodaya

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New delhi

The Supreme Court on Thursday directed the Tamil Nadu Government to comply with its December 2025 direction to identify land for establishing Navodaya Vidyalayas in each district of the state.

"There has to be cooperative federalism," a bench of Justices B V Nagarathna and Augustine George Masih observed while hearing the Tamil Nadu Government's plea. "Tomorrow, if the central Government comes up with any policy in the Concurrent List and if each of the states start saying that I don't accept your policy, then what will happen to our federal structure," the bench observed.

The top court was hearing the state's plea challenging the Madras High Court's September 2017 directive to facilitate the establishment of Navodaya Vidyalaya in every district there.

The bench also asked the



state Government to change its mindset over the issue.

During the hearing, senior advocate Jaideep Gupta, appearing for Tamil Nadu, told the bench that an application has been filed for recall of the apex court's December 15, 2025 order.

In its December last year order, the top court had directed the state to identify the requisite extent of land that is necessary for establishing Navodaya Vidyalaya in each of its districts. It had said that the exercise be carried out within six weeks.

"We are not recalling that order," the bench observed on Thursday.

The bench noted that between December 15 and today, there has been a change in the Government in the state. "Be that as it may, we direct the petitioner state to comply with our order dated December 15, 2025 in so far as identification of the requisite extent of land that is necessary for establishing Navodaya Vidyalaya in each of the districts of the petitioner state," the bench said.

It said the direction is always subject to the result of the special leave petition filed by the state.

"In the circumstances, we grant the state Government three months time to comply

with the aforesaid direction," the bench said. It asked the representatives of the state and the Centre to have further discussion with regard to the establishment of these schools there.

During the hearing, the bench told the state's counsel, "Your mindset must first change. If you say I don't want Navodaya Schools because I don't want Hindi to be taught on the soil of Tamil Nadu..." Gupta said the state was not at all opposing study of Hindi in Tamil Nadu.

"There are substantive number of schools (in Tamil Nadu) where Hindi is taught," he said. Additional Solicitor General K M Nataraj, appearing for the Centre, said the requirement of the state is only to provide land. "Rest everything will be taken care of by the central Government.

There will be no burden at all on the state Government," he said, adding that the issue regarding language policy can be worked out.

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RBI cancels registration of five NBFCs

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on Thursday said it has cancelled the certificate of registration of five non-banking finance companies (NBFCs), according to a release. Separately, the central bank said eight NBFCs have surrendered their licences due to various reasons, including exit from Non-Banking Financial Institution (NBFI) business.

The RBI has cancelled the licence of Dar's Financial Services, Rolta Holding and Finance Corporation, Vasudeo Securities, Parsoli Corporation, and A C Choksi Financial Services, as per the release. Further, Anupam Mercantile, Grand Motor and Finance, Sky Limit International Finance, and ASA International India Microfinance have surrendered their licence due to exit from NBFI business.Shivam Securities Pvt Ltd, and April Investment and Finance Pvt Ltd have surrendered their licence as they ceased to be a legal entity due to amalgamation/ merger/dissolution/ voluntary strike-off, the RBI said.



Coal ministry launches 16th round of commercial auctions

The coal ministry on Thursday launched the 16th round of commercial coal mine auctions inviting stakeholders to participate in the bidding of the blocks. In the latest round, the ministry has put 25 coal blocks on sale. Of these, 21 are fully explored and 4 partially explored mines spread over Odisha, Maharashtra, Jharkhand, Chhattisgarh, West Bengal, Bihar, Telangana and Arunachal Pradesh.

"We invite investors to participate in this round of auction. The new round has potential to generate huge employment and attract new investments into the sector," Minister of State for Coal and Mines Satish Chandra Dubey said. Commercial coal mining was launched by Prime Minister Narendra Modi in 2020. Over the past six years, across 15 completed rounds, 147 coal mines have been successfully auctioned, bringing 44 new companies into the sector. The auctioned mines are expected to generate annual revenue of approximately ₹47,500 crore, attract capital investment of nearly ₹55,000 crore and create around 4.9 lakh employment opportunities across coal-bearing states.



Lock-in for chip plants announced

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Approved chip plants under the Semicon 2.0 programme will not be allowed to sell or mortgage any part of the project till the declaration of commercial production of the entire project, according to the scheme's guidelines issued on Thursday.

The government had notified Semicon 2.0 with an incentive outlay of ₹1.27 lakh crore. Till declaration of the commercial production of the entire project, the company shall not sell or dispose of the project assets or any part thereof or create thereon any mortgage, lien or charge by way of hypothecation or otherwise, except in the ordinary course of business, without prior approval of the Nodal Agency, the guideline said.

The scheme has six pillars to boost the semiconductor ecosystem in the country comprising — design, machines and materials, setting up more fabs, further strengthening the ATMP and OSAT industry, research and development and talent development.

Out of the six pillars, guidelines have been published for three pillars - machines and materials, setting up more fabs, further strengthening the ATMP and OSAT industry.



Applicants under the machines and materials pillar can also receive production-linked incentives (PLI) benefits under the scheme for domestic sourcing of components and sub-assemblies that are produced in India.

As per the guidelines, units receiving fiscal support under the scheme shall have to remain in commercial production for a period of at least (three) years from the date of commencement of commercial production of the entire project and provide an undertaking to the same. Expenditure incurred on

land and its development, temporary structures, site offices, temporary office space, and other temporary facilities created at the project site will not be considered as eligible capital expenditure or investment under the scheme.

As per the norms, cost incurred for technology transfer, interest during construction (IDC), and research and development will not be considered as part of capital expenditure or investment under Semicon 2.0.

Applicant and promoter or group applying for the incentive under the scheme

should hold at least 51 per cent of the total equity share capital with equivalent voting rights in the project company at all times during the term of the fiscal support agreement (FSA), including its three years of operation after the commercial operation date.

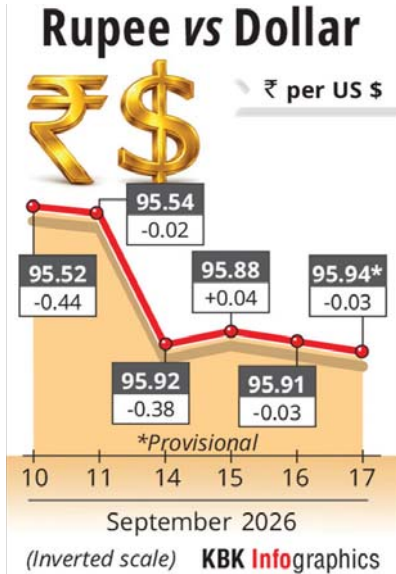
The controlling entity must be identified at the application stage itself, and its continuity is a condition for continued fiscal support and fulfilment of other conditions as per the FSA. Any change in shareholding must be reported to the Nodal Agency during this period, the guidelines said.

Rupee settles 3 paise lower at 95.94 against US dollar

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The rupee, which slipped below the 96 level in intraday trade, ended Thursday's session with a loss of just 3 paise at 95.94 (provisional) against the US dollar, paring initial losses on likely RBI intervention. The rupee ended almost flat amid a slight fall in the dollar index and crude oil prices, which supported investor sentiment despite global geopolitical volatility. According to forex analysts, the local currency, however, stayed under pressure due to outflows of foreign funds and global trade uncertainties after the House of Representatives cleared a law authorising President Donald Trump to impose up to a 100 per cent tariff on India and other countries importing Russian oil.

The domestic unit was also weighed down after the US Federal Reserve hiked interest rates for the first time in three years amid rising inflation, they



said. At the interbank foreign exchange market, the rupee opened at 95.88 and

hit the intraday low of 96.10, breaching the 96 level for the first time since July 24. The unit recovered during the session and touched the high of 95.78 before settling at 95.94 against the US dollar, 3 paise lower than the previous closing level. "The Indian rupee experienced a highly volatile trading session on Thursday, initially buckling under a hawkish Fed onslaught and weaker Asian currency sentiment.

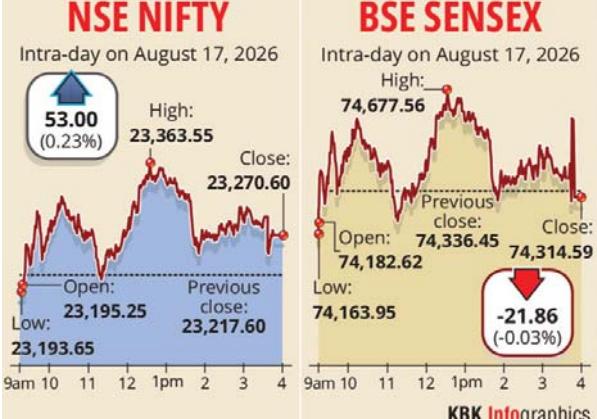
However, those early losses proved fleeting as aggressive central bank intervention swooped in with heavy-handed dollar defence, pulling the local unit off the canvas to secure marginal gains," Dilip Parmar - Senior Research Analyst, HDFC Securities. Parmar further noted that "turning to the technical outlook, the spot USD/INR pair remains in an overall upward trend following its recent surge, though we anticipate a period of short-term consolidation with key support around 95.45 and resistance capped at 96.30."

Stock markets close flat after US Fed rate hike

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Benchmark indices Sensex and Nifty closed nearly flat on Thursday as caution prevailed after the US Federal Reserve increased its interest rates and indicated further tightening in monetary policy.

Giving up intraday gains, the 30-share BSE Sensex dipped 21.86 points, or 0.03 per cent, to settle at 74,314.59. During the day, it climbed 341.11 points, or 0.45 per cent, to 74,677.56. The 50-share NSE Nifty closed higher by 53 points, or 0.23 per cent, at 23,270.60. The index hit a day's high of 23,363.55.



Among the 30 Sensex firms, HDFC Bank, Titan, ICICI Bank, State Bank of India, Bharti Airtel and Axis Bank were the major laggards.

Tata Steel, Bharat Electronics, InterGlobe Aviation, Eternal, Maruti and Asian Paints were among the gainers.

"Indian equities ended mixed on Thursday after a range-bound session. The Nifty edged up to 23,270, while the Sensex slipped marginally to 74,314 and Bank Nifty declined to 56,055. Selective buying supported the Nifty, but weakness in private-sector banks and IT stocks limited the broader recovery," said Hariselman Radhakrishnan, Founder & CEO of HST Wealth, a Research Analyst firm.

Market sentiment remained cautious after the US Federal Reserve raised interest rates by 25 basis points and signalled that another increase could follow this year.

Gold falls ₹600 on weak domestic demand

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Gold prices fell by ₹600 to ₹1.55 lakh per 10 grams in the national capital on Thursday as weak domestic demand weighed on the precious metal.

The yellow metal of 99.9 per cent purity had closed at ₹1,55,600 per 10 grams on Wednesday. Silver, however, held steady at ₹2.42 lakh per kilogram, inclusive of all taxes, according to local traders. Traders said weak demand in the domestic market weighed on gold prices. "Gold edged lower on Thursday, tracking overnight weakness in international



markets after the Federal Reserve delivered a hawkish policy message," Saumil Gandhi, Senior Analyst - Commodities at HDFC Securities, said.

The US Federal Reserve raised its benchmark interest rate by 25 basis points to

3.75-4 per cent, as widely expected, marking its first rate increase in three years. Fed Chair Kevin Warsh's emphasis on persistent inflationary pressures, along with stronger-than-expected August core inflation, reinforced expectations that

monetary policy could remain restrictive. However, bullion found some support in global markets on Thursday as Treasury yields, crude oil prices and the dollar index pulled back slightly. Spot gold rose \$52.85, or 1.24 per cent, to \$4,317.11 per ounce, while silver gained nearly 2 per cent to \$64.06 an ounce.

"Spot gold is staging a recovery and traded over 1 per cent higher around \$4,310 an ounce in global markets as crude oil, treasury yields, and dollar index have pulled back slightly," Praveen Singh, Head of Commodities at Mirae Asset Sharekhan, said.

Trust is invisible foundation of every healthy economy: Ram Nath Kovind

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Ram Nath Kovind, Former President of India on Thursday while addressing the FICCI-CASCADE 'MASCRADE 2026' (Movement Against Smuggled and Counterfeit Trade), said that trust is the invisible foundation of every healthy economy and smuggling, counterfeiting gradually erode that trust. "Consumers trust manufacturers, manufacturers trust the supply chain, investors trust their institutions and their regulators. Smuggling and counterfeiting gradually erode that trust. The entire economic system is based on trust. Therefore, the movement against counterfeiting and smuggling is about protecting the trust in the systems and institutions that allow an economy to function," he added.

Kovind further stated that in today's world, illicit trade has taught us a lesson that a supply chain is only as secure as its weakest point. Highlighting the importance



(L-R) Anant Swarup, Secretary General, FICCI; Vivek Chaturvedi, Chairman, Central Board of Indirect Taxes and Customs; Ram Nath Kovind, Former President of India; Anil Rajput, Chairman, FICCI CASCADE and Kapil Hathi, Member, FICCI CASCADE and CFO, Amazon India at the inaugural session of 12th edition of FICCI CASCADE's flagship event MASCRADE 2026

of the conference's theme - 'One World, One Fight: Eliminating Counterfeiting and Smuggling Through Collective Action', he said that the theme of this conference has a sense of resonance with India's largest vision for the world. "Our Prime Minister Narendra Modi has articulated the principle of one earth, one family, one future as a guiding commitment for India. There is a natural connection between that vision and the idea of one world, one fight. Both remind us of a simple truth, our challenges are interconnected and so are our destinies," he noted.

Kovind added that India today is at an important moment in its economic journey. "We are witnessing transformation across manufacturing, infrastructure, technology, entrepreneurship and global trade. Indian enter-

prises are increasingly becoming part of global value chains, while our digital economy is creating new opportunities for businesses and consumers. With this growth comes a responsibility to protect the ecosystem that makes such growth possible," he emphasised.

"There are three ideas about India that we must defend together," Kovind said. "The first is of Bharat as Vishwaguru; second is India as a global centre of enterprise, manufacturing and innovation, reflected in our aspirations for Make in India and Atmanirbhar Bharat and the third idea is of Indian citizen as a discerning and empowered consumer, who has every right to expect that what is purchased is genuine, safe and what it claims to be. Illicit trade undermines all three," he highlighted.

Speaking on the role of technology in fighting the menace of illicit trade and smuggling, Kovind said that technology offers us powerful new tools. "Data analytics can

help identify unusual patterns, AI can help agencies assess risks more intelligently. Digital systems can improve transparency and make enforcement more effective. But technology by itself is not enough. We need technology, but we also need inter-agency and international cooperation in intelligence sharing," he added.

Vivek Chaturvedi, Chairman, Central Board of Indirect Taxes and Customs (CBIC) said that the illicit economy is no longer simply about bringing prohibited goods across the border. It is increasingly about creating an entire parallel supply chain using legitimate logistics infrastructure, documentation, financial channels, and digital platforms to disguise such illicit activity.

Anil Rajput, Chairman, FICCI CASCADE, said, "The fight against illicit trade is not merely an economic imperative, nor should it be viewed simply through the lens of revenue loss. It is a security imperative. It is a governance

imperative and, ultimately, an imperative for peace and stability of nations across the globe." Anant Swarup, Secretary General, FICCI said that illicit trade networks are increasingly sophisticated, technology-enabled, and borderless. Their impact goes far beyond revenue losses, undermining investments, employment, consumer safety, innovation, and fair competition. "For a fast-growing economy like India, trusted markets and secure supply chains are indispensable. Our response to illicit trade must therefore go beyond seizures alone," he added.

Kapil Hathi, Member, FICCI CASCADE and CFO, Amazon India said that the sophistication of counterfeiters has grown exponentially, and the only way to stay ahead is to invest in advanced technology and tools that can detect what the human eye cannot.

FICCI-KPMG report on 'Illicit Trade in India: Economic Impact, Enforcement Challenges and the Path Forward' was released.

Gold jewellery demand softens

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Gold jewellery demand has softened in recent weeks after a strong run-up ahead of the festive season, with sharp price swings prompting consumers to defer discretionary purchases and wait for greater price stability, the World Gold Council said on Thursday.

However, demand is expected to improve as the festive and wedding season progresses, supported by steady investment demand and resilient wedding-related buying, though elevated prices and volatility may continue to constrain discretionary buying, according to blog post by WGC.

In the blog, WGC Research Head, India, Kavita Chako stated that according to industry feedback, the strength in gold jewellery demand seen in the run-up



to the festive season, has softened over recent weeks.

The sharp gold price rally in August, followed by the subsequent pullback, has left many consumers in a wait-and-watch mode, delaying discretionary purchases, she said. Retailers have also been cautious about inventory building, preferring to replenish based on realised demand, while some manufacturers have reported delays in uptake of orders by retailers. Wedding-related demand has remained relatively resilient, although anecdotal reports point to a structural shift towards lighter-weight jewellery.

FROM THE
WORLD

NEPAL

Flood death toll
surges to 1,410

The death toll from the devastating flash floods in Nepal surged to 1,410 on Thursday, with over 6,100 people still missing, according to the country's disaster management authorities.

Flash floods, triggered by an ice-rock avalanche near the Nepal-Tibet border on August 26, devastated towns and villages in northern and central Nepal.

The Bhotekoshi River, which flows south from the Himalayan border region, carried the floodwaters downstream, sweeping away homes, vehicles, roads and bridges and damaging hydropower projects.

According to the data issued by Nepal's National Disaster Risk Reduction and Management Authority on Thursday evening, 1,410 people have been killed in the floods so far, with 6,145 people still missing.

ROMANIA

Drone alerts
spark fear

The text alerts blare first, then the blasts arrive. For 48-year-old Robert Marian, who lives in Isaccea, a small Romanian border town in eastern Tulcea County along the Danube River with a crossing into Ukraine, the proximity of Russian drone strikes – just hundreds of meters across the river - has become a source of constant fear. “There are alerts warning us that something is coming,” he said. “It happened two weeks ago, maybe three. I was asleep at midnight. One was quieter, but another was really loud. I got scared and ran out of the house.” As Russia's war in Ukraine grinds on, drone incursions into Romania's airspace have increased significantly. The blasts just across the Danube are a reminder of how close war is to NATO territory.

Energy security of India's people comes first: Kwatra

SAGAR KULKARNI
■ Washington

India is guided by the principle of “people first” in matters of energy security, Indian Ambassador Vinay Mohan Kwatra said on Thursday, hours after the US Congress passed a bill to impose steep tariffs on buyers of Russia's energy.

His remarks came after the US Congress passed the Lindsey O Graham Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act that would authorise President Donald Trump to impose sanctions on Russia and steep tariffs on its trading partners in oil and gas, including India and China.

“The energy security of India's people comes first,” Kwatra said in a post on X. “Our choices are guided by availability, affordability, market conditions and commercial viability,” Kwatra said, noting that India



imports over 85 per cent of its crude oil and around half its natural gas.

He said when recent conflicts squeezed global supplies, India acted decisively to protect its people from price shocks. “That also helped steady global energy markets and prevent a deeper crisis,” Kwatra said.

“Our sourcing reflects a fundamental national responsibility: looking

outside our borders to secure adequate, affordable and uninterrupted energy for our people,” the Indian envoy said.

India buys from a diverse range of partners across the Middle East, Africa, Latin America, Eurasia and the United States, he said.

“India is the world's fastest-growing major economy and its third-largest energy consumer. Yet the average Indian consumes less than one-third of the global average and one-tenth of the average American.

Our energy needs will, and must, grow,” he said.

Reliable and affordable supplies power homes, farms, hospitals, schools, factories & transport; protect livelihoods, and sustain growth, the Indian envoy said.

Intercepted Houthi drone debris killed one, says Saudi

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Cairo

The Saudi civil defence said Thursday that debris from an intercepted Houthi drone has killed one person and injured two others.

One Yemeni was killed, and a Saudi citizen and a Pakistani national were injured in Taif province in the western part of the country, officials said. The debris also damaged vehicles and buildings, according to the civil defence. The statement didn't give details on when exactly this happened.

The update comes amid an ongoing escalation between the Iran-backed Houthi rebels and Saudi-backed Government forces in Yemen. Government forces



have launched attacks against Houthi rebels along the Red Sea and Houthis have fired into neighbouring Saudi Arabia, which supports Yemen's Government.

On Wednesday, Saudi Arabia accused the Houthis of trying to attack Mecca, Islam's holiest city, with a drone. The Houthis denied targeting Mecca, and in a social media post in Thursday, Iranian Foreign Ministry spokesperson Esmail Baghaei said that a claim of intercepting a drone shouldn't be turned into an accusation of any specific party or to escalate tensions. He also condemned attacks on Islamic holy sites.

The growing tensions are impacting the Iran war, too, especially since Houthis captured the port city of Mokha and an island on the Bab el-Mandeb Strait, which is a crucial shipping alternative to the Strait of Hormuz.

Prime Minister Carney backs EU ties to protect Canadian sovereignty

ROB GILLIES ■ Strasbourg

Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney on Thursday embraced the prospect of his country becoming the European Union's first associate member, saying closer ties with the continent would ensure no country



could control Canada's markets or undermine its sovereignty.

Carney's speech to the European Parliament repeatedly extolled coop-

eration between Europe and Canada - but the relationship with the US, which has defined Canada's economy for decades and has increasingly soured, hung over the

address. Trump's tariffs, demands for economic concessions and repeated talk of making Canada the 51st state have pushed Ottawa to reduce its dependence on its neighbour and seek a far deeper economic, security and political relationship with Europe.

Carney told the parliament that he welcomed European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen's proposal, unveiled Wednesday, though he acknowledged that “associate membership” remains to be defined.

He outlined what he was proposing: deeper integration across trade, defense, critical minerals, artificial

UN-backed experts cite possible US war crimes in Iran strikes

JAMEY KEATEN ■ Geneva

Human rights experts commissioned by the UN's top human rights body say they have found “reasonable grounds” to believe the United States committed war crimes in two strikes in Iran, including on a school in the southern city of Minab.

They also accuse Iran's theocratic Government of carrying out crimes against humanity against its own people in a report published on Thursday.

The report, while not binding, adds to international evidence gathered about crimes in the war in Iran, and could eventually be used in efforts to reach justice in international courts. The fact-finding mission on Iran, chaired by jurist Sara Hossain of Bangladesh, is made up of independent experts and was created in 2022 by the Human Rights Council, the UN's top human rights body, which is based in Geneva. The experts were expected

to present their findings on Monday to the council, which is made up of 47 UN member countries.

The international fact-finding mission says its findings on US war crimes center on a pair of US airstrikes that killed at least 178 civilians, including women and children. At the start of the US-Israeli war against Iran in February, at least one US missile hit the Shajareh Tayyebah school in Minab, according to an Associated Press investigation. There has been no final accounting of what happened.

Iranian state media have said 168 people were killed in the strike, most of them children. “Following the United States and Israeli attacks on 28 February, the mission found reasonable grounds to believe the United States committed the war crime of launching indiscriminate attacks resulting in the loss of life or injury to civilians or damage to civilian objects,” a UN statement about the team's

findings said. The US State Department did not immediately respond to a request from *The Associated Press* seeking comment.

In their report, the experts concluded that “the building of the school was the intended point of impact” and the resulting damage wasn't the result of an errant strike or collateral damage from an attack on a compound of Iran's Revolutionary Guard next to the school.

The Trump administration has yet to directly accept responsibility or release the findings of a Pentagon investigation into the school bombing.

The UN-backed team based its allegations on two strikes — one involving Tomahawk missiles that hit the “clearly identifiable” school, and another in which Precision Strike Missiles dispersed tungsten pellets over a “clearly identifiable sports complex and residential area” in the southern city of Lamerd, also on February 28.



A man reacts to the camera while driving past a monument depicting the clenched fist of the late Iranian Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali

Fiji declares National HIV emergency

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Tokyo

Fiji has declared an HIV national emergency after data showed one in 60 people in the South Pacific island nation is now estimated to have the blood-borne virus.

The country says it is boosting testing and treatment efforts to fight a surge in new infections, which have increased 12-fold over the last 15 years, according to the joint United Nations Program on HIV and Aids (UNAIDS).

Latest figures showed there was about 9,000 people living with HIV in 2025 in a country which has less than a million people, according to the UN agency. It said only 39 per cent of patients knew their HIV status and just 22 per cent were receiving antiretroviral treatment.



The Pioneer

Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Mannba, Mother of No.16014234X Hav Rajput Narayan Sinh Jagat Sinh, R/o-VIII & PO- Karbatiya, Dist-Mehsana, Gujarat- 384355, have changed my name from Mannba to Rajput Manba Jagatsinh, vide affidavit dated 17/09/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Palanichamy, Father of- No.15192615K NK (DVR SPL) Karthic Kumar P, R/o- 31/2, Pillaimar East West Street, Seithur, Rajapalayam Tk, Viruthunagar Dist, Tamil Nadu- 626121, have changed my name from Palanichamy to Palanisamy, vide affidavit dated 17/09/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Shinde Ramchandra Maruti S/o Maruti Shinde, R/o Qtr. No. 07/13, APS Colony, Delhi Cantt, Delhi- 110010, declare that name of mine has been wrongly written as Shinde RM in my minor Son namely Shinde Ayush Ramchandra aged 14 years in his School Records. The actual name of mine is Shinde Ramchandra Maruti which may be amended accordingly.

I, No.4355017L Nk Man Kumar Barman (Retd), resident of Vill- Joypur Pt III P.O- Joypur Pt III PS- Joypur, Dist- Cachar, State- Assam, PIN- 788107 have changed my spouse's name in my records from Anu Rekha Barman to Anurekha Barman vide affidavit dated 16/09/2026 before 1st Class Magistrate, Silchar, Cachar, Assam.

I, Veneeta Yadav, W/o No. 14845020X Hav Anil Kumar, R/o- Vill- Girdharpur, PO-Bhimganj, Distt- Raebareli, U.P - 229207, have changed my name from Veneeta Yadav to Vineeta Devi, vide affidavit dated 17/09/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given on behalf of PRATIMA JHA who is purchasing PORTION OF PLOT NO. 109, AREA MEASURING 96.33 SQUARE YARDS OUT OF KHASRA NO. 6424, SITUATED IN THE AREA OF VILLAGE HASSTA, DELHI, COLONY KNOWN AS BLOCK K-1 EXTN. MOHAN GARDEN, UTTAM NAGAR, NEW DELHI-110059, from HARISH JOSHI AND KULDEEP, who had Purchased the subject property through Sale Deed dated 21.03.2025 executed by Sonjia Kumari Alias Sonjiana, As Doc no. 2025/2511/8090 Book no.1 Vol no. 14265 Pages- 1-22 SRO- West Janakpuri. Who owned by Notarized General Power of Attorney, ATS, WILL, 25.07.2011 executed by Manohar Lal, now PRATIMA JHA is intend to purchase the subject property and same to be mortgaged with ADITYA BIRLA HOUSING FINANCE LIMITED So, to comply the requirements of BANK/NBFC, we give this public notice that if any Person having any type of claim/right/interests/creating mortgage over the said property, may inform in writing, at the address mentioned below, about his objections, within 15 days from today, failing which it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all type of Encumbrances, lien etc.

Lucem Legal LLP
N-161, Ground Floor, Saira Tower, Gautam Nagar
Near Yusuf Sarai Community Centre, Delhi-110049
Contact # 011-40046316 & 4167327

PUBLIC NOTICE

I, Vikas Puri, in the capacity of a Director in the Company PGF Limited (PGF) hereby bring to the attention of the general public that an individual named Mr. Raju Ahlawat S/O Sh. Jay Pal Singh R/O H. No. 128, Todarmal Colony, Prem Nagar, Najafgarh, Delhi, have terminated/Removed from his appointment/post as Caretaker, with immediate effect, on behalf of PGF Limited to protect/secure the assets/properties of PGF from illegal possession/encroachment or illegal sale/ transfer by various individuals/entities, situated in Delhi (NCT), Gurgaon and Rewari, all mentioned in the list of properties belonging to PGF and its intermediaries, situated in the Delhi had been settled out as Annexure A, annexed with appointment letter dated 25/08/2025). Further he has been terminated/Removed to perform all duties mentioned in the aforesaid appointment letter as he failed to perform all his duties as per the rule/terms of PGF as well has been involved in illegal activities.

The general public is hereby informed that any individuals or entity engaging in any transaction/activities pertaining to the properties/assets belonging to or related to PGF, with aforesaid Raju Ahlawat, shall be deal at their own sole risk and liabilities/consequences.

This public notice has been issued in the interest of justice and for public awareness.

For PGF LIMITED
(Vikas Puri) Director | DIN: 03532507

COURT NOTICE

IN THE COURT OF MS. SAUMYA CHAUHAN, LD. DJ-01, EAST, KKD, COURTS DELHI

PC. NO. 9/2026

P-1 Sanjeev Malhotra
S/o Late Sh. Sanjay Malhotra R/o 35, Bank Enclave, Laxmi Nagar, East Delhi-110092
Mobile no. 9910122988 E-mail: sm36be@yahoo.co.in

Verses

PETITIONER
R-1 The State
Through Chief Secretary Players building, Delhi Secretariat, GNCT of Delhi, Indraprastha Marg, ITO, New Delhi New Delhi-110002
R-2 Vandana Malhotra
W/o Late Sh. Rajiv Malhotra R/o 35, Bank Enclave, 1st Floor, Laxmi Nagar, East Delhi-110092, Mob no. 9899300498
R-3 Jshan Malhotra
S/o Late Sh. Rajiv Malhotra R/o 35, Bank Enclave, 1st Floor, Laxmi Nagar, East Delhi-110092, Mob no. 9899300498
R-4 Shivam Malhotra
S/o Late Sh. Rajiv Malhotra R/o 35, Bank Enclave, 1st Floor, Laxmi Nagar, East Delhi-110092, Mob no. 9899300498

RESPONDENTS

Petition for probate under section 276 of Indian succession act (XXXIV of 1925) for grant of probate with the will deed dated 22/11/2013 annexed with the petition.

whereas in the above noted petition, the petitioner has applied for grant of probate of will registered on 22.11.2013 duly executed by Late Sat Paul Malhotra S/o Late Sh. Kirpa Ram Malhotra, R/o 35, Bank Enclave, IP, Extension, Delhi-110092 in respect of his free hold double storey built-up House Bearing no. 35, Situated At: Bank Enclave, IP, Extension, Delhi-110092 and as per contents of the said will, the petitioner claims right on entire ground floor alongwith entire roof over the first floor, including bathroom on the terrace of the aforesaid property.

Whereas the 06-10-2026 at 10⁰ o'clock in the forenoon has been fixed for hearing of the case, notice is hereby given that person having any interest in the administration of the concerned may if he/she desire appear in this Court of the said 06-10-2026 and see the proceedings.

Judge Given under my hand and the seal of this court on 20-08-2026.

District Judge-01
Kankardooma,
East Delhi-110032

Seal

OFFICE OF MUNICIPAL CORPORATION KORBA

e-Procurement Tender Notice

Main Portal: <http://eproc.cgstate.gov.in> KORBA

SN	System Tender No.	Name of Work/Description of Work	Probable Amount of Contract
1.	199464 (2nd Call)	CONSTRUCTION OF BOX CRICKET AT ZONE-2 IN STADIUM MUNICIPAL CORPORATION, KORBA (C.G.)	Rs. 158.58 Lakh

The details can be viewed directly from the Government of Chhattisgarh <http://cproc.cgstate.gov.in> from 15.09.2026 at 15.30 Hours. (1ST) onwards.

Sd/-
Superintending Engineer
Municipal Corporation
Korba (C.G.)

ARMY PUBLIC SCHOOL, SRINAGAR

BB, CANTT., BATWARA (J&K)- 190004

Website: www.apssrinagar.co.in

INVITING QUOTATIONS

1. On behalf of the Chairman Army Public School, Srinagar invites sealed quotations from reputed and authorised firms for supply of the following Music Department items under Two-Bid System (Technical Bid and Commercial Bid):-

Name of Item	Qty
Yamaha YDP-105 Arius Series Digital Console Piano 88 keys with bench	01
Yamaha DBR12(12") powered speakers 1000	02
Mixer 6XIR Yamaha MG12x0 (knob version) Analog mixing Console (6 XLR+3 stereo effects+ USB Model No MG12xUK	01
Studio Master XR 80HH Microphone	01
Connect speaker to Audio mixer wire (Pair of 20 Metre)	04

2. The Tech Bid should contain the details of Company valid GST Registration Certificate and PAN Card. Technical specifications of the proposed items including make/ model/ warranty.

3. Firms shall submit their bids in separate sealed envelopes, clearly marked "TECH BID" and "COMMERCIAL BID". The school reserves the right to cancel the call for quotation without assigning any reason. The last date for submission of quotations is 26 Sep 2026. For any query contact during all working days between 10 a.m. to 03 p.m at 0194-2468224.

Sd/- Principal

kotak

Kotak Mahindra Bank

NOTICE

Locker Hired by MRS RITA BATRA having address at WZ-77 9B GURU KIRPA MARKET,SCHOOL ROAD UTTAM NAGAR, NEW DELHI, 110059 with KOTAK MAHINDRA BANK Situated at PLOT NO-55, SEC-12 DWARKA-110075 remains un-operated from last 10 years & 9 Months and the rent due for the last 9 years.

All the 3 letters earlier sent to MRS RITA BATRA calling her to clear dues and to operate the locker has returned unserved and She is not contactable.

It is hereby informed that despite this notice, if dues not cleared and locker is not operated by MRS RITA BATRA within 90 days from the date of this notice, break open of the said locker will be done on December 16, 2026 at around 12p.m.

kotak

Kotak Mahindra Bank

NOTICE

Locker Hired by MR. VIKRAM K GHOLYA having address at FL NO-141 IIIRD FLR SEC-18 B, DWK, NEW DELHI, 110075 with KOTAK MAHINDRA BANK Situated at PLOT NO-55, SEC-12 DWARKA-110075 remains un-operated from last 10 years & 9 Months and the rent due for the last 9 years.

All the 3 letters earlier sent to MR. VIKRAM K GHOLYA calling him to clear dues and to operate the locker has returned unserved and he is not contactable.

It is hereby informed that despite this notice, if dues not cleared and locker is not operated by MR. VIKRAM K GHOLYA within 90 days from the date of this notice, break open of the said locker will be done on December 16, 2026 at around 12p.m.

Amid Gulf tensions, Pakistan backs Makkah pact

SAJJAD HUSSAIN ■ Islamabad

Pakistan on Thursday said it was committed to implementing the Makkah defence agreement amid raging tensions in the Gulf region after what Saudi Arabia described as an attempted drone attack by Yemen's Houthis against the Muslim holy city.

The trilateral defence agreement, involving Pakistan, Turkiye and Saudi Arabia, was inked last month. The pact establishes a framework for collective deterrence and stipulates that an armed attack against any one of them would be regarded as an attack against all.

Speaking to *Geo News* on Wednesday, Defence Minister Khawaja Asif said that Pakistan is fully prepared to fulfil its obligations under the Makkah agreement. The



Pakistan Defence Minister Khawaja Asif

"Makkah Agreement applies to us, and we will fulfil our duty," he was quoted as saying by the news channel. Asif's statements came after Saudi authorities claimed that their air defences had intercepted and destroyed a Houthi

drone south of the city. The drone was destroyed before it entered Mecca's prohibited airspace, according to Saudi authorities.

The Houthis, however, denied that their air defences had intercepted and destroyed a Houthi

there is no need for an agreement to protect it," Asif was quoted as saying by the channel.

He said Pakistan did not need an agreement to protect the holy sites, as safeguarding them was a duty even in the absence of the pact. During his weekly briefing on Thursday, Foreign Office spokesperson Sajjad Haider Khan reiterated the intent and spirit to uphold the defence deal.

Responding to a query on whether any mechanism had been devised as to how Pakistan will ensure that recent Houthi attacks in Saudi Arabia were thwarted, Khan said that Pakistan was committed to "implementing" the agreement.

"However, when, how, where and what force will be used against what objectives, in which modes and matters- operational confiden-

tiality requires us to be discreet at this stage," he added.

He said that Pakistan has for a long time shared the perspective of having peace and stability in the region because "this is not only in the interest of Pakistan and Iran, but also the entire region and beyond." He also termed the Bab el-Mandeb situation as "exceptionally serious" and went on to call on the Houthis to stop their activities.

"In this regard, our discussions basically revolve around bringing peace and stability through dialogue and diplomacy and not through coercive measures," he said.

On Wednesday, Asif had said the Makkah pact provided for mutual defence if the territorial integrity or geographical boundaries of any of the three countries were violated. (PTI)

Ramaphosa booked off work due to ill health after BRICS



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Johannesburg

South African President Cyril Ramaphosa has been booked off from public engagements due to "ill health", his office said on Thursday.

"President Ramaphosa, who returned from the BRICS Summit in India on Monday, has been advised by his medical team to rest and recover," the Presidency said.

It said that the 73-year-old leader has currently been booked off from public engagements "due to ill health." His office, however, did not provide further details on the president's condition.

It said the President has asked the respective ministers to represent him at scheduled public engagements.

During the BRICS summit on September 12 and 13 in New Delhi, Ramaphosa participated in discussions on global governance and multilateralism and addressed the India-South Africa Business Leadership Roundtable.

He also held a bilateral meeting with Prime Minister Narendra Modi on the margins of the summit and exchanged views on the multi-faceted strategic partnership between India and South Africa. (PTI)

China opposes US Congress sanctions Bill

KJM VARMA ■ Beijing

China on Thursday rejected the US "long-arm jurisdiction" to impose tariffs on purchases of Russian oil and gas, saying its normal trade and economic cooperation with other countries should not be subject to interference or coercion by third parties.

The US House of Representatives passed the Lindsey O Graham sanctioning Russia and Iran Act 2026 that authorises Trump to impose sanctions on Russia and steep tariffs on its leading trading partners such as India and China.

Asked about the bill, Chinese Foreign Ministry spokesperson Guo Jiakun



Chinese Foreign Ministry spokesperson Guo Jiakun

told a media briefing that China opposes any action that lacks UN Security Council authorisation. "China consistently opposes long-arm jurisdiction that lacks a basis in international law and is not authorised

by the United Nations Security Council," Guo said. He said that China has always carried out normal economic and trade cooperation with countries around the world based on equality and mutual benefit.

"Such cooperation neither targets any third party nor is subject to interference or coercion from any third party", he said.

Beijing has repeatedly opposed unilateral sanctions. It also defied US sanctions against buying oil from Iran. China, along with India, is one of the largest buyers of oil and gas from Russia.

Much of China's imports are transported through pipelines crossing its land border.

According to official data, China's imports of Russian oil and gas amounted to \$64 billion last year, and its imports from January to August this year crossed over \$70 billion. (PTI)

Pakistan, China start boundary joint commission in Islamabad

SAJJAD HUSSAIN ■ Islamabad

Pakistan and China have operationalised a joint mechanism for managing their common border, a move rejected by India, which said that the body has no legal basis to decide on arrangements related to Indian territory under illegal occupation.

The inaugural meeting of the Commission — based on the 2013 Agreement on the Boundary Management System — was held at the Ministry of Foreign Affairs in Islamabad on Wednesday, according to a statement issued by the Foreign Office. India on Wednesday rejected the "so-called"



boundary joint commission set up by Pakistan and China, saying that the body has no legal basis to decide on arrangements related to Indian territory under illegal occupation.

India has been consistently maintaining that Pakistan's handing over of certain territories such as Shaksgam Valley to China in 1963 was illegal and unacceptable.

Russian missile attacks injure 19, including children in Ukraine

SAMYA KULLAB ■ Kyiv

A Russian barrage of missiles and drones targeting Ukraine's capital and the surrounding region injured at least 19 people overnight and into Thursday morning, authorities said.

President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said Ukrainian forces carried out overnight strikes against targets in Russia, including an oil refinery in Yaroslavl and a military airfield in the Rostov region.

The Kyiv City Military Administration said the overnight attacks were recorded at more than 10 locations in the city, while 33 sites were damaged in the wider region. A 10-year-old girl and a 12-year-old boy

were among the injured, the administration said in a statement on Telegram.

Peace efforts to end Russia's 4 1/2-year full-scale invasion have stalled, with the issue of territorial concessions in eastern Ukraine among the central sticking points. Successive rounds of US-brokered talks have failed to produce a breakthrough. Ukraine is also seeking security guarantees from partners for a deal.

US President Donald Trump claimed in a post on social media on Monday that Russia and Ukraine had mutually agreed to cease attacking each other's energy facilities, strikes that have led to significant supply issues in both countries. In an inter-



A man inspecting damage to his apartment after a Russian missile exploded near his home in Kyiv, Ukraine

view with CBS News on Tuesday, Zelenskyy pushed back on Trump's claim, saying that while an energy truce was discussed during a recent meeting in Kyiv with

Trump's representatives, Steve Witkoff and Jared Kushner, he would only enter such an agreement if Russia ceases its attacks on Ukrainian energy sites. A

Nepal Army Chief meets Chinese defence minister

SHIRISH B PRADHAN ■ Kathmandu

Nepal Army chief Ashok Raj Sigdel paid a courtesy call on Chinese Defence Minister Dong Jun in Beijing and discussed matters relating to mutual interest and military relations, the army said here.

Sigdel is on a week-long visit to China. He left for Beijing on September 13 at the invitation of the Chinese Government and is scheduled to return to Nepal on September 19.

During his meeting with Dong on Wednesday, the two sides discussed issues relating to mutual interests and bilateral military relations, the Nepal Army headquarters in Kathmandu said in a statement. Sigdel also inspected the National Defence



Nepal Army chief Ashok Raj Sigdel with Chinese Defence Minister Dong Jun in Beijing

University of China and attended the inaugural session of the 13th Beijing Xiangshan Forum on Wednesday. The Xiangshan Forum, being held from September 15 to 17, is a key platform for international security and defence dialogue and brings together senior defence officials, military leaders and experts.

During his visit, Sigdel is also expected to meet senior Chinese military officials and discuss future military cooperation, including preparations for the next edition of the joint Nepal-China military exercise, Sagarmatha Friendship.

Nepal and China have been conducting the Sagarmatha Friendship exercise since 2017, focusing on counter-terrorism. (PTI)

India firmly committed to Bhutan's progress: EAM

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Thimphu

India stands firmly committed to Bhutan's progress and prosperity, said External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar on Thursday after meeting with Prime Minister Tshering Tobgay in Thimphu.

Jaishankar arrived in Bhutan on Wednesday on a two-day official visit aiming to further strengthen the bilateral ties and cooperation between the two countries.

"Delighted to call on PM @tsheringtobgay of Bhutan, in Thimphu today. Conveyed warm greetings of PM @narendramodi," Jaishankar posted on X after the meeting.

"Deeply value his sentiments for our unique ties of friendship and cooperation. India stands firmly committed



External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar hands over electric vehicles to Bhutan Prime Minister Tshering Tobgay during his visit in Thimphu

to Bhutan's progress and prosperity," he said.

EAM Jaishankar handed over 54 Made in India electric vehicles to Bhutanese PM Tobgay on the occasion.

"India is supporting Bhutan's advances towards e-mobility and sustainability

transport," he posted on X.

The EAM also launched the second phase of the international UPI for Bhutanese citizens to make payments while visiting India.

"Together with the use of UPI in Bhutan, this completes two-way UPI-based digital

payment connectivity between India and Bhutan," he posted on X. Bhutanese PM Tobgay and Jaishankar oversaw the exchange of a Memorandum of Understanding on extending the Nehru Wangchuck Scholarship Scheme for higher education by Bhutanese students at Indian institutions.

Jaishankar received a warm welcome from his Bhutanese counterpart DN Dhungyel on his arrival in the valley town of Paro. The talks between the two ministers focused on advancing multifaceted engagement in development partnership, energy, trade, connectivity, culture and people-to-people ties. EAM also inaugurated 65-bed Gyaltsuen Jetsun Pema Mother and Child Hospital in Mongar.

Heavy rain and floods in northern Vietnam submerge homes, disrupt economy

ANIRUDDHA GHOSAL ■ Hanoi

Heavy rain caused flooding across parts of northern Vietnam on Thursday, disrupting travel, inundating homes and pushing several rivers above dangerous levels, authorities and state media said.

Rain has fallen across northern and north-central Vietnam this week, with some areas receiving more than 50 centimeters (19.7 inches), according to the disaster prevention department said.

More than 2,000 homes have been submerged, many key transportation routes blocked and more than 1,000

households isolated. Ninh Binh and Thanh Hoa provinces, which include lowland and hilly areas south of the capital Hanoi, have been among the hardest hit.

Vietnam is among the world's most climate-vulnerable countries and prone to flooding.

A series of severe storms last year spurred the country to find new ways to prepare for and manage floods.

In Thanh Hoa province, authorities told students to stay home because flooding had made travel to school dangerous, state media said.

Heavy rains and flooding have submerged or

damaged about 10,014 hectares (24,745 acres) of rice and other crops, with the largest losses reported in Ninh Binh, Thanh Hoa and Nghe An provinces. Thousands of livestock and poultry also have been killed.

"The flood happens every year," Ninh Binh resident Tran Ngoc Tai told national broadcaster VTV, adding that people were prepared with fresh water and food.

Many streets in Hanoi were deeply flooded Thursday morning, with water nearly a meter (3.2 feet) deep in some places, disrupting traffic and making it difficult for resi-



Vietnamese army troops preparing boats for rescue works in flooding areas in Thanh Hoa province, Vietnam

dents to get to work, take children to school or leave their homes.

Rainfall from Wednesday night to Thursday morning exceeded 15 centimeters (5.9 inches) in some areas, state media said.

Many high schools and universities in Hanoi remained closed or switched to online classes Thursday afternoon as heavy rain caused widespread flooding.

The rising waters of Bui River in the southwest outskirts of Hanoi threatened to flood homes, prompting authorities to deploy hundreds of soldiers to help residents move belongings to higher ground, state

media said.

A cold air mass moving south is expected to bring five days of heavy rain to southern Vietnam including flood-prone Ho Chi Minh City, Vietnam's financial Capital, starting September 17, according to the Southern Regional Hydro-Meteorological Center.

Forecasters predict widespread rain through September 21. Authorities have warned of flooding in low-lying areas and along waterways. Ho Chi Minh City is forecast to receive 10 to 20 centimeters (4 to 8 inches) of rain, with some areas getting more. (AP)

Beyond Babur: How India and Uzbekistan are reconnecting through culture

GAYANE UMEROVA

When Babur left the Fergana Valley for India in the early sixteenth century, he could hardly have imagined the empire he founded would leave so deep a mark on India's history, culture and architecture. Five centuries later, his birthplace in present-day Uzbekistan remains a reminder that ties between our two countries run deeper than diplomacy or trade, rooted instead in a shared cultural story.

That story is entering a new chapter. Last weekend, the state visit of Prime Minister Narendra Modi to Tashkent saw India and Uzbekistan elevate ties from a Strategic Partnership to a Comprehensive Strategic Partnership.

A broad set of agreements included a three-year programme of reciprocal cultural weeks, joint film festivals, new tourist routes and a 30-day visa-free regime for travellers from each country.

Prime Minister Modi also

pledged support for restoring Uzbekistan's Buddhist heritage sites, announced Hindi-language scholarships, and proposed translating the Tamil classic Tirukkural into Uzbek.

As Uzbekistan marks the 35th anniversary of its independence, this again shows the significant role played by culture in my country's transformation. Uzbekistan is investing heavily in heritage, museums and creative industries, recognising that culture generates opportunity, strengthens communities and connects nations.

For India, this should feel familiar. Both countries are home to ancient civilisations, and both know heritage is most valuable when part of contemporary life. India's success in protecting its cultural assets has made it one of the world's most compelling destinations, and Uzbekistan is similarly pairing infrastructure investment with a renewed commitment to contemporary creativity.

The connections between

our histories extend well beyond the Mughal period. Long before Babur, Buddhism travelled from India to ancient Termez in southern Uzbekistan, where monasteries such as Fayaz Tepe and Kara Tepe testify to centuries of exchange across Central and South Asia.

Indian cinema built another bridge with affection for Raj Kapoor running so deep that a statue of the actor was unveiled in Tashkent in December 2024. Prime Minister Modi observed last year that India and Uzbekistan are "bound by a dynamic partnership that continues to expand across culture, economy and people-to-people ties."

Culture is not the only element in the relationship, but it is often the one that creates the deepest connections. In February 2025, I attended the India Art Fair in New Delhi, focused on links between Central and South Asia. That spirit was again evident at last year's Bukhara Biennial, established by the



Prime Minister Narendra Modi with Uzbekistan President Shavkat Mirziyoyev during talks

Uzbekistan Art and Culture Development Foundation (ACDF), drawing artists, craftspeople and musicians worldwide, and 1.8 million visitors.

Indian artists, including Subodh Gupta, worked alongside Uzbek collaborators on new commissions. Gupta's pavilion, Salt Carried by the Wind, echoed a mosque that

once stood on the site of a spice market where Indian merchants traded, pairing his own cooking with tableware made by Uzbek ceramicist Baxtiyor Nazirov. As Gupta observed ahead of the Biennial, "There are many similarities in our cultures, from the artisans and their ceramics to the food and architectural traditions that

travelled across borders."

Museums and archives in both countries have long collaborated, from India's National Museum work on artefacts linked to Babur and the Mughal era to the India-Uzbekistan: Dialogue of Cultures exhibition in New Delhi, showcasing manuscripts, paintings and objects spanning centuries of

exchange.

Uzbekistan is also investing in future infrastructure. The Bukhara region has attracted more than \$8 billion over eight years in a wider heritage, industry and tourism drive, while a former Tashkent power station has become the Centre for Contemporary Arts, and a new National Museum of Uzbekistan, designed by Tadao Ando, is rising in the capital. Since 2021, ACDF has commissioned Uzbekistan's national pavilions at the Venice Art and Architecture Biennales. Its projects have reached more than five million visitors across 17 countries through collaborations with over 40 institutions, including the Louvre, the Uffizi Galleries and the British Museum.

15 This visibility is fuelling one of the world's most remarkable tourism booms with a record 11.7 million international visitors in 2025, and arrivals up 37 per cent in the first quarter of 2026 compared with the same period

last year, placing Uzbekistan among the world's fastest-growing destinations. India plays a growing role in that success. More than 80,000 Indian visitors travelled to Uzbekistan in 2025, aided by expanding air connectivity and growing cultural awareness. What they find is world-famous monuments coexisting with a vibrant contemporary scene, new museums, exhibitions and festivals alongside the legacies of the Silk Roads.

India has been woven into Uzbekistan's cultural story for centuries, including through a children's book about Babur produced by the ACDF. As the Prime Minister signalled on his visit to Tashkent, the opportunity now is not merely to celebrate that shared inheritance, but to build upon it together.

The writer is head of the Department of Creative Economy and Tourism of the Administration of the President of the Republic of Uzbekistan and Chairperson of the Uzbekistan Art and Culture Development Foundation.

More than 58,000 Divyangjan, senior citizens receive assistive devices at nationwide camps

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

More than 58,000 Divyangjan and senior citizens across India received assistive devices worth approximately ₹68 crore free of cost as part of nationwide Samajik Adhikarita Camps organised on Thursday at 76 locations across 21 states.

The initiative was organised by the Department of Empowerment of Persons with Disabilities (DEPwD), Ministry of Social Justice & Empowerment, Government of India, through the Artificial Limbs Manufacturing Corporation of India (ALIMCO). The camps were aimed at enhancing mobility, independence, dignity and self-reliance among beneficiaries by providing assistive devices based on their assessed individual requirements.

The main programme was held at Lav-Kush Ramlila Maidan near the Red Fort in New Delhi, with Union Minister for Social Justice & Empowerment Dr. Virendra Kumar as the Chief Guest. The programme was virtually connected with camp locations across the country, bringing beneficiaries, public representatives, District Administration officials and ALIMCO officials together on a common nationwide platform.

Also present at the New Delhi programme were Praveen Khandelwal, Member of Parliament from Chandni Chowk; Kishor Makwana, Chairman, National Commission for Scheduled Castes; Manmeet Nanda, Additional Secretary, Ministry of Social Justice &



Empowerment; and Praveen Kumar, Chairman and Managing Director, ALIMCO, along with other senior officials and dignitaries.

Assistive devices as enablers of independent living

Addressing the gathering, Dr. Virendra Kumar reiterated the vision of Prime Minister Narendra Modi of "Sabka Saath, Sabka Vikas, Sabka Vishwas and Sabka Prayas", and emphasised that Divyangjan and senior citizens must remain active participants in India's development journey.

The Minister said assistive devices are not merely instruments of support but important enablers of mobility, confidence, self-respect and independent living. He stressed the Government's commitment to ensuring that welfare schemes and assistive technologies reach eligible beneficiaries at the last mile.

Kumar also highlighted the expansion of Pradhan Mantri Divyasha-Vayoshri Kendras (PMD-VKs), with 109 centres currently operational across the country. These centres

bring services under the ADIP Scheme and Rashtriya Vayoshri Yojana (RVY) closer to beneficiaries.

He also referred to the establishment of 28 Single Window Cross-Disability Early Intervention Centres (CDEICs), rehabilitation services provided through National Institutes and Composite Regional Centres (CRCs), and initiatives aimed at promoting Divyang sportspersons, including the Divyangta Sports Centre at Gwalior.

Call for wider participation in empowerment initiatives

Virendra Kumar emphasised that empowerment of Divyangjan and senior citizens is a shared social responsibility and called for greater participation from State Governments, District Administrations, civil society organisations, NGOs, social and religious institutions and the corporate sector.

He acknowledged the contribution of organisations including Tara Sansthan, Narayan Seva Sansthan and the Luv-Kush Ramlila

Committee.

The Minister also called upon cultural and social organisations to create more platforms for Divyangjan to showcase their artistic and creative abilities. Referring to Divya Kala Melas, he highlighted their role in promoting entrepreneurship, livelihoods and economic independence among Divyang artisans and entrepreneurs.

He further stressed the need for continued efforts to make Government offices, hospitals, educational institutions, public spaces and transport systems barrier-free, describing accessibility as a shared responsibility.

ALIMCO stresses quality and technology

Speaking on the occasion, ALIMCO Chairman and Managing Director Praveen Kumar highlighted the Corporation's focus on the quality, utility and design of assistive devices.

He said efforts were being made to ensure that beneficiaries receive appropriate solutions suited to their individual requirements. He also highlighted ALIMCO's increasing adoption of digital technology to make service delivery simpler, more efficient, transparent and beneficiary-centric.

"ALIMCO remains committed to the empowerment and welfare of Divyangjan and Senior Citizens. Our endeavour is to ensure that quality assistive devices reach beneficiaries in a timely manner and contribute meaningfully towards strengthening independence, self-reliance and dignity in their lives," he said.

Sewa Diwas exhibition celebrates 25 years of PM's public service at PMML



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

An exhibition titled "Sewa Diwas: 25 Years of Public Service", commemorating the birth anniversary of Prime Minister Narendra Modi and marking 25 years of his public service, was inaugurated at Pradhanmantri Sangrahalaya (PMML) today.

The exhibition was inaugurated by Nripendra

Misra, Chairman, Executive Council, Pradhanmantri Sangrahalaya.

The exhibition brings together a curated selection of paintings inspired by themes and ideas from Mann Ki Baat, along with 3D art installations featuring portraits of Prime Minister Narendra Modi. It also includes the philatelic display "The Man & His Mission" and selected

Tools and Equipment Expo 2026 kicks off

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The three-day 'Tools and Equipment Expo 2026' kicked off on Thursday at Bharat Mandapam in the national capital.

The expo will showcase cutting-edge solutions across hand tools, power tools, smart automation, and cutting and welding technologies.

Speaking at the event, deputy director, NPC-DPIIT, Ministry of Commerce and Industry, Yadu Kumar Yadav said, "Over the past decade, efforts have focused on integrating MSMEs' prod-



ucts, processes and systems through lean manufacturing, and the focus is now shifting towards the next level of digital integration.

Under the Ministry of MSME's RAMP scheme, more than 750 units are currently being integrated into an Industry 4.0 ecosystem in Gujarat, with similar ecosystems envisaged across the

country." Managing director, Informa Markets, the organiser of the expo Yogesh Mudras said, "With India's hand and power tools exports currently at around US\$1 billion, and the potential to scale this to more than US\$25 billion by 2035, the opportunity to strengthen India's manufacturing and export capabilities is significant."

Over 300 exhibitors, over 2,000 products on display over 150 new product launches and over 8,000 industry professionals with participation from leading domestic and international brands.

Safety of doctors who protect others is crucial: Kiran Bedi



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In recent years, doctors have increasingly faced situations involving violence, threats, and harassment. This initiative was launched by Dr Kiran Bedi (IPS), former Lieutenant Governor of Puducherry, who attended a special event at the India International Centre as the chief guest.

Dr Kiran Bedi stated, "The legal and social protection of doctors—who safeguard the lives of others—is crucial; 'Ozone Pharmaceuticals' stepping forward for this cause is a commendable initiative."

In light of the rising violence, threats, harassment, and baseless legal cases against doctors, Ozone Pharmaceuticals has launched 'Ozone Shield'. Speaking on the need for Subash Sehgal, Founder and Managing Director, said, "It is our responsibility to stand by doctors when they face violence or unwarranted legal complications."

Recent data also highlights concerns regarding the safety of doctors. A nationwide survey conducted this year by experts from AIIMS, Safdarjung Hospital, and VMCM among more than 1,500 healthcare workers revealed that 78.4 per cent had received threats while on duty.

77th Raising Day of IDSE Cadre celebrated at Air Force station Palam

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The 77th Raising Day of the Indian Defence Service of Engineers (IDSE) cadre under the Military Engineer Services (MES), Ministry of Defence, was celebrated on 17th September 2026 at the Jumbo Mazumdar Centre, Air Force Station Palam, New Delhi.

The officers marked the occasion by organising a one-day conference with the central theme: "Ethics, Accountability and Excellence towards achieving the aim of Viksit Bharat @ 2047." The conference was attended by



dignitaries from various departments and ministries, including the Ministry of Railways, Central Vigilance Commission, Defence Accounts Department, National Highway Authority, and Public Sector Undertakings.

Defence Minister Rajnath

Singh and Defence Secretary Rajesh Kumar Singh conveyed their greetings and messages to IDSE officers on the 77th Raising Day. In their messages, they laid emphasis on ethics, transparency and accountability.

AK Jain, IDSE, DG (Pers), delivered the welcome address. He emphasised that as professionals entrusted with public works and Government construction, IDSE officers carry a responsibility that goes beyond engineering excellence. "Ethics, Integrity, Accountability and Transparency must remain the cornerstone of every decision and every project undertaken. A culture of transparency and accountability not only strengthens public confidence but also reinforces the credibility and reputation of the engineering profession and the government," he said.

In Next-Gen push, Chhattisgarh widens road to jobs, skills

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

With its youth-centric development agenda, the Chhattisgarh Government is making a concerted push on skills, employment, higher education, entrepreneurship and sports.

Around 9,000 vacant Government posts are being taken up for direct recruitment. A new Chhattisgarh Staff Selection Board has been constituted to make Class III and IV recruitment integrated, transparent and time-bound, according to an

official statement.

To restore confidence in recruitment system, tough provisions to curb paper leaks, impersonation and electronic cheating have been introduced with 3-10 years' imprisonment, fines of ₹10 lakh to ₹1 crore and property confiscation for offenders.

The push extends to competitive examination preparation, with the government's CG-ACE initiative providing free coaching for NEET, CLAT, JEE, UPSC, CGPSC, banking, SSC and railway examinations through a Rs 33-crore allocation.



"Our youth are Chhattisgarh's biggest strength and hope for the future. We want to ensure that every one gets access to

quality education, skills, opportunities and a transparent system. Youth empowerment is central to our vision of a developed Chhattisgarh, in line with Prime Minister Narendra Modi's vision of a developed India," said Chief Minister Vishnu Deo Sai.

Budgetary allocation for higher education has risen by nearly 50 percent, from ₹1,212.75 crore in 2023-24 to ₹1,822.75 crore in 2025-26.

Five Government colleges are being developed as Centres of Excellence at Jashpur, Raipur, Durg, Baloda Bazar and Raigarh.

Chhattisgarh Institutes of Technology (CGIT) have been developed in Kawardha, Jashpur, Raigarh and Jagdalpur on the lines of premier institutions such as IITs. Further expansion is planned at Raipur, Bilaspur and Durg under the new fiscal budget.

Equal importance has also been given to the technical education ecosystem. An amount of ₹484.22 crore has been sanctioned to transform 160 ITIs in the state into state-of-the-art Model ITIs, while 17 ITIs are being modernised under the STRIVE project.

**G.B. Pant University of Agriculture & Technology**
Pantnagar-263145, Udham Singh Nagar, Uttarakhand

EMPLOYMENT NOTICE NO. A-32/2026 (for Backlog Posts)

Govind Ballabh Pant University of Agriculture & Technology, Pantnagar invites applications from eligible candidates for selection to the backlog vacant posts of Associate Professor (Academic Level-13A) and Assistant Professor (Academic Level-10) for reserved categories in different disciplines of various colleges. Details of the Posts, Pay Scales, General Instructions and Application Forms are available on the website <https://www.gbpuat.ac.in>. Last date for the receipt of application form is **21.10.2026 upto 05:00 PM at Chief Personnel Officer's Office, Personnel Management Section-A (Recruitment Section), Govind Ballabh Pant University of Agriculture & Technology, Pantnagar, District - Udham Singh Nagar, Uttarakhand, PIN - 263145.**

CHIEF PERSONNEL OFFICER

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Institution of Engineers (India) (IEI) will host the "Engineering India's Global Footprint: Technology, Talent and Trust" summit on September 19 at the SCOPE Convention Centre, Lodhi Road, New Delhi, bringing together industry leaders, policymakers, academicians and engineering professionals to discuss India's growing role in the global engineering and technology landscape.

The full-day summit will also feature the presentation of the 18th IEI Industry Excellence Award and the 5th IEI Engineering Education Excellence Award. A Union Minister is expected to address the inaugural session, which will also feature senior representatives from industry, academia and government.

The summit will include three technical panel discussions focusing on India's transition from Atmanirbhar Bharat towards a globally competitive engineering economy,

strengthening engineering education and research capacity for Viksit Bharat, and fostering collaboration among industry, academia and startups to develop internationally competitive products.

A business connect session, networking dinner and the evening awards ceremony will form part of the programme. Instituted in 2008, the IEI Industry Excellence Award recognises engineering organisations for sustained performance in areas including operations,



innovation, quality and governance. The 2026 awards cover categories such as engineering manufacturing and processing, engineering services and consultancy,

construction, MSMEs, startups, industrial innovation, emerging technology leadership, sustainable engineering practices, and defence and aerospace.

BRIEFLY

US Open runner-up Shelton withdraws from Laver Cup



US Open runner-up Ben Shelton withdrew from the Laver Cup and will be replaced by 16th-ranked Brandon Nakashima on Team World, organizers announced Thursday.

No reason was given for Shelton's withdrawal but he's slated to play Davis Cup for the United States in the Czech Republic starting on Friday - less than a week after losing to Alexander Zverev in the U.S. Open final. Shelton is up to a career-high No. 4 in the rankings after reaching his first Grand Slam final.

It will mark Nakashima's Laver Cup debut. He joins Alex de Minaur, Taylor Fritz, Alexander Bublik, Learner Tien and Francisco Cerundolo on Team World, which has Andre Agassi as its captain. Yannick Noah's Team Europe features Zverev, Carlos Alcaraz, Flavio Cobolli, Rafael Jodar, Jakub Mensik and Casper Ruud.

(AP)

Gonsalves-Beg pair bows out of Asian Games Teqball event



India's Declan Marshall Gonsalves and Mohamed Anas Imran Beg bowed out of the medal race in the men's doubles Teqball competition at the Asian Games after losing both their group matches here on Thursday. Placed in Group B, the 31-year-old Gonsalves and Beg, 26, both hailing from Mumbai, lost their matches 0-2. The Indians first lost 10-12 8-12 against Vietnam's Truong Giang Ba and Anh Khoa Le before going down 4-12 7-12 against South Korea's Junsuk Lee and Taebeen Lee.

Gonsalves, who started the game five years ago, is the defending national champion in the men's doubles category for five consecutive years and also won national championship in the men's singles in 2025. At international level, he has won a bronze medal in the men's doubles category at the World Teqball Championships held in Vietnam in 2024.

(PTI)

India begin Asian Games title defence against Japan

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Nagoya

Fresh from their record-extending Asia Cup triumph, defending champions India will begin their Asian Games title defence as overwhelming favourites against hosts Japan in the women's quarterfinals here on Friday.

India head into the continental showpiece with confidence after lifting their eighth T20 Asia Cup in Dubai last week, but the knock-out format leaves them with little margin for error.

Eight teams are competing in the women's event and the competition starts directly with the quarterfinals, meaning there are no group stage matches to provide teams with time to settle into the tournament. One defeat is enough to end a campaign.

Shafali Verma will be one of India's key weapons after an outstanding Asia Cup, where she emerged as the team's leading



batter and finished as the tournament's highest run-scorer. Her consistency at the top gave India a strong start in the UAE. Smriti Mandhana, however, endured an inconsistent campaign and will be eager to rediscover her touch as India embark on another title bid. Much of India's bowling will revolve around experienced all-

rounder Deepti Sharma and left-arm spinner Sree Charani, who has rapidly established herself as an important member of the attack.

Charani was among India's stand-out performers in the Asia Cup and reached the landmark of 50 T20I wickets in only her 30th appearance. The 22-year-old's ability to control the middle overs could prove important.

Captain Harmanpreet Kaur will also be looking for a better outing

after an indifferent Asia Cup, with her experience in pressure situations likely to assume greater significance in a tournament where every game is a must-win.

India have plenty of bowling resources at their disposal with Nandini Sharma, Renuka Thakur and Kranti Gaud offering pace options. Deepti, Charani, Radha Yadav and Shreyanka Patil, who has recovered from her ankle injury, give the side multiple spin choices. The batting, too, has depth beyond the opening pair. The wicketkeeper-batter Richa Ghosh is capable of providing impetus in middle and lower-order. India will hope that Shafali and Mandhana can set the platform, allowing their middle order to play with greater freedom.

Japan, playing on home soil, will be looking to make the most of the occasion against a superior opponent. The hosts face a formidable bowling attack and will need to negotiate India's spin options effectively while restricting their aggressive top-order batters.



Cramped lodging, allocation mess at Costa Serena hits Asiad



PHILEM DIPAK SINGH ■ Nagoya

Rooms meant for two are being shared by three, complained some Indian athletes lodged at the much-criticised Costa Serena cruise ship for the Asian Games as even the host nation's competitors looked for alternate accommodation amid the organisational chaos that has rocked the build-up to the mega-event here.

Barely two days before the opening ceremony, local media reports suggested that some Japanese athletes are looking for alternative arrangements after cases of male and female players being allocated shared rooms emerged. "There have been cases where coaches, team officials, and athletes have been assigned to the same room. There are also situations where

room assignments were made purely based on the numbers, such as assigning five twin rooms for a group of five men and five women," Japan's deputy chef de mission Hisashi Mizutori said at a media interaction here.

"While the numbers match on paper, practically it creates challenging situations such as men and women being assigned together, coaches being assigned with athletes, or trainers who need to accommodate a lot of medical equipment being assigned together," he was quoted as saying by 'Japan Times'.

Indian athletes from rowing, wushu and table tennis have already checked in at the Italian cruise ship which is currently at the centre of media attention. The ship is almost 300m long and has 1,500 cabins.

(PTI)

Khalin leads by one-shot at Nava Raipur Open

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Raipur

Khalin Joshi fired a one-under 33 to retain a one-shot lead over the field after the third round of the inaugural Nava Raipur Open 2026 here on Thursday.

The 34-year-old Bengaluru golfer (29-30-33), who began the day with a two-stroke advantage, mixed two birdies with his first bogey of the week to reach 10-under 92 heading into the final round.

Joshi, a two-time winner on the DP World PGTI this season and currently 12th in the Race to DP World India Championship, has dropped only one shot through the opening 27 holes.

Heavy rain left the course unsuitable for full 18-hole rounds, prompting the Tournament Committee to stage each of the tournament's four rounds over the back nine.

Chandigarh's Angad Cheema



(34-29-30) emerged as Joshi's closest challenger after producing a bogey-free four-under 30. The 36-year-old climbed from tied 13th to second at nine-under 93.

Seven players shared third place at eight-under 94, leaving eight golfers within two shots of the lead ahead of the final nine holes. Delhi's 18-year-old Pritish Singh Karayat (34-31-29) made the biggest move of

the day, firing a bogey-free five-under 29 to surge from tied 36th into the seven-way tie for third.

Karayat was joined by Ahmedabad's Anshul Patel (32-31-31), Bangladesh's Badal Hossain (33-30-31), Faridabad's Karan Pratap Singh (32-30-32), Gurugram's Veer Ahlawat (32-30-32), Chandigarh's Umed Kumar (33-29-32) and Panchkula's Raunil (31-30-33).

Surfing: India's French coach Samai Reboul sets sights on LA Olympics

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

Frenchman Samai Reboul believes that India's historic Asian Games debut in surfing should be viewed as a stepping stone towards the "ultimate goal" of qualifying for the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics.

Reboul, a former surfer and trained coach who has been working with the Indian national team since 2024, is currently preparing the four-member squad in Mahabalipuram ahead of the Aichi-Nagoya Asian Games, where surfing will make its continental debut.

India will field two men and two women in the shortboard competition. Kishore Kumar and Sivaraj Babu are compet-



ing in the men's event while Kamali Moorthy and Sugar Shanti Banarse will take part in the women's section.

The Asian Games will also offer quota places for the 2028 Olympics, giving Indian surfing a potential pathway to the sport's biggest stage.

"The Olympics is definitely

part of the long-term vision, but to get there an important objective is to create sustainable pathways for Indian surfers to develop from a young age and eventually compete at the highest international level. The 2026 Asian Games are an important step," Reboul told SAI Media.

Switzerland picks Sion forward Boteli in Nations League squad

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Bern (Switzerland)

World Cup quarterfinalist Switzerland rewarded 20-year-old Sion forward Winsley Boteli with a first international call-up Thursday after a fast start to the season that reportedly made him a transfer target for Champions League teams Galatasaray and Porto.

Boteli scored a hat trick last month against Ajax in the Conference League qualifying playoffs in his tally of 12 goals from 14 games so far.

Switzerland coach Murat Yakin also picked 20-year-old Parma defender Sascha Britschgi for first time in a 25-man squad for Nations League games against Scotland, Slovenia and North Macedonia.

Captain Granit Xhaka returns after an impressive World Cup to extend his national record of 152 appearances. The Sunderland midfielder turns 34 the day after Switzerland opens its Nations League second-tier group at North Macedonia on Sept. 26.

Breel Embolo, who was incor-



rectly sent off in the World Cup quarterfinal loss to Argentina, was selected after his move to Atlanta United in Major League Soccer. A third uncapped player, 21-year-old center back Zachary Athekame, is back in the squad while playing on loan from AC Milan at Lyon. Athekame and Boteli join WC breakout star Johan Manzambi, Denis Zakaria and Zeki Amdouni as squad members who were once in the youth system at Servette yet combined to play just six games for the Geneva club. Zakaria, now Monaco captain, played all six of those games in the Swiss second tier in 2014-15.

DAILY SUDOKU

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★☆☆☆

HOW TO SOLVE IT

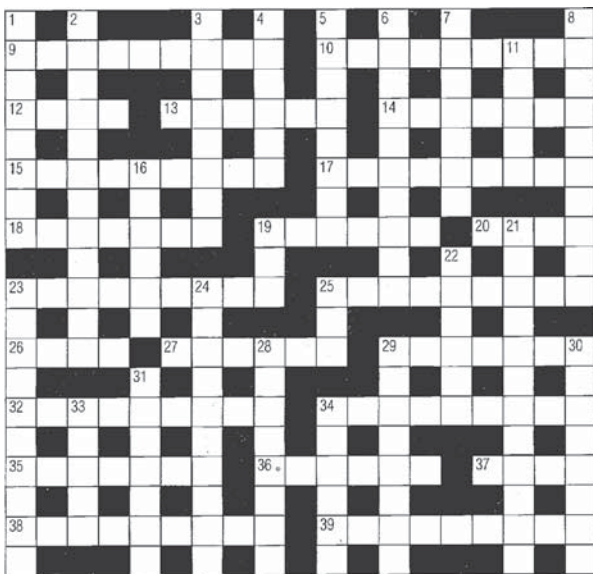
Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction- no maths involved.



SOLUTION (17.9.26)

9	4	1	3	7	6	5	8	2
5	6	3	2	4	8	7	1	9
2	8	7	5	1	9	3	4	6
1	2	8	7	5	3	6	9	4
4	7	6	9	8	1	2	3	5
3	5	9	4	6	2	8	7	1
8	3	4	1	2	5	9	6	7
7	9	2	6	3	4	1	5	8
6	1	5	8	9	7	4	2	3

DOUBLE CROSSWORD
FRIDAY | SEPTEMBER 18, 2026



ACROSS

- 9 Regarding the condition of, exaggerate (9)
10 Plus I'm travelling in one without having planned to (2,7)
12 Just for show (4)
13 Renounce, when you surrender (4,2)
14 Having us dress when the siren goes off. It's early (7)
15 Not wanting to let a cult move in to occupy it (9)
17 He's responsible for the dispossession (9)
18 The attack and capture of (7)
19 The woman who got the hat squashed by a case (6)
20 See the star turn (4)

DOWN

- 1 Says it's true about the business studies (7)
2 The murderer in the soap? (6,6)
3 With the rain pouring, forced to go outside and get soaked (8)
4 Not bad with clothes on (6)
5 The full fifty enter to take part in (8)
6 Rush to get a drink - and a humdinger it is! (10)
7 Taking pains to cook the child healthy food (7)
8 Like the household name who made whoopee? (10)
11 Many songs. "Home on the Range" is one of them (5)
16 They are why there's a U in "luggage" (7)
19 The sun now is low (3)

- 23 Calm once they had got themselves together (9)
25 Mad that one had authenticated it? (9)
26 Nick, for instance, is a man's name (4)
27 Happy to shade again. It was too bright (9)
29 Have the lady report on the whole thing (3)
32 Yellow roses are not (9)
34 Totally democratic, as schools never are (9)
35 The insects are let loose among other insects (7)
36 There are rules for determining just what it is (6)
37 A girl few have time for (4)
38 The greatest circulators of banknotes will do so (9)
39 Maybe getting a char, lashing out when in the money! (7)

- 21 To a soldier, denotes unearned income (7)
22 Many are different when the tail's docked (6)
23 Happens when the ship changes course (7)
24 What Marks and Spencer did when they got together? (6,4)
25 Fish do get caught by rising (3)
28 Set about, therefore, getting an instrument (8)
29 Splashes the fighters with? (8)
30 Try to eradicate the smears from the material (8)
31 Say in your case you have nothing to hide (7)
33 The clumsy article about prison is returned (5)
34 Stick a coin in to get something to eat (7)

SOLUTION (17.9.26)

- ACROSS
4, Pa's-try
7, A-II-can't-e
8, Things
10, Slash
13, He-ad.
14, Temp
15, Bart
16, Bit
17, Over
19, Twin
21, Round-head
23, Dill
24, Dart(-s)
26, Web
27, Coat
29, Char
32, G-Amy
33, Sh-one
34, Beg-one
35, Gathered
36, Strata
DOWN
1, Wa-ist
2, Hira-M
3, Bath
4, Peter
5, Skid
6, Re-gain
9, Hatter
11, Leg
12, Spool
32, Go-Y-a
33, Soho
15, Ben
16, Bid
18, V-ulc-an
20, Watch
21, Rib
22, Hat
23, Def-eat
25, Ban
28, Omega
30, Hour-I
31, Ready
32, Go-Y-a
33, Soho

India crush Afghanistan by 127 runs in 3rd T20I to take series 3-0

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Abhishek Sharma brought a dead rubber to life with a breathtaking 30-ball century as India completed a series sweep over Afghanistan with a dominating 127-run win in the third and final T20 here on Thursday.

Abhishek blew Afghanistan attack into smithereens en route to a 30-ball hundred, the fastest by an Indian, firing his team to 221 for seven after the opposition decided to field.

Afghanistan, whose batting let the team down in the first two games, once again were not able to challenge India with the bat, getting bowled out for 94 in 14.1 overs. Both teams head to the Asian Games from here.

India gave the opening over of Afghanistan's chase to all-rounder Nitish Reddy,

who conceded 15 runs before coming back to pick three wickets later in the innings. Rahmannullah Gurbaz (15 off 11) and Sediqullah Atal (1 off 3) fell to a slog sweep in the same over from Axar Patel in the powerplay.

Jasprit Bumrah bowled a crushing yorker to dismiss Darwish Rasooli while Yash Thakur accounted for Ibrahim Zadran in the sixth over, leaving Afghanistan at 47 for four. The door was as good as shut on Afghanistan.

The night well and truly belonged to Abhishek who hammered as many as 11 sixes in his 108 off 34 balls for his third hundred in T20 Internationals.

The sizzling century was also the fastest by a cricketer from a Test-playing nation against a Test-playing nation, surpassing the 33-ball effort from New



India's Abhishek Sharma reacts after his century during the third and final T20I cricket match between India and Afghanistan, in New Delhi on Thursday

Zealand's Finn Allen against South Africa earlier this year. For the fastest hundred by an Indian, he broke Rohit Sharma's record of 2017 when he achieved the feat in 35 balls.

Majority of Abhishek's thundering strikes sailed over the bowler's head.

With India already securing the series, Abhishek added the much-needed zing to a dead rubber with



India's players celebrate the wicket of Afghanistan's Sediqullah Atal during the third and final T20I cricket match between India and Afghanistan, in New Delhi on Thursday

his sensational hitting. The sixes kept coming, whether he made room to play an inside out stroke or stayed still to dispatch the bowler down the ground.

It was the first time in the

series that India batted first, allowing Abhishek to make most of his time in the middle.

Thanks to his six-hitting spree, India raced to 100 for no loss in the powerplay,

their highest in T20s in the first six overs.

Sanju Samson did not get to do much while Abhishek was going hammer and tongs in the powerplay but went on to make a fluent 50 off 35 balls, his second successive fifty plus score.

With both the openers in top form, Vaibhav Sooryavanshi will need to warm the bench for the foreseeable future.

Abhishek was unstoppable from the get go, maintaining same intensity against the fast bowlers and spinners.

Afghanistan, who have not been able to compete with India in the latter's own backyard, had their task cut out with Abhishek disdainfully slaying Azmat Omarzai and Fazalhaq Farooqi, who conceded 17 and 23 runs in the second and third over respectively.

Captain Ibrahim Zadran

tried spin early in the powerplay but that also did not work against a rampaging Abhishek. Samson got going with a couple of straight sixes off Mohammed Nabi before Abhishek too cleared the fence twice in the same over that went for 29 runs.

Samson was also dropped on 22 at mid-off by Zadran.

Abhishek's fifty came off 16 balls before he completed his memorable hundred in the ninth over. He got to 99 via a pulsating pull off Abdullah Ahmadzai and got to three figures with a rare single.

He celebrated his milestone with a seated meditation pose as the crowd duly stood on their feet after witnessing a special knock.

In the end, Afghanistan did well to restrict India to a sub 250 total. India only managed 37 runs in the last five overs with the loss of four wickets.

Zimbabwe's Mukuhani succeeds Singapore's Khwaja as new ICC deputy chairperson



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Dubai

Zimbabwe's Tavengwa Mukuhani, on Thursday, was named as the new Deputy Chairperson of ICC until November 2027 after the all powerful Board of Directors gave green-light his appointment, replacing Singapore's Imran Khwaja.

"Mukuhani, who is the Chairman of Zimbabwe Cricket and represents it on the ICC Board, succeeds Khwaja following his departure from the Board. "Mukuhani currently serves on the ICC Finance and Commercial Affairs Committee (F&CA) and the Nominations Committee, and chairs the HR and Remuneration Committee," an ICC release stated on Thursday.

The appointment comes at a significant time for African cricket, with Zimbabwe preparing to co-host the ICC Men's Cricket World Cup 2027 alongside South Africa and Namibia.

ICC chairman Jay Shah said, "I warmly congratulate Tavengwa Mukuhani on his appointment as Deputy Chair of the ICC. His experience in cricket administration, understanding of the global game and commitment to its development will be invaluable to the ICC Board.

"Tavengwa has earned the confidence of his fellow Directors, and I look forward to working closely with him to strengthen cricket across our Members and create greater opportunities for the game to grow worldwide. His election is also a significant milestone for Zimbabwe, as he becomes the first Zimbabwean to serve as Deputy Chair," Shah added. Mukuhani, on his part, said, "I look forward to working closely with our Chairman, Jay Shah, whose leadership, energy and ambition have brought a clear sense of purpose to the ICC, with a strong focus on growing cricket, creating opportunities for our Members and reaching new audiences and markets

"Cricket is entering an exciting period, particularly with its return to the Olympic Games and continued global expansion. I look forward to supporting our Chairman, Jay Shah and fellow board directors in advancing our shared priorities and serving the best interests of cricket globally," he added.



Asian Games a teaser to 2028 Los Angeles Olympics: India Women's head coach Amol Muzumdar

AJAI MASAND ■ Nagoya

(PTI) India women's head coach Amol Muzumdar on Thursday termed the Aichi-Nagoya Asian Games a "teaser" for the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics, where women's cricket will make its debut, with skipper Harmanpreet Kaur echoing the sentiment and saying the team will carry the same winning mindset into the global showpiece as it does at the Asian Games.

Defending champions India begin their campaign against hosts Japan here on Friday, with all eight teams eyeing a place in the semifinals.

Fresh from their Women's T20 Asia Cup triumph and having gone from one tournament to another, travelling from Dubai to Nagoya, India will look to maintain their momentum and clinch a second Asian Games gold.

"I think this (Asian Games) is a great teaser towards the Olympic quest for the Indian women's



team. We are getting used to certain things in the Asian Games. Just touring a different part of the cricketing world, which is Japan... never before been in this country," said Muzumdar.

"The same would probably be true for most of us in LA. So, I guess the players would have a different kind of an experience. I think it (Asian Games) is a great learning experience for everyone of us and I'm really looking forward to this Asian Games," added Muzumdar.

Harmanpreet said the team is looking forward to playing good cricket at the Asian Games and carrying those learnings into the Olympics.

"I'm sure how we enjoyed the last time

in China (2022 Hangzhou Asian Games), the same way we are going to enjoy here (in Nagoya). As a team, we are looking forward to the Olympics, and hopefully going with the same mindset and the same approach... these two tournaments (Asian Games and Olympics), especially as a cricketer, we are really looking forward to," added Harmanpreet.

She said playing at Japan and Los Angeles, which are not traditional cricket hubs, would be an interesting and valuable learning experience for the team.

"The countries like Japan and LA, we haven't seen much cricket, but as a cricketer, we are going to experience something totally different. We are not used to the conditions; we are not used to the grounds. It's a completely different feeling," she added.

Muzumdar said the players had literally lived out of their suitcases in recent weeks, travelling from Dubai for the Asia Cup to Delhi for just a night, before flying to Tokyo and then Nagoya for the Asian Games.

(PTI)



Bangladesh advance to semis without playing; Pakistan scrape past Thailand in Asian Games

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Nagoya

Bangladesh entered the semifinals without even stepping on to the field, while Pakistan had to toil hard against unfancied Thailand in a low-scoring thriller before booking their last-four spot in the Asian Games women's cricket competition here on Thursday. Bangladesh advanced on the basis of their higher international ranking after their quarterfinal match against China was abandoned due to a wet outfield. The T20 match was called off without even the toss taking place at the Karogi Sports Park in Aichi prefecture's Nishin city.

Bangladesh are currently ranked 10th in the ICC's T20 International standings, while China is way down at the 36th position.

Pakistan, on the other hand, won by three wickets after being a set a target of 92 by Thailand in a truncated match due to wet conditions.

Bangladesh will take on the winner of the quarterfinal between India and Japan, due to be played on Friday, in the semifinals scheduled for September 20. Pakistan will square off



against the winner of the Sri Lanka Malaysia clash, also on Friday.

The Harmanpreet Kaur-led India are the defending champions in the competition that features only eight teams and began from the quarterfinal stage. The Pakistan-Thailand clash also got off to a delayed start at the same venue due to the ground conditions and was eventually truncated to 11-overs-a-side. Opting to bowl after winning the toss, the unheralded Thai batters gave a good account of themselves by posting 91/4 with wicket-keeper and

number three Nannapat Koncharoenkai top-scoring with a 38-ball 49 that featured seven fours.

In reply, it was a typically erratic performance by Pakistan with wickets falling regularly.

Shawaal Zulfiqar (25) and Fatima Sana (21) were the only notable contributors as their batting collapsed despite a relatively gettable target on the board. For Thailand, off-spinners Onnichia Kamchomphu (3/37) and Sunida Chaturongrattana (2/23) did well for the side.

PCB to decide on action against Rizwan, Imam-ul-Haq after court rejects petition

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Lahore

The Pakistan Cricket Board will decide on whether to initiate any disciplinary action against senior players Muhammad Rizwan and Imam-ul-Haq after the Lahore High Court dismissed the wicket-keeper batter's petition challenging notices issued to him by the National Cyber Crime Investigation Agency (NCCIA). During Thursday's hearing, Lahore High Court Chief Justice Aalia Neelum dismissed Rizwan's petition after hearing arguments from both sides. Advocate Qazi Umair Ali, appearing for Rizwan, told court that notices had been issued to his client.

"You should go and respond to the notice. On which date was the notice issued to you?" Chief Justice Neelum remarked.

The petitioner's lawyer replied that after the Lord's Test, the petitioner was called to the hotel lobby, interrogated without a notice, and



his mobile phone was confiscated.

He further stated that the petitioner handed over the mobile phone on the assurance that it would be returned after three hours; however, the phone has not been returned to the petitioner to date, which demonstrates bad faith. Rizwan's lawyer argued that the ICC's Anti-Corruption Unit is the appropriate forum to protect cricketers from corruption, and the matter against the petitioner was not referred to the ICC Anti-Corruption Unit. Rizwan's lawyer in his petition challenged the NCCIA summons while questioning the jurisdiction of the NCCIA and the nature of the investigation.

A song, 10 men and a golden finish: Harbinder recalls India's 1966 Asiad triumph

MONA PARTHSARATHI ■ New Delhi,

Sixty years after India scripted hockey history at the 1966 Asian Games in Bangkok, Harbinder Singh still gets goosebumps when he hears the song that became the team's companion on its journey to gold.

"Whenever we went to a match, Shankar Laxman (India captain and goalkeeper at that time) would play 'Watan ki raah mein watan ke naujawan shaheed ho' in the team bus, and all the players would sing along. This would automatically motivate us," the 83-year-old three-time Olympic medalist told PTI in an exclusive interview.

"Even today, when I hear this song, I get goosebumps," he added.

It also became a galvanising force before their Asian Games final against arch foes Pakistan, a match that India won to bring home their first ever gold

at the continental showpiece.

The song and the final remain etched in the memory of the legendary centre-forward, who was also a part of India's 1964 Tokyo Olympics gold-winning team. "We had won the gold medal at the Tokyo Olympics just two years earlier, and so the excitement was high, as most of the players from the Tokyo Olympics were on this team. We were determined to win our first Asian Games gold medal," he recalled.

India achieved that goal, beating two-time champions Pakistan. The match, however, appeared to be slipping away almost from the start.

With India losing a player to injury within the first five minutes and no substitution rule in place, the team was reduced to 10 men for almost the entirety of the match.

Eventually, after 70 minutes and the first period of extra time, a wounded



Balbir Singh returned to the field to score the winner. "The match started off rough, and within the first five minutes, our right winger, Railways' Balbir Singh,

was injured by a Pakistani player's stick and had to be stretchered off," Harbinder remembered. "Pakistan's team was very strong, and the entire 70

minutes remained goal-less," he said.

Even the first half of extra time, which lasted seven-and-a-half minutes, produced no breakthrough. Then, with five minutes left in the second half of extra time, came the moment that decided the gold medal. "...Balbir was standing on the sidelines with a bandaged knee. Indian players began telling him to play on one leg. Why was he standing outside? After asking the umpire, he came on the field, and luckily, he scored the only goal of the match," said Harbinder, a Padma Shri awardee. India's squad had three players named Balbir Singh — the injured Railways winger and two others representing Punjab and the Services.

"At that time, hockey was the dominant sport, cricket wasn't as prevalent," Harbinder said, recalling how the team was welcomed with victory processions in Delhi, Amritsar and Jalandhar.

"Because hockey was an amateur sport, we couldn't receive any prizes for winning a gold medal, but victory processions were held in Delhi, Amritsar, and Jalandhar," he added.

There were no permanent national camps either, with players coming together only before major tournaments. "At that time, the camp was held in Jalandhar. The Federation bore the expenses of the camp, there was no government funding at that time. The camp was held in the heat of June, July, and August. "There were no AC coolers, and mosquitoes were rampant. It was quite tough, but the diet was excellent, authentic Punjabi food," he added.

Harbinder, who also won gold medals in the junior and senior 100m and 200m athletics events, feels modern hockey is faster but has lost some of the artistry that once made the sport a major spectator attraction.